

ITIS 6300 HCD

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Final Project Description: University's Admission & Financial Aid Website Redesign Report

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Introduction:

This project is all about redesigning the university's Admission & Financial Aid website and thinking of ways through which it can be improved. The aim will be to develop a website that genuinely supports the journeys of prospective students, parents, and other visitors by making the navigation clear, engaging, and very easy to use. With that, we started doing a thorough design critique to understand what works and doesn't work. We reflected on aspects that pertained to visual design, interaction design, and usability. Hence, we were able to highlight those areas that needed enhancement, be it by providing more continuity, being more accessible, or easier to navigate.

That was not all. For each of the problems that we found, we looked for solutions that would be thoughtful concerning the branding of the university and yet meet actual user needs. With this as our background, we created high-fidelity prototypes showing our design enhancements. These are steps in this journey of discovery, decisions taken, and a vision of a website serving its users better. In the following sections, this report will walk you through each one of them. The obvious purpose of this design journey is to make the website a useful resource for everybody who visits it.

Chapter 1: Design Critique Learnings:

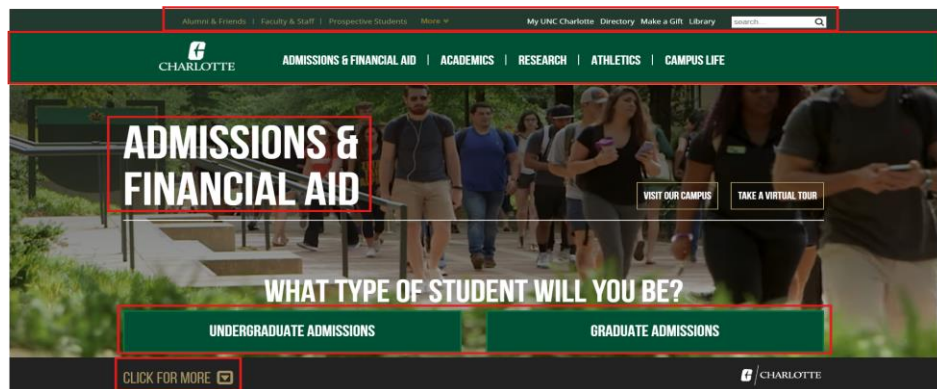
In reviewing the UNC Charlotte Admissions & Financial Aid Website, we had an opportunity to address issues such as visual design, interaction design, and usability heuristics. We were able to identify a number of strengths and weaknesses under all of these, which may perhaps drive enhancement in a way to improve user experience. The following sections outline our findings, categorized by topic, and comment on positives and negatives, as well as any recommendations for improvements.

***Note:** Some of the points and images in this report may appear repetitive. This is deliberate, as some of the features that involve visuals and interaction have broad implications for the design of the website. Such repetitions are necessary to have a full critique and emphasize the importance of the review in areas such as visual consistency, usability, and other aspects that involve the user experience. I appreciate your patience in this as we go through the review comprehensively.*

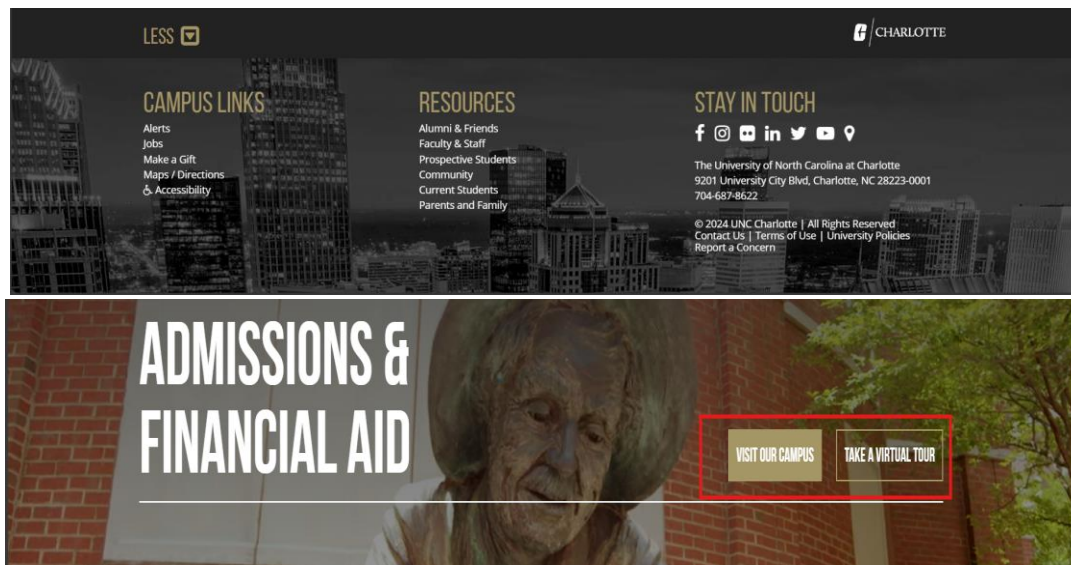
1. Visual Design Critique

a. Color Choices:

- i. **Positive:** Perhaps the most appealing feature of the website's graphic design is the use of green and gold. The University does quite well in reflecting its brand image. A signature color scheme like this gives a school its identity and allows for consistency throughout the site. For instance, the navigation has white text against a green background that is likely to provide enough contrast to keep items readable.



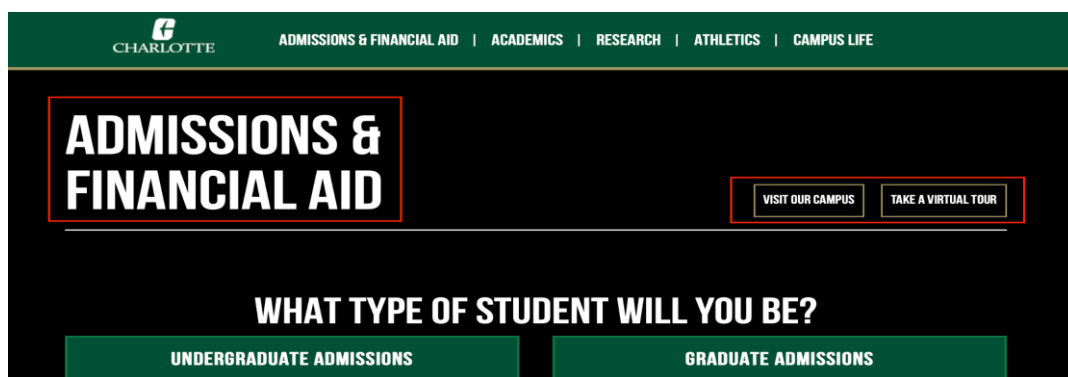
- ii. **Negative:** Where there is still room for further refinement of color contrast, such as in the footer, white text on a gray background does not contrast as well. Others include some buttons like "Visit Our Campus" that do not have very apparent visual cues-like clear hover effects make them more salient and interesting.



- iii. **Recommendation:** Increase the contrasts to a readable level, as in the footer area, and harmonize consistent hover effects on all buttons in place to make it more readable and usable. Making such changes would improve not only accessibility but also interactivity and an engaging interface with end-users.

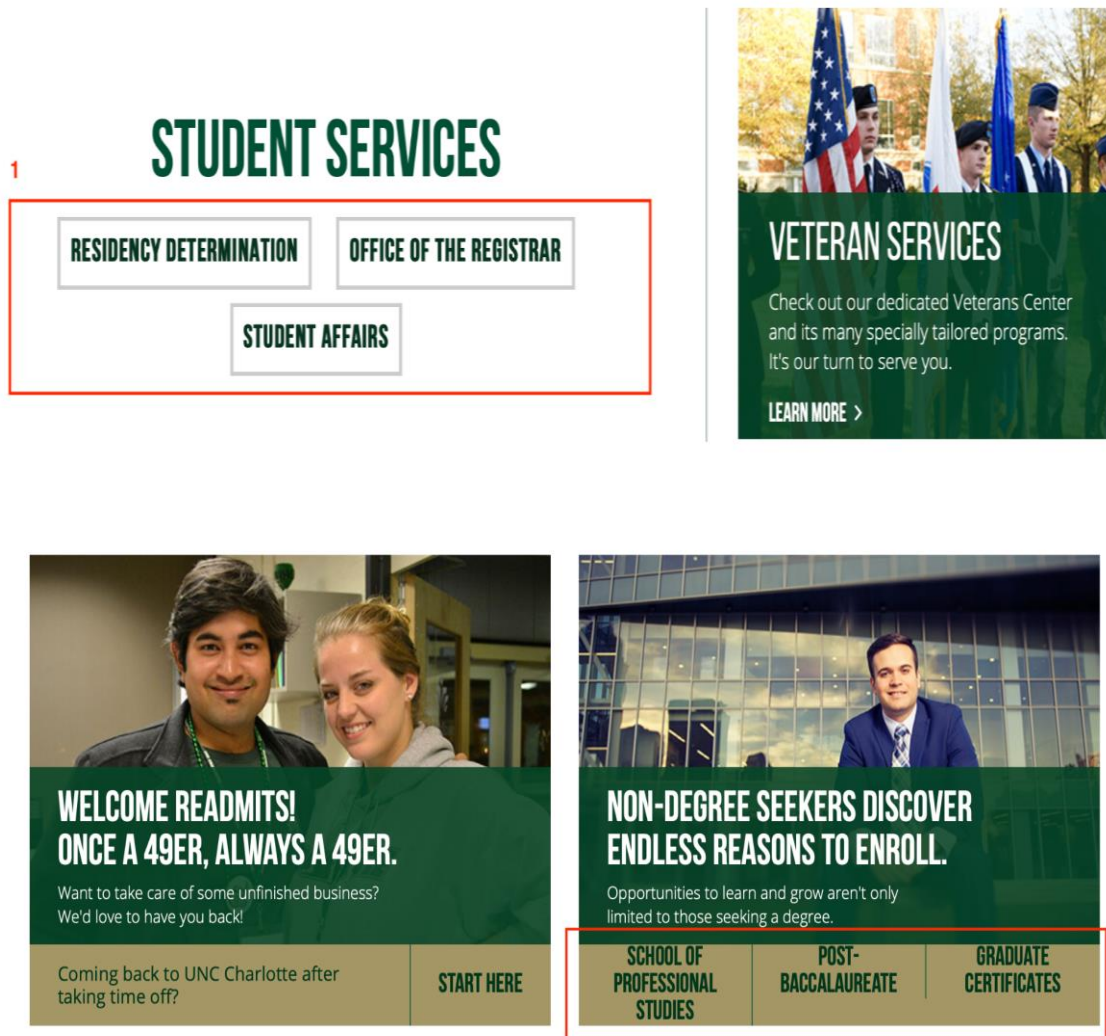
b. Grid or Layout Structure:

- i. **Positive:** The grid of the website is highly structured for the most part. For example, there is a clearly defined structure in both the navigation bar and the main content areas that contribute to a professional look without making users feel overwhelmed. The consistent spacing and alignment make the navigation area intuitive.



- ii. **Negative:** The site, though, seems inconsistent with the grid, where it breaks up the general flow of the site. For example, the way in which the section on student services showcases its content is varied, sometimes feeling fractured. In the "Non-Degree Seekers" section, there is a off-

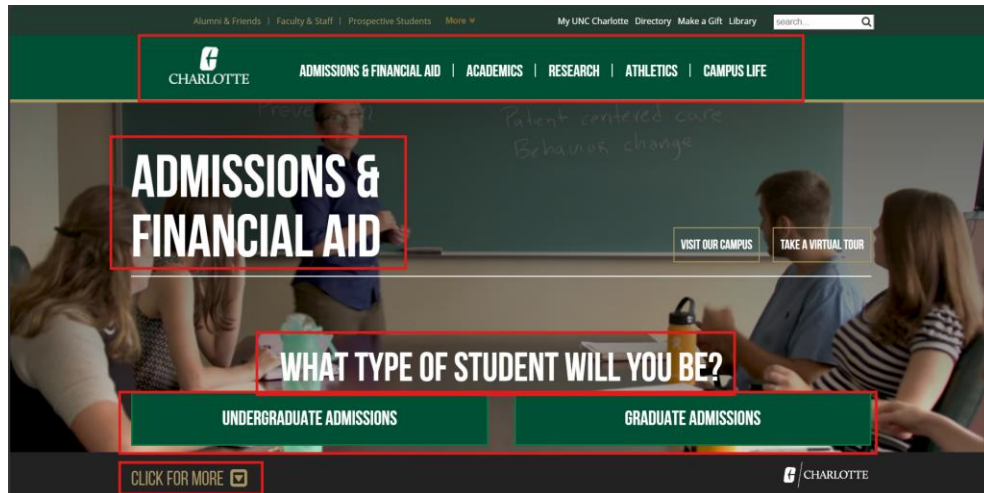
centered text alignment, making the layout not look as good as it may be for a user.



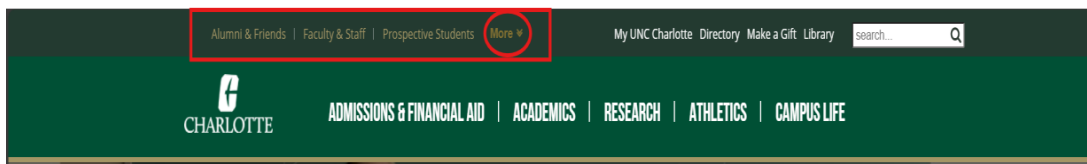
- iii. **Recommendation:** All divisions should be done on a grid pattern to reduce inconsistency in order to beautify the layout. This would include divisions where proper alignment of all the buttons and cards within the grid is necessary, so as to make navigation easier on the website and bring about a more uniform look and feel of the entire website.

c. Typeface and Typography:

- i. **Positive:** Overall, the typography in this website helps to make clarity and brand recognition. The heading structure presents clarity with continuity of font sizes throughout guiding the user through the content. For example, the name of the university is highly visible and this typography is conducive and supports the branding effort of this website.



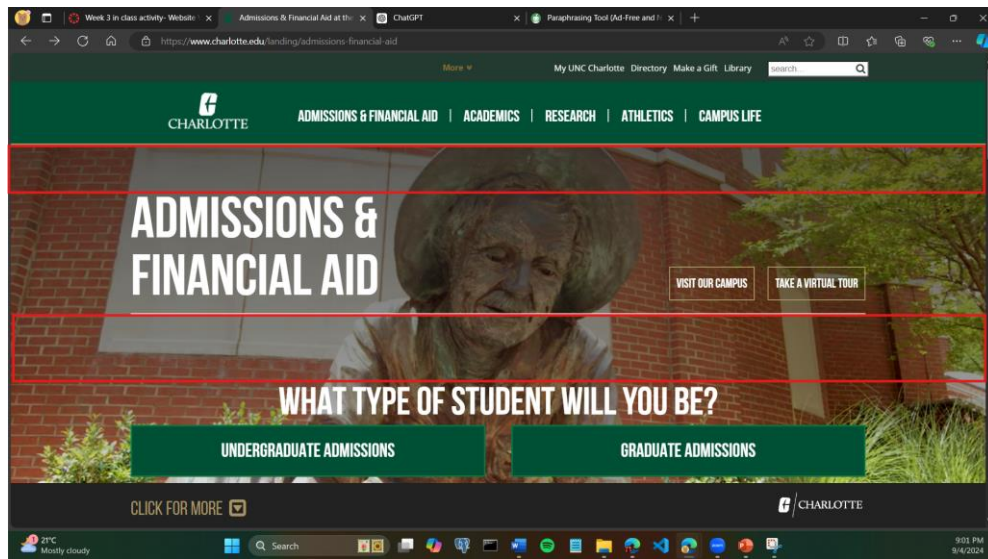
- ii. **Negative:** There are a few font inconsistencies, such as on smaller screens, which further reduce readability. For example, the font weight in the "More" button is different from the rest of the buttons on the top navigation bar and hence looks a little out of place, further reducing the consistency in typography of this site.



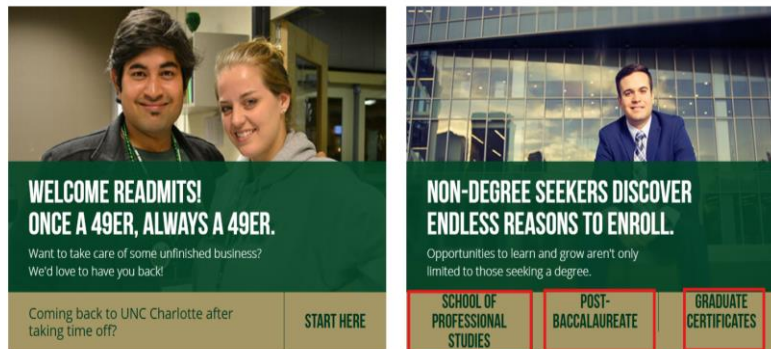
- iii. **Recommendation:** The website would be better not to change the font style and size in different sections, as it would be more readable on a larger variety of devices. More modifications in responsiveness would further improve readability on small-screen devices and bring ease of using whatever device they prefer.

d. Use of Whitespace:

- i. **Positive:** In some parts of the website, for example, the homepage, there is an effective use of whitespace to point toward some navigation links and buttons for calls to action. That said, this effective use of space makes the layout clean, balanced, and invitingly easy-going.



- ii. **Negative:** There are sections, such as "Non-Degree Seekers," that have too much white space, which forces unnecessary scrolling and disrupts information flow. Too much open space may make users lose focus or become frustrated trying to get through the page.



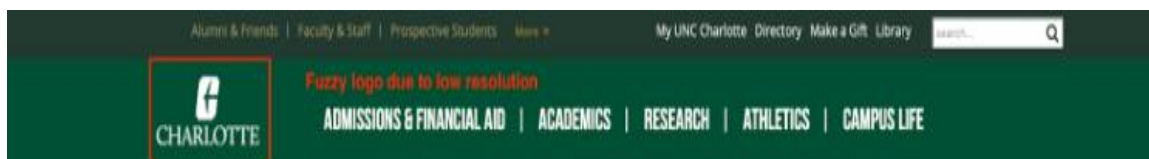
- iii. **Recommendation:** It would be more user-friendly with respect to information processing to reduce whitespace in those kinds of areas without affecting the cleanliness of the site.

e. Images and Visuals Used:

- i. **Positive:** The overall use of images on the site is quite effective in creating a rapport with the potential student. The contextual images, like campus photos and visuals of veteran services, make it personal to make the university's community come alive. Such pictures make the potential users imagine themselves in a campus setting.



- ii. **Negative:** The resolution of some images on the website, like the UNC Charlotte logo, is quite low and pixelated, which diminishes some of the aspects of professionalism on the website. Misaligned images further break the flow of the design, thus leaving a feeling of inconsistency in the layout.

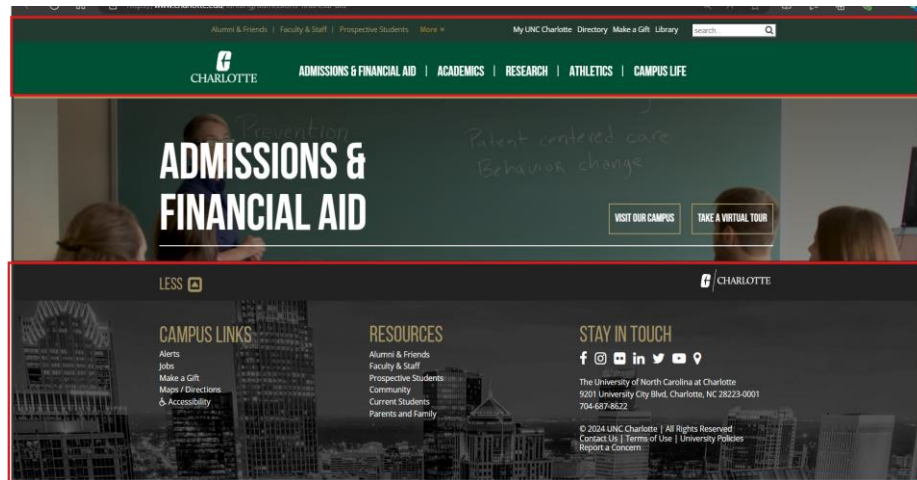


- iii. **Recommendation:** Ensuring all images are high resolution and more so perfectly aligned will go a long way in adding professionalism to the website. University branding would be stronger with consistent quality visuals throughout all the pages, and it would finally create a more polished user experience.

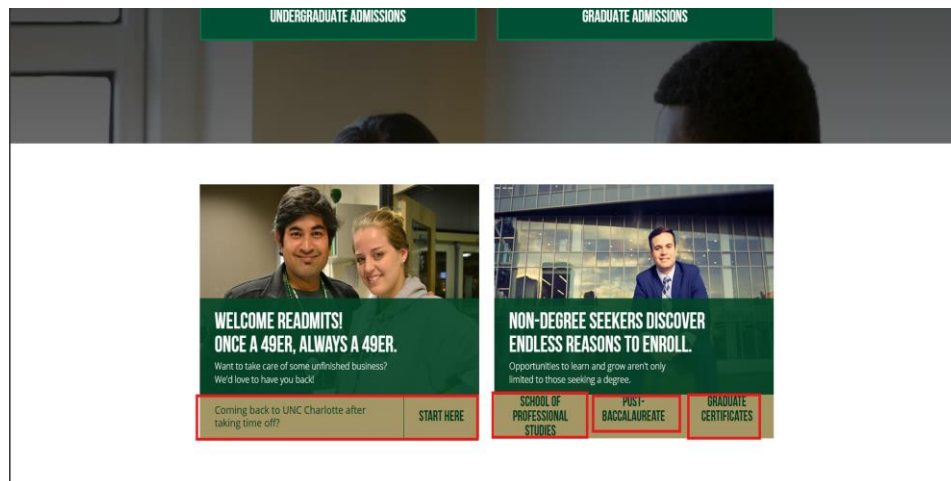
2. Interaction Design Critique

a. Consistency:

- i. **Positive:** The website has a lot of consistency in many major keys, such as the green and gold colors used, really helping to enforce the brand and make it cohesive. The top navigation bar/header does indeed appear consistent across all the pages, which may help a user feel oriented when moving through the site.



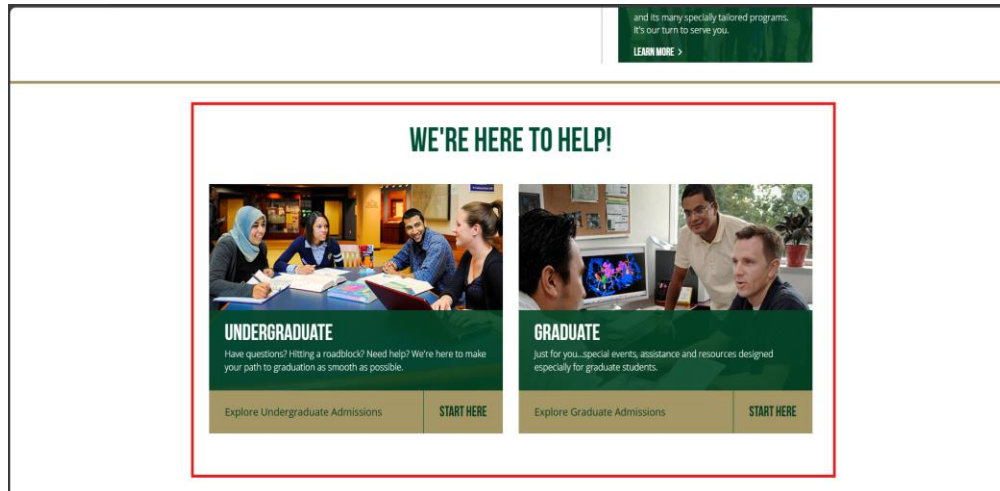
- ii. **Negative:** The only shortcoming is that there is a lack of consistency in button styles and footer layouts that takes away from such cohesion. Buttons are shaped differently or have different font sizes on one page as compared to another, and the design of the footer changes from one sector to the next. This can cause a break in the flow of the user and discontinuity within the site.



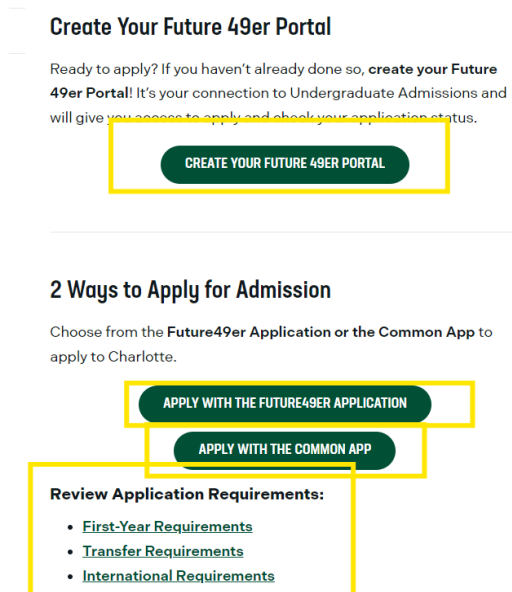
- iii. **Recommendation:** Similarly, the shape of the buttons should be consistent, as well as the footer design and all other visual aspects throughout the site. This would ensure that a visitor has a seamless experience because consistency and professionalism would be instituted.

b. Minimalism:

- i. **Positive:** The use of the minimalist design approach on the home page makes users instinctively focus their attention on important features while keeping everything simple and accessible. It allows users to focus on main calls-to-action with no distractions.



- ii. **Negative:** Other parts of the website are not following this minimalist approach since they carry more information than is actually needed. Extra content can make the layout a bit crowded and take away usability because then a user may not easily know what's important.

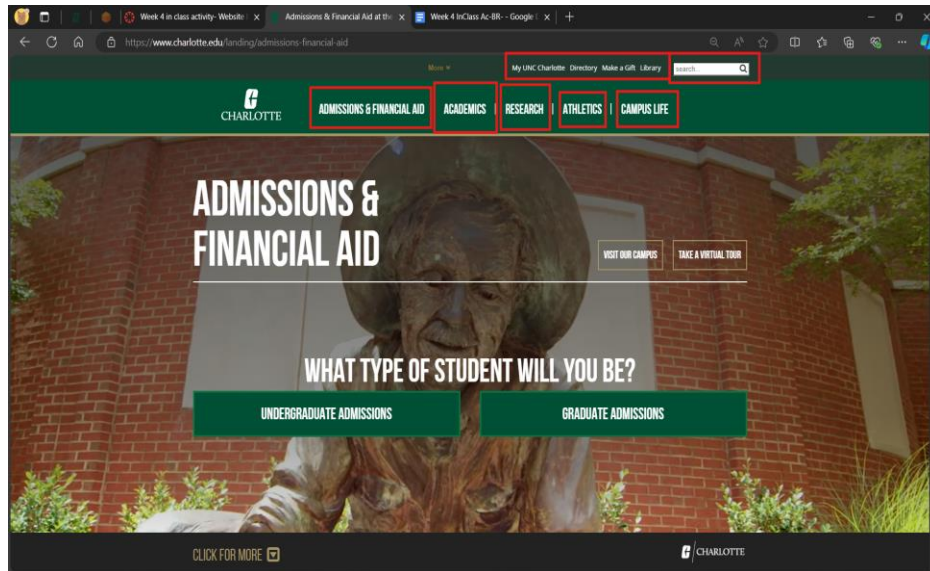


- iii. **Recommendation:** We would like to see the website go further in its minimalism to cut content down to only what is most necessary for satisfying a user's appetites. This would help lend greater clarity to the design and help other pages be consistent.

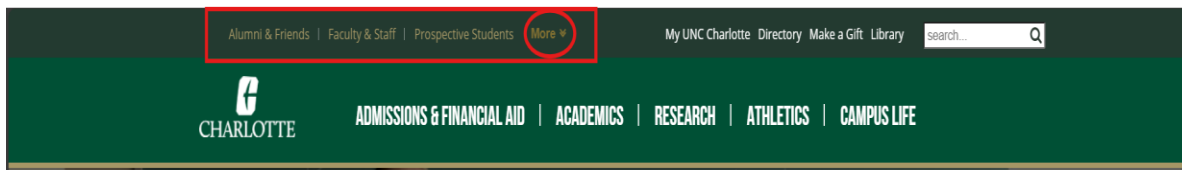
c. **Discoverability:**

- i. **Positive:** The website has put its most necessary features, including the search bar and links to social media, most prominently on the homepage.

The footer also contains useful contact information about the university that might help a user stay in touch with the institution.



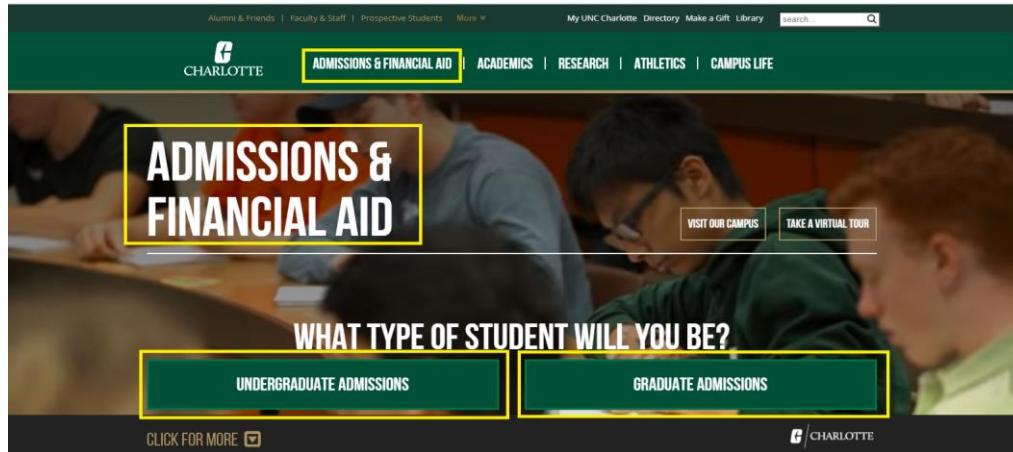
- ii. **Negative:** Critical links, such as "Faculty and Staff" and "Prospective Students," are still buried deep in drop-down menus, which can make it very difficult to find them with ease.



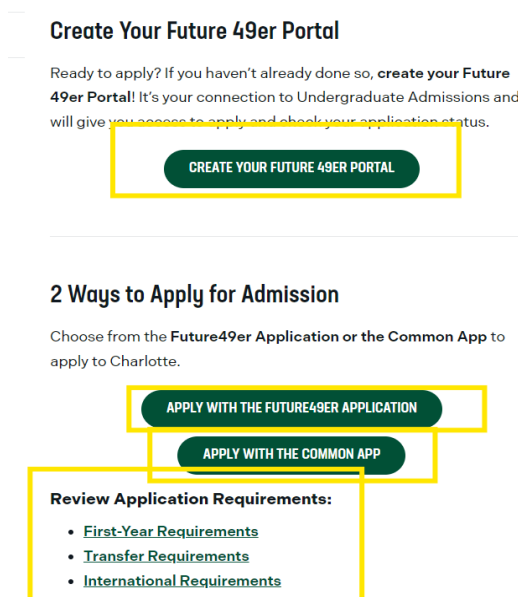
- iii. **Recommendation:** Move the important links to more prominent locations on the navigation bar for better discoverability, which will help the user find key information without much hassle.

d. Learnability:

- i. **Positive:** Familiar navigation elements like the clickable university logo and clear headings make the site easy to use. Such familiar design decisions enhance learnability, users understand faster the structure and navigation of the site.



- ii. **Negative:** Some pages are so information-loaded, for instance, the Financial Aid page, that it would be quite overwhelming for a new user to even know where to begin or what the next steps might be.

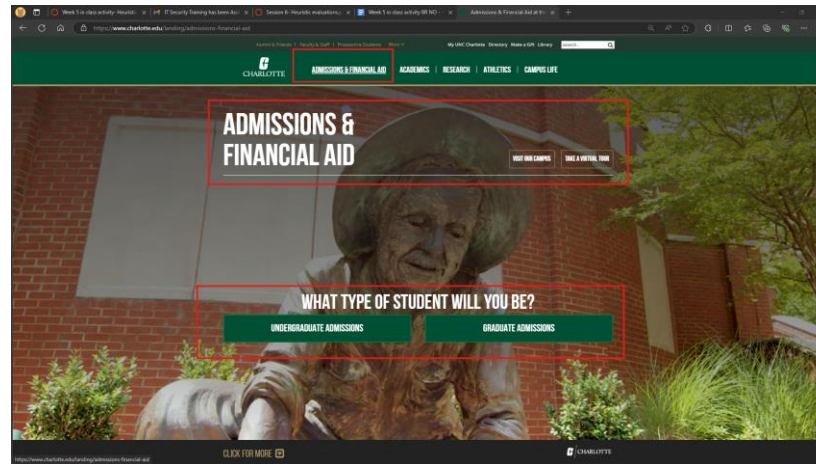


- iii. **Recommendation:** A simpler interface and guided onboarding would onboard users more effectively. This would add to usability in that users would become familiar over time with characteristics and content that are important.

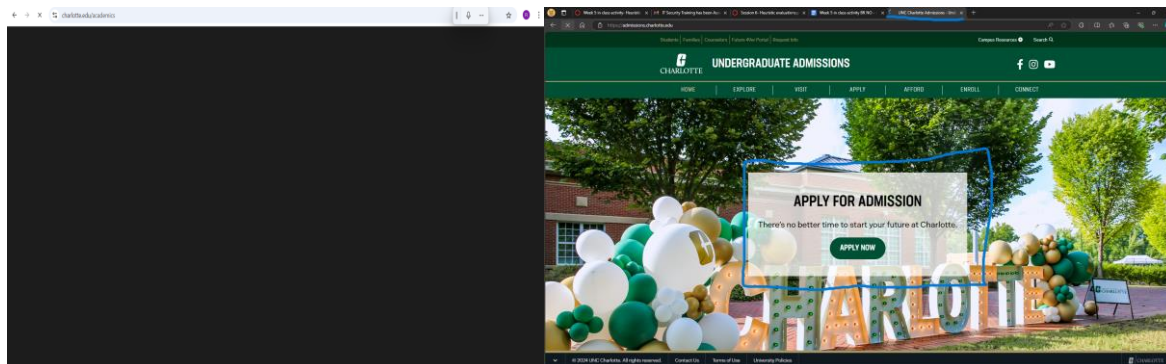
3. Heuristic Evaluation

a. Visibility of System Status:

- i. **Positive:** The website incorporates effective hover effects on navigation buttons, which give users immediate feedback about interactive elements, thus allowing them to perceive what actions are possible to them.



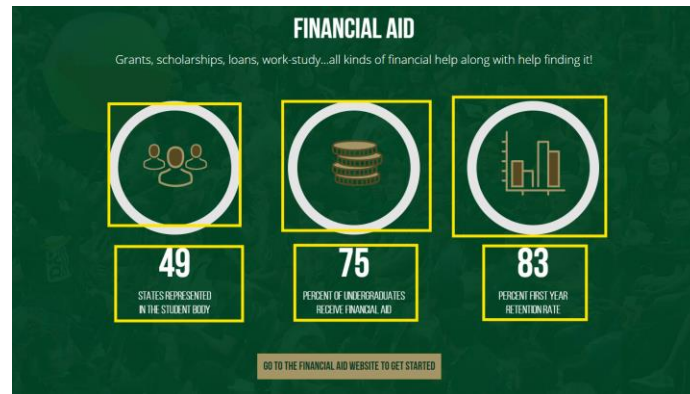
- ii. **Negative:** There is no loading indicator in the event of moving from one page to another, and at times, it even freezes the user with a blank page. A lack of visual feedback can get the user puzzled as well as suffer from network delays.



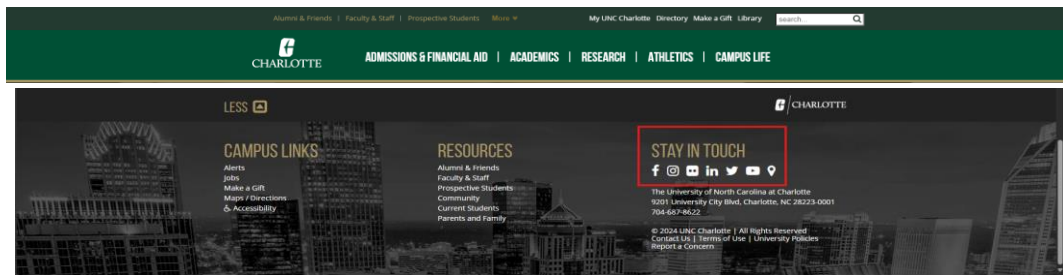
- iii. **Recommendation:** Include loading icons or progress bars during page transitions to let the user know what the system is doing and keep them grounded regarding where they are, so they don't get frustrated.

b. Match Between System and the Real World:

- i. **Positive:** The website does a great job of using icons - for instance, using icons for things like financial aid and student body; it allows users to grasp immediately under what context the content is given. These real-world symbols make the site more intuitive.



- ii. **Negative:** The issue is that all of the links do not have icons, this will make some of the options unappealing and hard to locate in an instance.



- iii. **Recommendation:** Easy-to-understand icons for each main navigation link would create better usability and allow increased usage throughout the site.

c. Error Prevention:

- i. **Positive:** The website is good with error prevention of some kinds; the dates not available in the campus tour calendar are grayed out to prevent user errors when scheduling.

On-Campus Tour: First-Year

On-Campus tours include an admissions presentation, a guided walking tour of campus, and a guided residence hall tour.

September 2024						
Su	Mo	Tu	We	Th	Fr	Sa
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
8	9	10	11	12	13	14
15	16	17	18	19	20	21
22	23	24	25	26	27	28
29	30					

Legend:

- Seats available
- No seats available
- No scheduled events

- ii. **Negative:** This includes form completions and selecting of options, where error prevention features are lacking in some areas, and users are bound to make avoidable mistakes.



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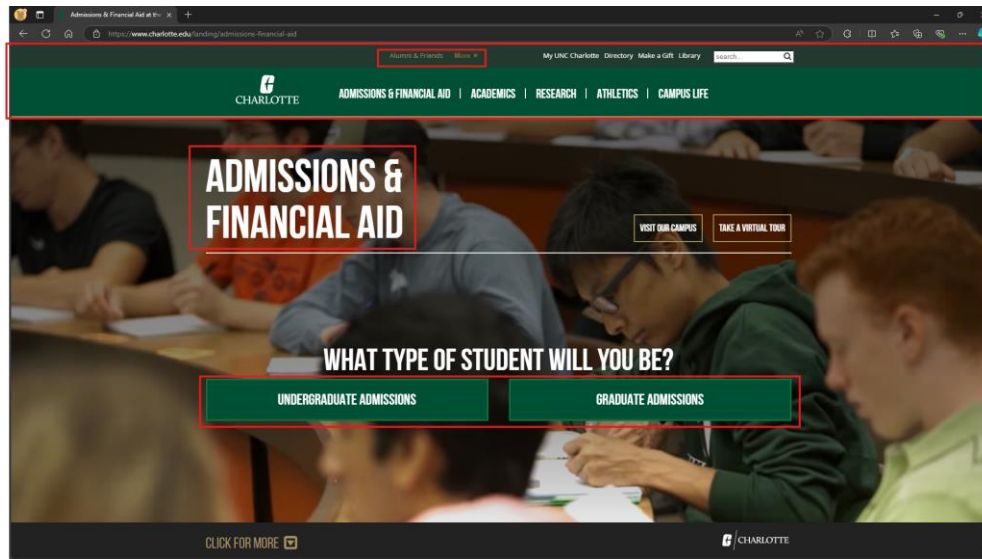




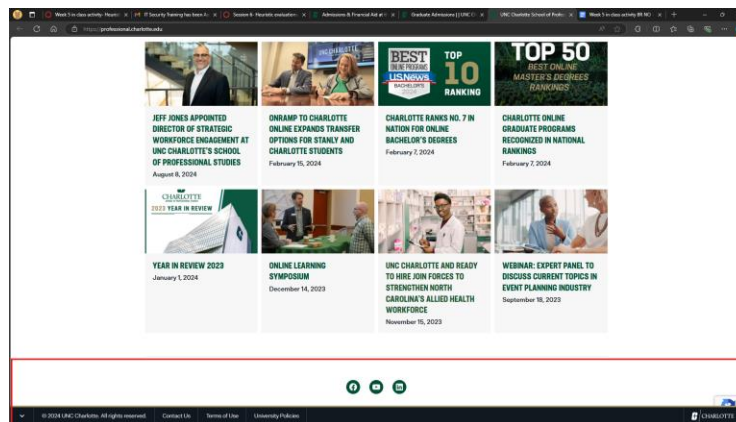
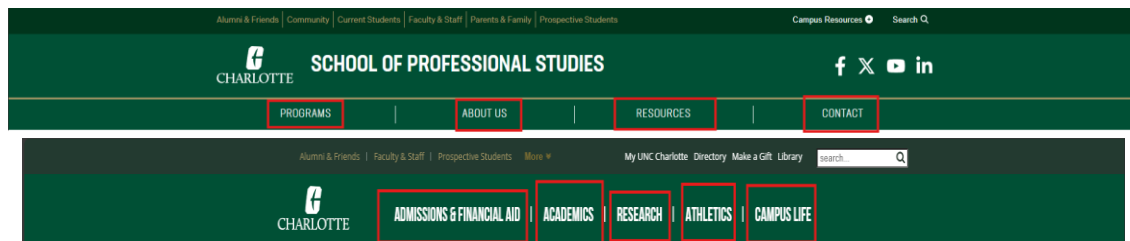
- iii. **Recommendation:** A more holistic strategy of error prevention, such as input validations, needs to be in place. This would, in turn, reduce user frustrations and increase the through rate of task completions on the site.

d. Consistency and Standards:

- i. **Positive:** There is consistency in the use of UNCC's brand colors across the site, and a generally consistent background helps to support consistent look and feel across the website.



- ii. **Negative:** Font styles and footers are different from page to page, which makes them all inconsistent, and, therefore, the site has an amateur look.

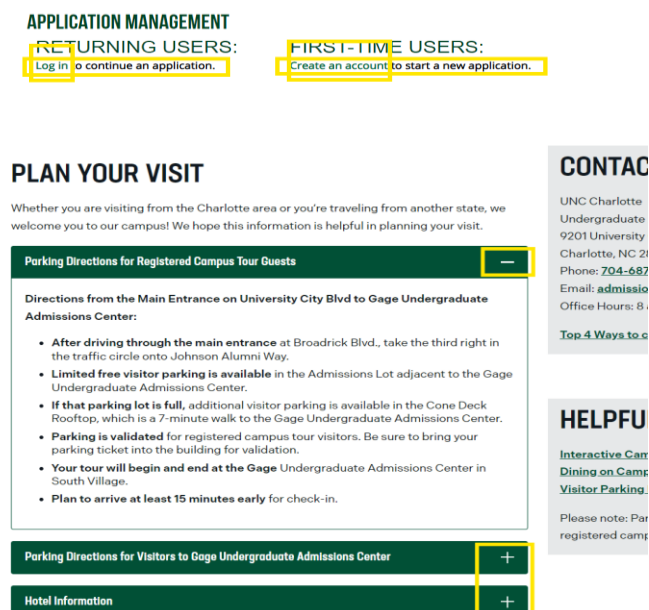


- iii. **Recommendation:** Consistency in font, footer, and alignments throughout would make navigation easier for clients and be more coherent.

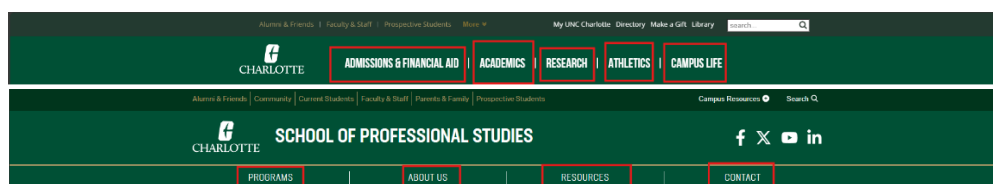
e. **Recognition Rather Than Recall:**

- i. **Positive:** Familiar icons, for example, the "+" symbol for expandable sections of this website, can enable the users to understand what it is used for rather than necessarily remembering what to do with it. Such an

approach relieves the cognitive load for the users of this website and keeps the amount of effort needed for finding what they are looking for at a minimum.



- ii. **Negative:** Some buttons and links are purely text without icons or indicators showing what they do. For example, some of the links for navigation don't have clear icons pointing out their function, which makes it hard to remember where they are or what parts of the website contain.

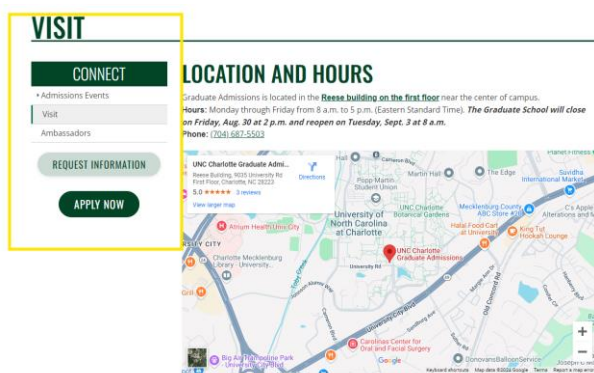
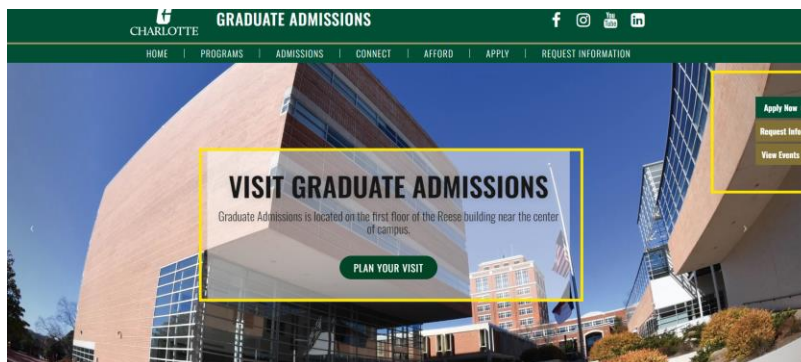


- iii. **Recommendation:** Adding icons or other visual indicators beside important links to navigate and buttons would enhance recognition. Commonly used icons for particular functions, such as using a magnifying glass for search or a question mark for help, will help users recognize functions quicker by not having to remember specific details of the interface.

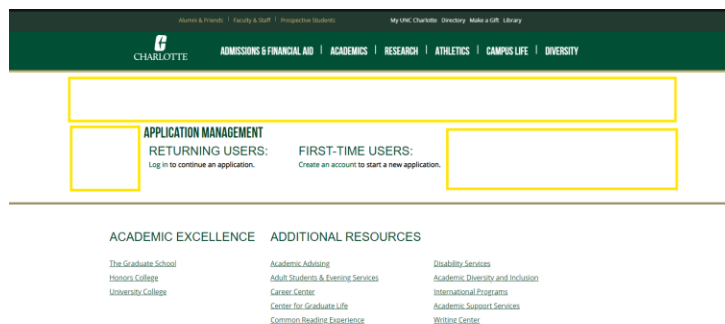
f. Flexibility and Efficiency of Use:

- i. **Positive:** The website layout for navigation isn't very complicated but serves to assist new and returning users in finding what they need. Early on, the user can select their type of student-undergraduate or graduate-

which makes access to information easier to get through. In making this journey simpler, it becomes a far more relevant experience for them.



- ii. **Negative:** For expert users who wish to access information quickly, there is limited flexibility. The absence of shortcuts, such as immediate links to frequently used pages or a customizable dashboard, may make them slower than they need to be.



- iii. **Recommendation:** Features such as having a "Quick Links" section for pages the user frequently visits or options to save pages as favorites would provide some degree of flexibility to the expert user. This would save time

when users return to the site and try not to backtrack too many steps each time.

g. Aesthetic and Minimalist Design:

- i. **Positive:** This minimalistic approach on the home page ensures that it does not overload the user by placing too much emphasis on features. It has this positive effect of making users focus on stuff that really matters, such as vital information like admissions and financial aid.



- ii. **Negative:** Too much information, sometimes even clutter, is observed on some sections, specifically in deeper pages. Certain types of pages seem to show up unnecessarily full and visually cluttered-the ones with several options and/or categories-which really conflicted with the minimalistic design and might be confusing to users.

Create Your Future 49er Portal

Ready to apply? If you haven't already done so, **create your Future 49er Portal**! It's your connection to Undergraduate Admissions and will give you access to apply and check your application status.

CREATE YOUR FUTURE 49ER PORTAL

2 Ways to Apply for Admission

Choose from the **Future49er Application** or the **Common App** to apply to Charlotte.

APPLY WITH THE FUTURE49ER APPLICATION

APPLY WITH THE COMMON APP

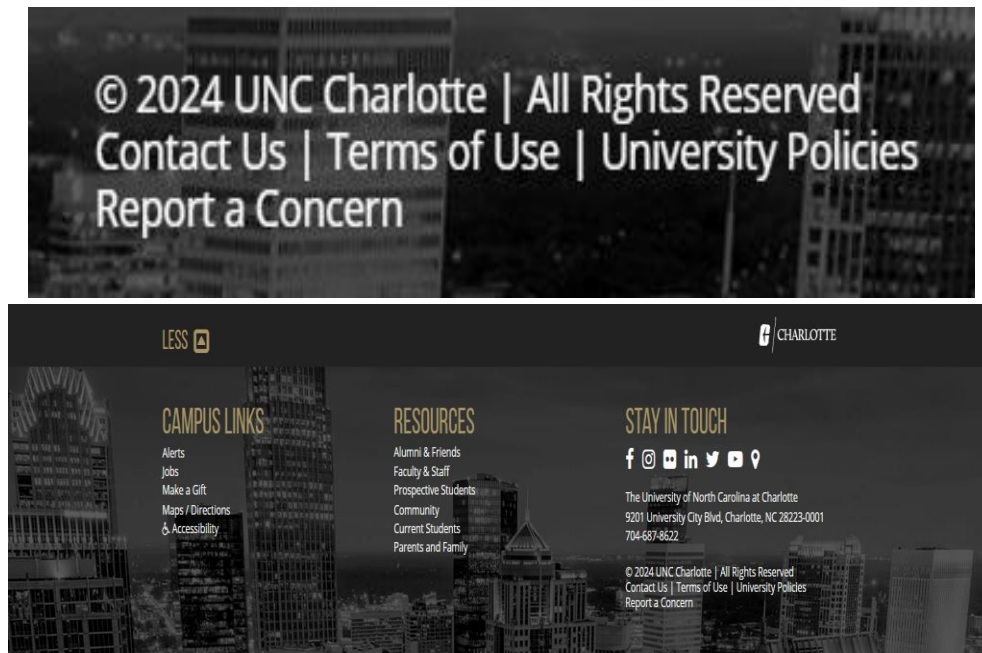
Review Application Requirements:

- [First-Year Requirements](#)
- [Transfer Requirements](#)
- [International Requirements](#)

- iii. **Recommendation:** Too much information, sometimes even clutter, is observed on some sections, specifically in deeper pages. Certain types of pages seem to show up unnecessarily full and visually cluttered-the ones with several options and/or categories-which really conflicted with the minimalistic design and might be confusing to users.

h. Help and Documentation:

- i. **Positive:** The website has helpful links at the bottom of the page to help users who would want to seek further information such as contact and FAQs. The presence of this support guarantees that users can eliminate queries on their own without necessarily having to go out of the site.



- ii. **Negative:** Even with the footer links, there is no help button consolidated or any readily available documentation for users in case complex sections, like the admissions process, need to be explained. The new user may find it difficult to find their way around seeking assistance in case of any confusion or error.
- iii. **Recommendation:** A clear "Help" icon or partial inclusion of a chatbot might allow better access to support facilities. The possibility of a pop-up or side bar at the bottom right corner showing rapid options for quick help could prevent users from going outside the flow.

This critique takes on the review of the current web design for UNC Charlotte Admissions & Financial Aid and what would enable it to be a better serving tool for its users. Currently, the website does note the branding of the university while offering resources, but our assessment did define certain places where the website might be more seamless, accessible, and engaging. Color contrast, consistency, and ease of navigation will go a long way in making the experience seamless and inclusive for all visitors, setting the foundation to walk up to the next steps in our redesign journey.

Chapter 2: Main Personas and Interviews:

1. Persona Introduction: The following are three major personas identified to serve in guiding the design process in this university's redesign of its Admissions and Financial Aid website:

a. Persona 1: Prospective Undergraduate Transfer Student

Persona: Ritu is a 20-year-old community college student who will be transferring into a four-year major in data science. She's very eager to see how her credits transfer and is looking for clear information about what financial aid is provided to transfer students. This website has continually frustrated her, as it feels cluttered and important resources are deeply buried in multiple menus.



Prospective Undergraduate Transfer Student Persona

- **Name:** Ritu Sharma
- **Occupation:** Community College Student
- **Age:** 20
- **Gender:** Female

Backstory:

Ritu is currently studying at a community college and plans to transfer to a four-year university. She dreams of pursuing a degree in business administration and is excited about the opportunities a larger university can provide. However, she's anxious about the transfer process, especially around understanding how her credits will transfer and what financial aid options are available for transfer students. Ritu wants a clear, seamless path to help her transition smoothly.

Motivations:

Ritu is motivated by her ambition to earn a bachelor's degree and explore new career opportunities. She's eager to find a university that values her academic journey so far and supports her transfer smoothly. Financial aid is crucial for her, as she hopes to manage her education costs effectively.

Frustrations:

She feels overwhelmed by the lack of clear guidance on credit transfers and financial aid eligibility for transfer students. Searching through various sections of the admissions website has been challenging, and she feels there should be a more straightforward way to find relevant resources.

Ideal Experience/Goals/Aspiration:

Ritu hopes for a website that can guide her through the transfer process with ease, helping her understand her eligibility for credit transfers and available financial aid. Ideally, she'd like a dedicated section that addresses transfer student needs, with eligibility checkers and an FAQ section tailored to her journey.

"Transferring should feel like a step forward, not an obstacle course. I just need clear answers and a supportive path to my goals."

b. Persona 2: International Transfer Student Persona: Mihir is an international student, 26 years old, majoring in master's in computer science, and he has difficulties managing all visa-related documentation, credit transfers from international institutions, and searching for scholarships for non-US citizens. He needs a platform that will make this process less painful and laborious while providing quite specific, actionable resources relevant to his situation.



International Transfer Student Persona

- **Name:** Mihir Patel
- **Occupation:** International Student
- **Age:** 26
- **Gender:** Male

Backstory:

Mihir is an international student studying in the U.S. on a student visa. He's currently completing his associate degree and wishes to transfer to a university for a computer science program. Navigating the complexities of visa requirements, credit transfers, and financial aid for international students has been challenging. He feels that resources tailored to international transfer students are often lacking.

Motivations:

Mihir is driven by his passion for technology and his goal of securing a degree from a reputed U.S. university. He hopes to find a website that simplifies the process of understanding his eligibility, both in terms of visa and credit transfer requirements, without constant back-and-forth communication.

Frustrations:

Mihir finds it frustrating that information relevant to international students is often buried in general admissions pages. He wishes for a more personalized approach that considers the unique challenges international students face, particularly around visa-related information and financial aid options.

Ideal Experience/Goals/Aspiration:

Mihir wants an admissions website that offers specific, easy-to-find resources for international students. He envisions tools like eligibility checkers for financial aid and detailed guidelines on maintaining visa status during the transfer process.

"As an international student, clarity is everything. I need a website that speaks to my journey and makes it easier to focus on my studies and dreams."

- c. Persona 3: Alumni Transfer Student Persona:** Shruti is an alumna in her mid-20s who comes back to university for a second degree in mechanical engineering. She searches for information such as how many credits she can reuse and where to find financial aid specifically for alumni. Often, she leaves the website frustrated as it does not have specific resources that cater to returning students.



Alumni Transfer Student Persona

- **Name:** Shruti Desai
- **Occupation:** Graduate Student Aspiring Second Graduate Degree
- **Age:** 25
- **Gender:** Female

Backstory:

Shruti graduated a few years ago with a bachelor's degree in psychology. She has been working part-time while considering returning to school to pursue a master's degree. She's interested in exploring options for alumni who want to transfer back to their alma mater for further studies, specifically focusing on available financial aid and alumni resources.

Motivations:

Shruti is motivated by her desire to continue her education and grow in her career. She values her connection to her alma mater and hopes to find a supportive environment as she considers a return. Financial aid options and alumni-specific resources are top priorities.

Frustrations:

She often feels that alumni seeking further education are overlooked, and she struggles to find information on financial aid or resources specifically for alumni. Navigating the admissions website is time-consuming, with no clear pathways for returning students.

Ideal Experience/Goals/Aspiration:

Shruti wants a section on the admissions website dedicated to alumni who wish to return for advanced degrees. She would like to see financial aid information for alumni and resources that outline a simplified process for re-enrollment.

"Coming back to school should feel like coming home. It would be great to see support for alumni looking to continue their education."

2. Interview Process Description:

a. Main Persona Description:

- i. I will select the Prospective Student Persona based on this interview. It would comprise young people aged between 18 and 28 years who will access the university website for various purposes, which include seeking clear information about the programs and processes of application and financial aid that they may receive during their course. With this category, I can get feedback which could be helpful in the development of the website in such a way that it will be more user-friendly, and relevant to the future needs of students.
- ii. The selected primary persona for the redesign is Ritu Sharma, who represents potential undergraduate transfer students. This demographic directly impacts the admission policies of the institution, hence, their user experience is the most relevant to university goals.

b. Recruitment Methods:

- i. Participants were recruited through social media, university forums, and events such as International Coffee Hours. These people were found using LinkedIn and Reddit by looking for personas that matched the personas described. Great care was taken to find a diverse pool of participants that would match the needs presented by the personas. For Example:
 1. **Ritu Sharma:** I met on a social media platform in a group on Reddit targeting community college students looking to transfer to UNC Charlotte.
 2. **Mihir Patel:** I met him at International Coffee Hours and later connected through LinkedIn as he is currently pursuing his Master at UNC Charlotte.
 3. **Shruti Desai:** I contacted her through the alumni network on LinkedIn as she is pursuing her second degree at UNC Charlotte.

c. Interview Format:

- i. I had conducted a semi-structured interview here. This keeps some formalities in this kind of interview type and organization while one can go ahead with directed questions or converse freely. These have really helped in uncovering new insights that we might have never expected. These all give an improved understanding of the areas where the users use the university website, mainly the UNC Charlotte Admission & Financial Aid website.

d. Informed Consent:

- i. As these sessions were recorded both on-screen and in audio forms, it was explained very well to the participant right at the beginning of the testing session what this session was going to be like, its purpose, and recording. They were also informed that any responses provided would be treated as strictly confidential and used only for research purposes, so they may feel freer during the session and give more frank responses. At this point, informed consent was verbally obtained from participants in order to be sure they understood and agreed to proceed.

e. Recording Process and Interview Duration:

- i. Sessions were audio recorded in mp3 file format. As a matter of fact, this approach was quite useful in documenting what all the participants did while performing the assigned tasks for further analysis.
- ii. Each session was approximately 10-20 minutes in length. For convenience, the sessions were conducted on Zoom and a backup recording was done in OBS Studio and also took some notes in the Notepad app. Participants were informed about the purpose of these sessions and that they were going to be recorded. Informed verbal consent was obtained.

f. Questions Asked:

- i. The questions were related to the determination of problems while navigation, anything important on the website, and suggestions for improvement. In the later half, some questions were replaced; added were follow-up and some reflection questions, which will be elaborated on in Chapter 4 but focusing on the current chapter; here are some questions included below, which are as follows:
 1. Let's start by talking a little about your background. Can you tell me why you're interested in pursuing a master's in computer science at UNC Charlotte?
 2. When you were first researching the program, did you access UNC Charlotte's Admissions and Financial Aid website? What kind of information were you looking for?
 3. What was your overall first impression of the website? Was it easy to navigate?
 4. Did you encounter any specific problems when accessing the website?
 5. What's the usual way you try to get information about universities? Do you rely on their websites, or do you use other sources?
 6. Is there something that you feel the website could do better, especially regarding financial aid?

7. Was there any section or feature that you found useful? Why?
8. Were there any parts of the website that you found confusing or hard to navigate?
9. If you could change one thing about this website, what would that be, and why?
10. You mentioned searching for specific information using Google. Why do you use Google to search for information on financial aid instead of going directly to the university's website?
11. What would make you more interested in seeking the information regarding financial aid on the university website instead of Google?

3. Persona Development:

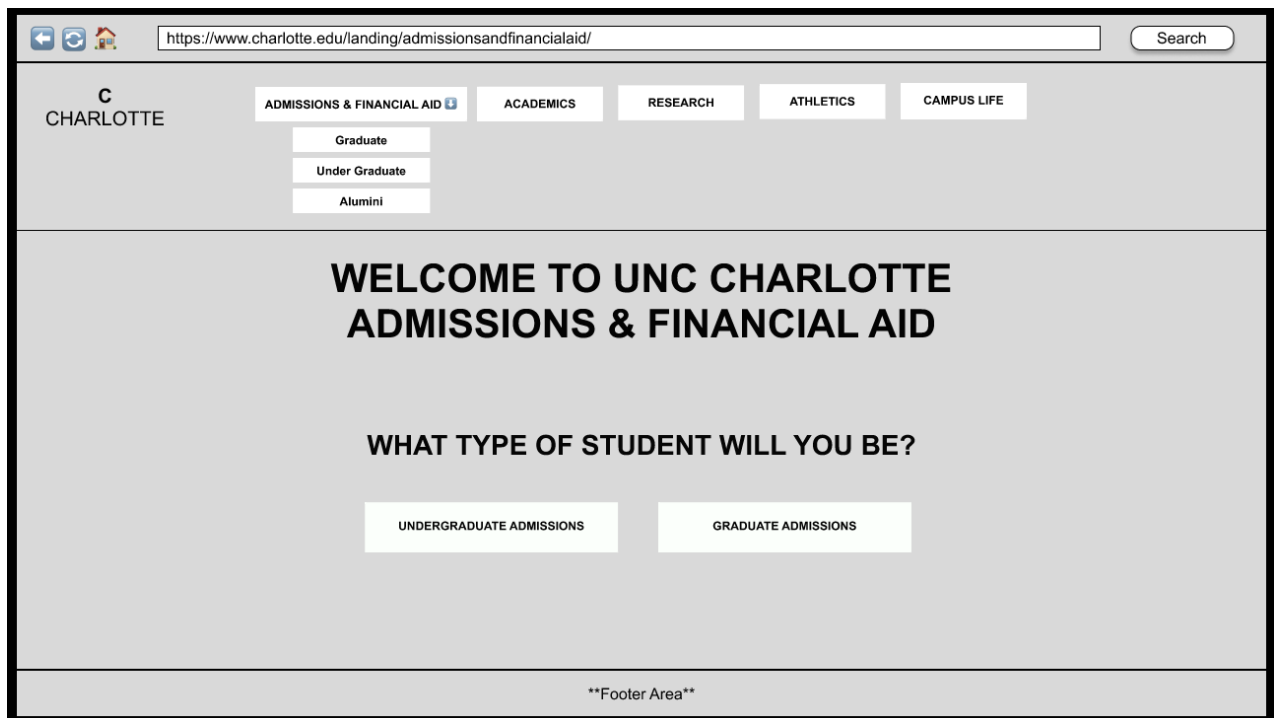
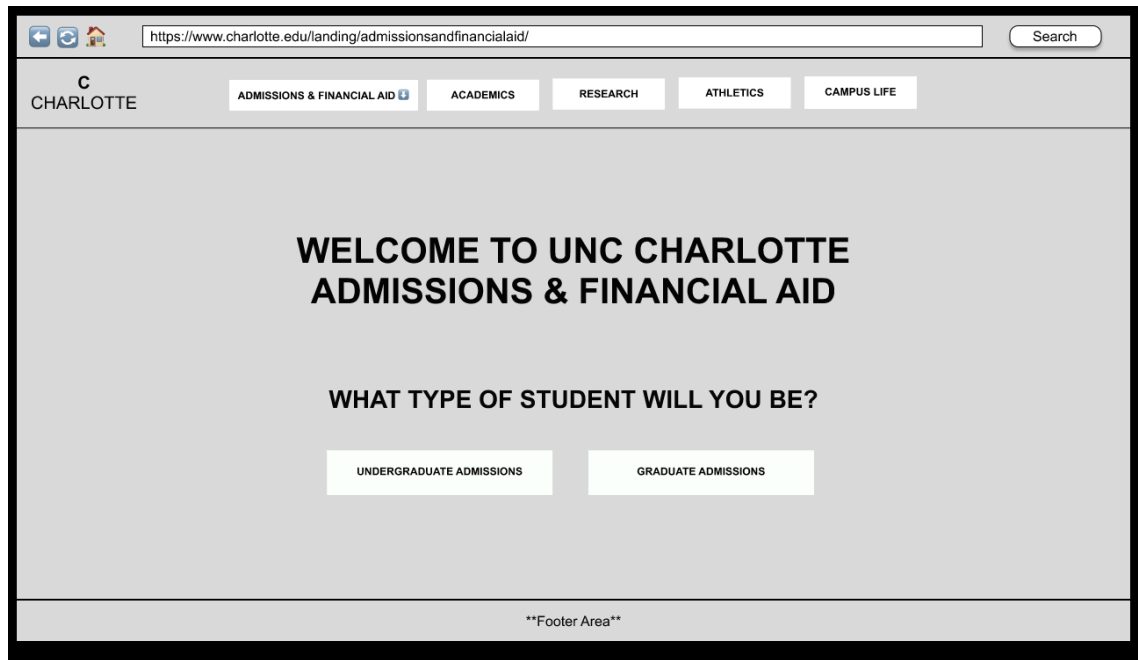
- a. The testing of participants representing each of the three personas-Ritu Sharma who is a Prospective Undergraduate Transfer Student then Mihir Patel who is an International Transfer Student and Shruti Desai, an Alumni Transfer Student-offered critical insight into challenges, needs, and expectations of using the Admissions and Financial Aid website at this university.
- b. **What went well** was that the interviewing process successfully captured detailed and actionable feedback. Participants appreciated the semi-structured format, where the telling of stories would happen without disruption but still manage to stay focused on critical topics. The use of Zoom for recording sessions was important to have clear audio and a robust record for analysis.
- c. **What didn't go well** included some scheduling conflicts, which were a bit of a challenge to deal with since participants had to work around personal and professional commitments. Other minor issues with sessions that arose included unstable internet connections. One of the issues that kept popping up was how difficult it was to find certain information on the website. This indicates whether navigation and discoverability need certain improvements.
- d. But there were some **unexpected learnings** such as:
 - i. **Dependency on Google:** Most of the respondents used Google to search for information they said should have been right there on the site. So major fault in the navigability.
 - ii. **Demand for Peer Testimonials:** Participants expressed interest in testimonials from peers or alumni, which could build trust and make the website more relatable.

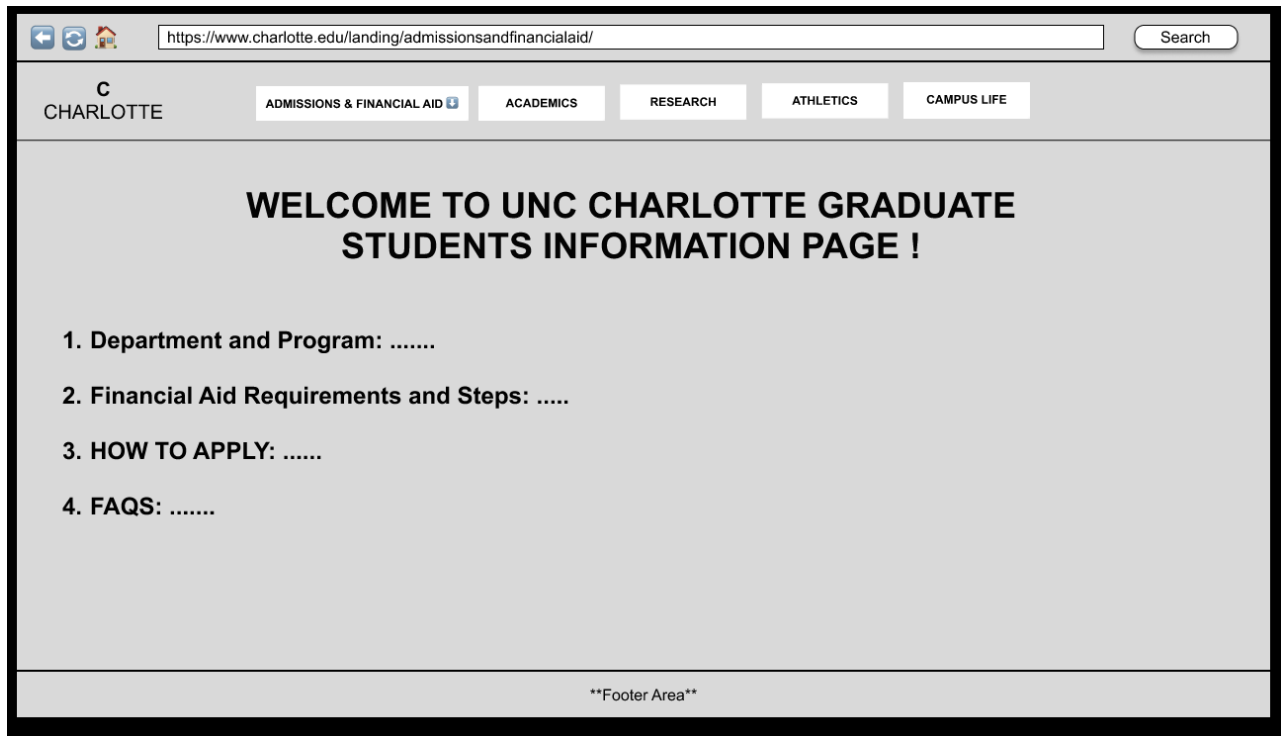
- iii. **Clarity in Eligibility Checkers:** The current eligibility checker was too generic. This has driven the students to demand bespoke outputs according to types such as prospective, international, or alumni students.
- e. Which leads to the **Key Insights from the interview** which revealed recurring themes that shaped the redesign strategy which are as follows:
 - i. **Navigation and Accessibility:** Respondents felt that finding this resource was a big hassle. For example, Ritu felt that the section for transfer students was "time-consuming and not intuitive." Mihir strongly felt that "I can hardly find links related to international student support." According to Shruti, too often while going through navigation related to financial aid information, "it took so many clicks," hence sometimes it was hard to trace resources specific to alumni.
 - ii. **Overwhelming Generalized Content:** Mihir and Ritu complained about an absence of partitioning of the content. International students were complaining that it is cumbersome to filter out information for the domestic users. In the same way, Shruti felt overwhelmed with the section on financial aid where scattered information made her less confident in the site.
 - iii. **Need for Interactive Support:** Support needs to be interactive in nature. Also, tools for interactive support were also a focus of emphasis for all three respondents. Ritu transfer student-specific aid eligibility checking, Mihir also suggested video tutorials of the international application process, and Shruti emphasized an FAQ section on credit transfers and questions specific to alumni students.
- f. Keeping in mind some of the major insights from above, we then assessed a few of the central needs identified or **user needs** during the interviews in the following manner:
 - i. **Simplified Navigation:** Clear directions to key areas to decrease the time and effort needed to find certain resources, for instance details on credit transfer or visa information.
 - ii. **Tailored Content:** Segregated pages for international, transfer, and alumni users; maintain targeted information in summarized form rather than bulk information.
 - iii. **Interactive Tools:** Include AI chatbots, interactive video tutorials showing processes step-by-step, and FAQs that are dynamic to personalized and real-time support for the user.
- g. Keeping these insights in mind, the development of personas led to the redesign approach to understand and target the most critical pain points of users.

Chapter 3: Top Three Needs and Design Ideas:

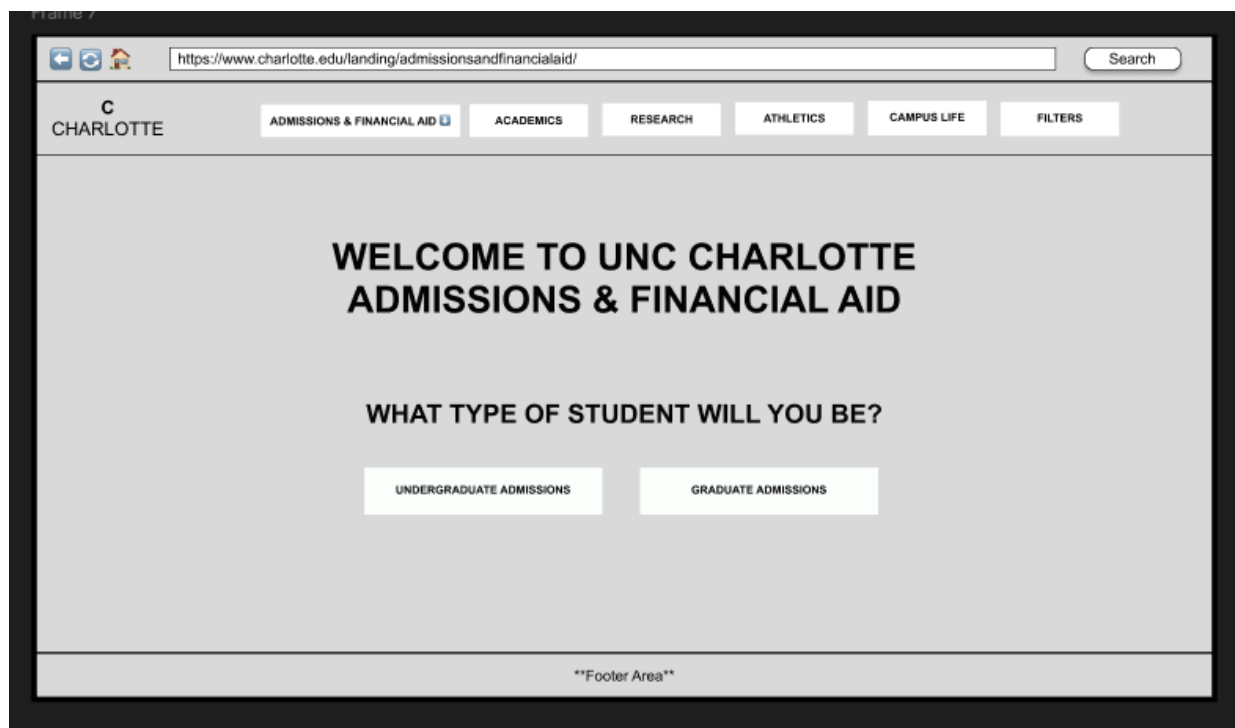
- **Introduction:** The introduction of three major user needs, oriented to enhance navigation, selection of the content according to the users' needs, and increase interactivity, has chosen website redesign based on insights gained from interviews, personas, and usability analysis. For each identified need, one single and well-thought-out design concept was created that proposes the best solution. The current chapter shows below the top three needs, explains the reasons for choosing those needs, and then proceeds with the introduction of related design concepts together with wireframes, which are as follows:
- **Identification of Top Three Needs:**
 - a. **Simplified Navigation and Information Accessibility:** Direct and intuitive navigational pathways are not provided by the website for accessing the most important areas, including academic programs, finance, and eligibility. This puts the end-users, for example, in a position where they cannot find what they are looking for without hassles. Thus, redesigning the navigational structure, which would take users through the website with ease, is indispensable for the facilitation of navigation and decreasing the complexity that improves user experience.
 - b. **Tailored Content Segmentation for Specific User Groups:** For most users, accessing relevant information is unthinkable, as the contents are not chunked. Because of the nature of the website structure, it's easier to access generalized information that may not suit a certain scenario. Segmentation of the contents into user groups, such as international students, transfer students, and graduate students would make the web content more personal and efficient.
 - c. **Enhanced Interactive and Personalized Support**
Features: During detailed operations, such as financial aid applications or the transfer of credit, support is given through which users can get clear assistance instantly, which is cumbersome. For personas, the inclusion of chatbots, frequently asked questions and video tutorials was required, which would provide instant support for students to continue without seeking external support. This deficiency would be met by an improvement in interactivity on the website.
- **Justified Selection of Needs:** The three needs have been directly selected about pain points and feedback of personas, usability testing, and interviews. Recurring challenges have been represented here that make a big difference in user satisfaction and the accomplishment of tasks:

- a. **Critical Impact on Usability:** The sign of good usability is to make navigation through the website or application easy. In the absence of a clear track, navigation becomes slow and crippling-in fact, users are prevented from achieving what they intend to achieve. For instance, users had to take help from external resources like Google to navigate through.
 - b. **Relevance to Target Personas:** Because different users have different needs, content must be segmented on the website. For example, international students will require very specific resources such as, but not limited to, visa information and scholarships available for a non-U.S. citizen. This makes personalization not just highly accessible but also trust-building among its users.
 - c. **High Demand for Real-Time Assistance:** The road to interactive tools and personal support is finding solutions to user needs in real time. What has repeatedly emphasized is the need for features such as chatbots and the option for live chats with all personas, which would reduce the effort necessary to finish complex tasks such as financial aid applications.
- These above requirements were ranked according to how frequently they appeared in different personas and how likely they are to significantly improve the usability of the website.
- **Design Ideas:** Each of the listed needs will be addressed with a creative and practical design solution. Below are the solutions corresponding to the problem statements and combined solutions, presented in a user-centric approach.
 - a. **Simplified Navigation and Enhanced Search Features:**
 - i. **Solution Description:** A combined approach that incorporates a Simplified Navbar and Filter Options:
 - 1. The simplified navbar allows dropdown under "Admission & Financial Aid" into pages directed toward the student type, whether Graduate, Undergraduate, or Alumni.





2. A "Filters" button opens the sidebar comprising Program Type, Student Type, Financial Aid, and FAFSA Guide. This will provide the viewer with the ability to search and filter results accordingly.



Frame 8

https://www.charlotte.edu/landing/admissionsandfinancialaid/ Search

C
CHARLOTTE

ADMISSIONS & FINANCIAL AID ACADEMICS RESEARCH ATHLETICS CAMPUS LIFE FILTERS

SELECT FILTERS AND SEARCH !

TYPE TO SEARCH Search

Program Type Student Type Financial Aid Transfer Requirements

Department Course Help FAFSA Guide Other

WELCOME TO UNC CHARLOTTE
ADMISSIONS & FINANCIAL AID

Footer Area

- ii. **Benefits:** Due to these improvements, it is simple to move around and cut down on wasting time when trying to find important resources. An example is that a transfer student will filter and receive credit transfer information, while the international student will get the requirements for the visa with ease.

b. Aid Eligibility Checker for Tailored Content

Segmentation:

- i. **Solution Description:** Position an "Aid Checker" button on the main navigation panel. By adding information to the form based on student type, program, and country of origin, it will return customized financial aid options with a list of eligibility. If not eligible, the results page will include the next steps or other resources.

https://www.charlotte.edu/landing/admissionsandfinancialaid/ Search

C
CHARLOTTE

ADMISSIONS & FINANCIAL AID ACADEMICS RESEARCH ATHLETICS CAMPUS LIFE AID CHECKER

WELCOME TO UNC CHARLOTTE ADMISSIONS & FINANCIAL AID

WHAT TYPE OF STUDENT WILL YOU BE?

UNDERGRADUATE ADMISSIONS GRADUATE ADMISSIONS

Footer Area

FRONT 2

https://www.charlotte.edu/landing/admissionsandfinancialaid/ Search

C
CHARLOTTE

ADMISSIONS & FINANCIAL AID ACADEMICS RESEARCH ATHLETICS CAMPUS LIFE AID CHECKER

AID ELIGIBILITY CHECKER

What Kind of Student are you?: Type either: Graduate/UnderGraduate/Alumini/PHD

Which Program are you in?: Type your Program

Country of Origin?: Type your Country

Are you First Generation Student?: Type either Yes/No/NA

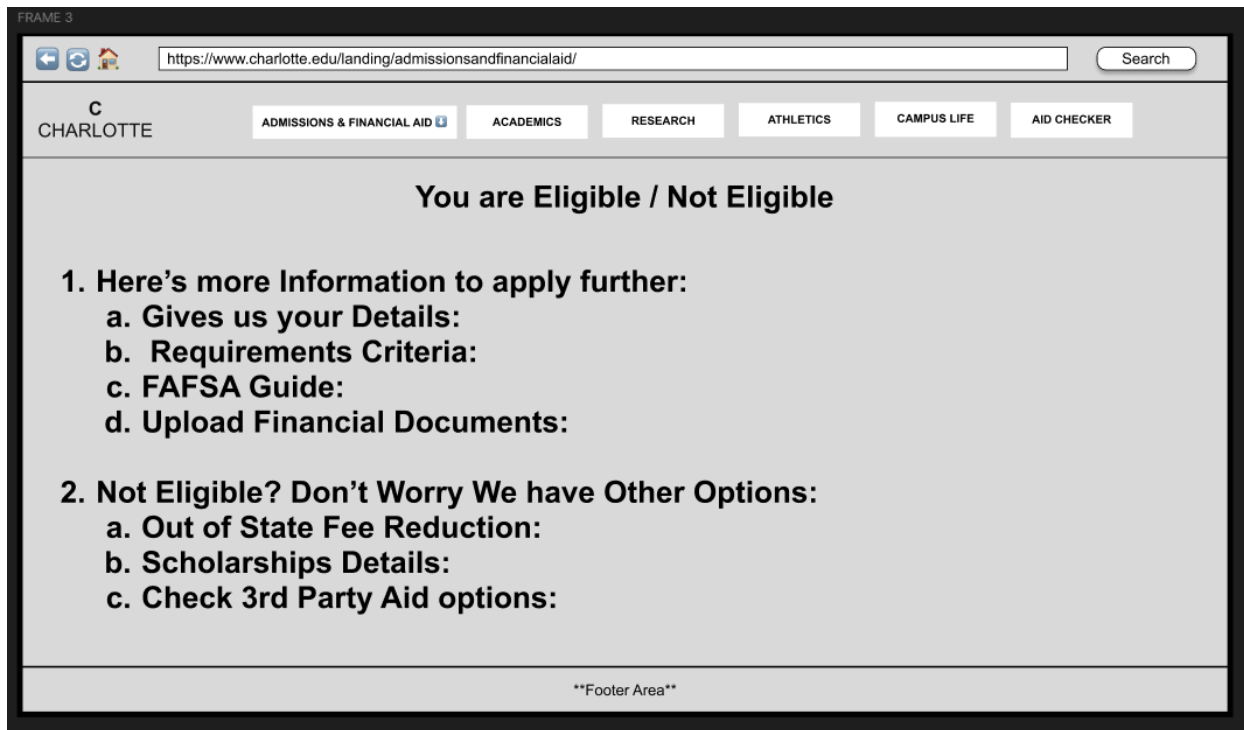
Select your department: Department Dropdown list

Select your Student Status: Type either: International/Transfer/Alumini

Which Semester are you Starting?: Semester Selection Dropdown List

Check Eligibility !! Clear Fields

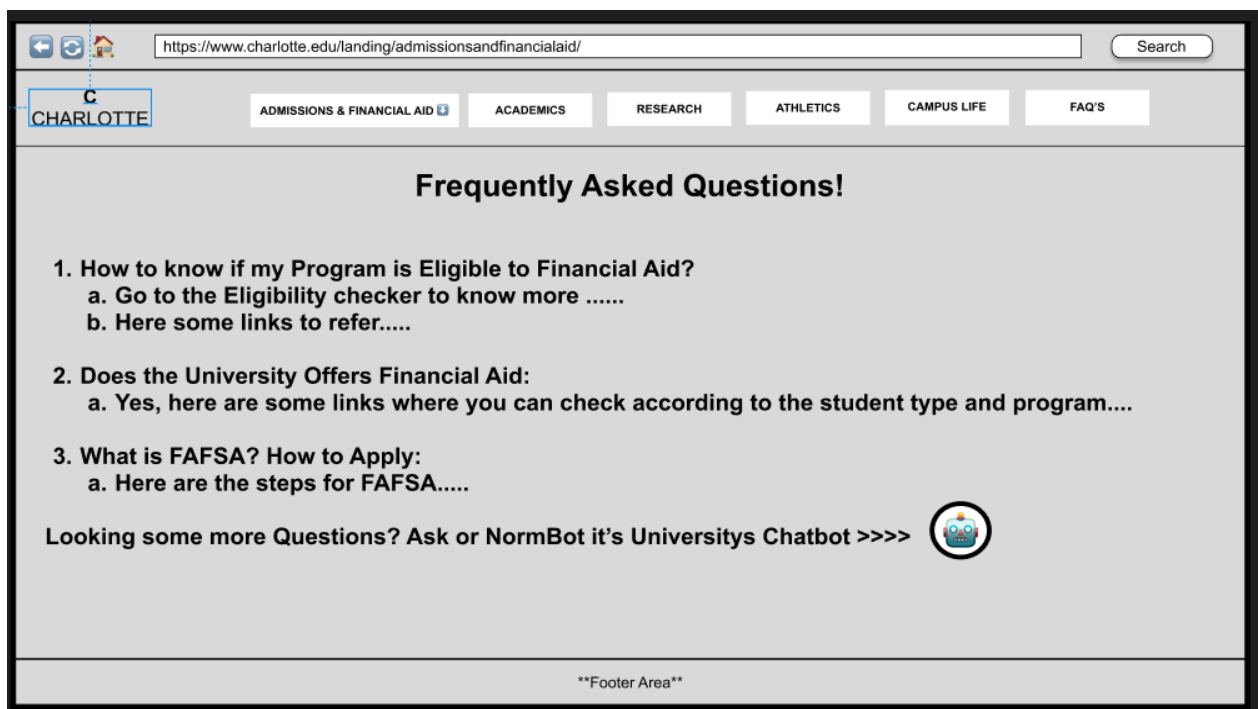
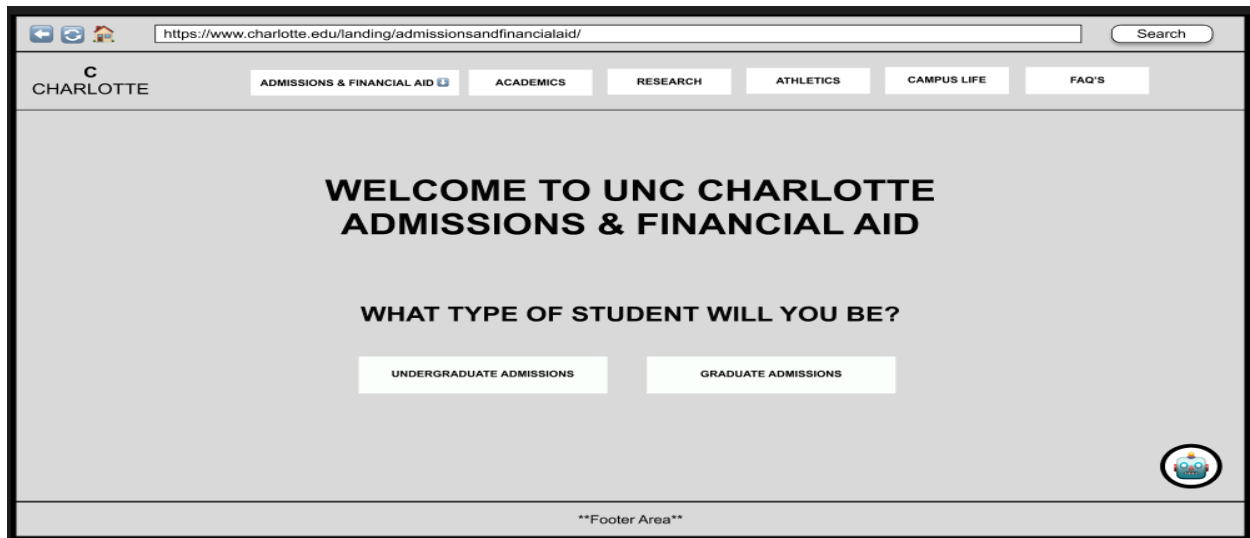
Footer Area

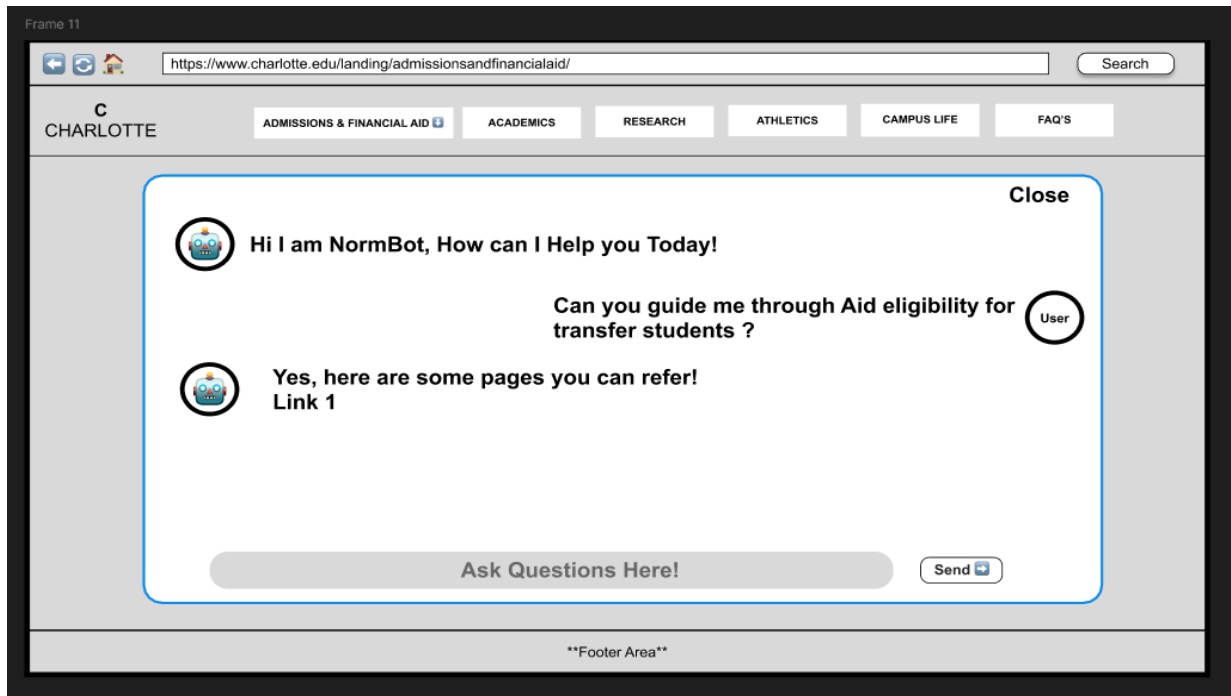


- ii. **Benefits:** This tool reduces confusion by only providing users with relevant content, depending on the information they enter. In such a way that an international student will only view the scholarships that are eligible for a non-US citizen, and transfer students will be only looking at the eligibility of aid related to their credit transfer status.

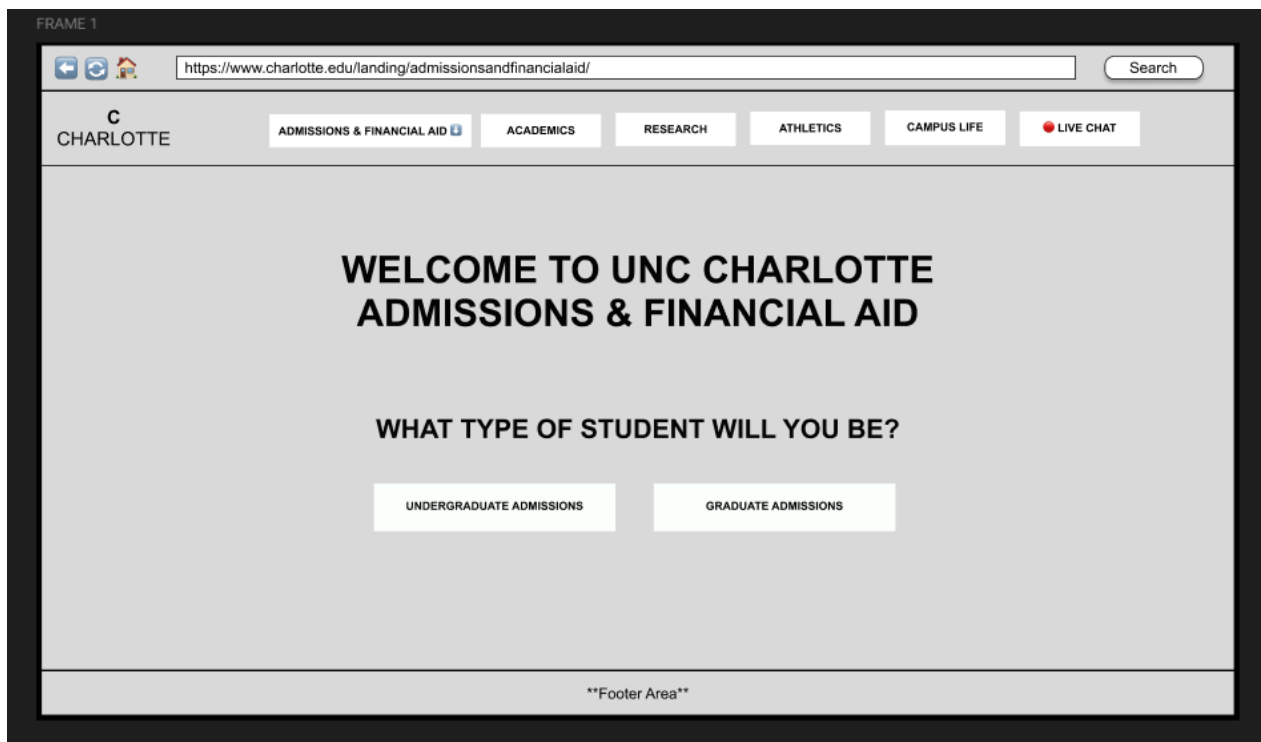
c. **Interactive Support Features: FAQ and Chatbot Combined with Live Chat:**

- i. **Solution Description:** Real time and in depth to complete the two solutions in one, as these features can enhance the overall Support feature:
 - 1. **FAQ and NormBot Chatbot:** The frequently asked questions are answered categorically in a tabbed format, and NormBot guides customers through how to find something or how to have complicated questions answered. Examples could include walking the students through FAFSA applications or credit transfer evaluations.





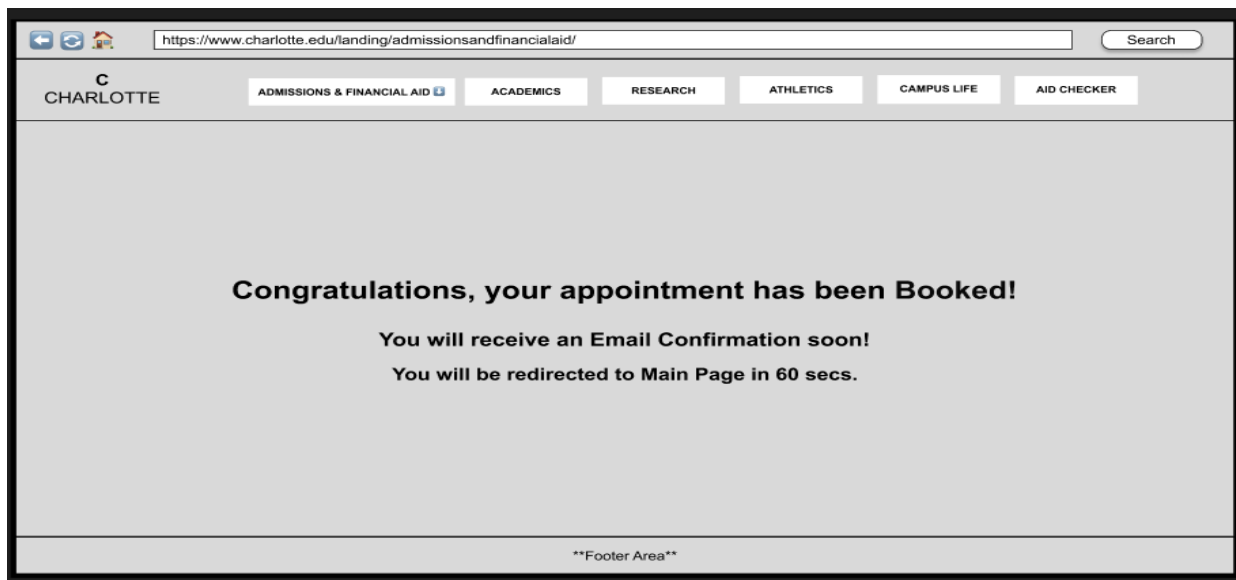
2. **Live Chat with Appointment Booking:** Users can schedule one-on-one sessions with a university representative by filling out an appointment form with details like Student Type, Program, and Preferred Time.



The screenshot shows a web browser window with the URL <https://www.charlotte.edu/landing/admissionsandfinancialaid/>. The page header includes the Charlotte logo and navigation links: ADMISSIONS & FINANCIAL AID, ACADEMICS, RESEARCH, ATHLETICS, CAMPUS LIFE, and AID CHECKER. The main content area is titled "BOOK AN APPOINTMENT" with the subtitle "To chat one on one with our Representative !!". The form contains the following fields and labels:

- Enter your Name?: Type your Name
- Country of Origin?: Type your Country
- Enter your Email?: Type your Email
- Check Date & Time Available: Select Date and Time
- Enter Student type and Program Type: Type either: International/Transfer and Graduate/UnderGraduate and Program details

At the bottom of the form are two buttons: "Book Appointment !!" and "Clear Fields". The footer area is labeled "**Footer Area**".



- ii. **Benefits:** Dual benefits involve the immediacy for the user through NormBot and personalized support through the live chat sessions. This addresses the diversified needs of the users, making the website experience smoother and friendlier.
- Navigation, customized content, and interactive tools solutions: The three above-mentioned features succeed in meeting the top three requirements effectively. By focusing on user concerns and providing focused solutions, redesigning achieves better usability and accessibility, adding to improved user happiness across all user groups.

Chapter 4: Usability Testing:

1. Participant Recruitment:

○ Eligible Selection Criteria:

- While searching for candidates for participation, the groups of undergraduate and graduate students were targeted while trying to distribute different experiences and views. This was a group that perfectly met the personas defined above, including transfer student, international student, and alumni.
- These participants are selected for the reason that they perfectly illustrate the personas as defined and also serve the exact needs of a student. The participants, once again, are going to test and offer valid and actionable feedback that can be utilized in refining the design to accommodate the actual user needs such as navigation tools, financial aid, and some support tools.

○ Rationale for Participant Selection:

- These participants were chosen again in order to fit the trait of the persona that we have discussed; those participants are:
 - I. **Ritu (Prospective Undergraduate Transfer Student):** Ritu who is a student currently pursuing a degree from community college and is coming to UNC Charlotte on a four-year program. She is most concerned about the process of credit transfer and what financial aid would be available to her.
 - II. **Mihir (International Transfer Student):** Mihir an international graduate student going through more complex processes like obtaining a visa, seeking scholarships, and transfer credit policy.
 - III. **Shruti (Alumni Transfer Student):** Shruti is an Alumni looking to complete a second degree, searching for alumni-only resources, such as re-enrollment and financial aid information.
- It means that the user insights found from usability testing were applicable to the personas, hence, exact improvements could be conducted on the website design.

○ Informed Consent:

- It was made crystal clear to them, prior to the testing sessions, that everything related to this particular testing involved audio and screen

recording. The participants gave verbal consent prior to the test wherein everything was clear and open for them to feel comfortable and give their honest contributions for the enhancement of UNC Charlotte Financial and Admissions aid website.

2. Usability Sessions: (Contains Task Assignments, Follow-up questions, Usability Findings, and Changes Made)

○ Usability Testing Sessions:

- Usability testing was conducted one-on-one through Zoom, whereby participants had to go through some guided tasks set up to test the major features of the website, which included navigation, the Aid Eligibility Checker, and other support tools like FAQs and Chatbot. Each session was about 15-20 minutes, and participants went through flows and patterns during the interview. I captured our data input and voice with OBS Studio and Notepad.

○ Assigned Tasks:

▪ Task 1: Testing Navigation Features

1. **Scenario:** Participants chose their respective program and ended up on the welcome page to get information regarding their program.

2. Main Task:

- Start at the home page and click on the "Admissions & Financial Aid" dropdown menu.
- Find pages relevant to their persona, like "Transfer Students" or "International Students."
- How easy or hard was it to locate those specific resources?

3. Follow Up Questions:

- Was the drop-down intuitive? Did it help find what was being looked for?
- How would you find the filters useful for getting information?
- What might be done to facilitate resources more easily for prospective transfers?

▪ Task 2: Visiting the Aid Eligibility Checker

1. **Scenario:** Participants used the tool to determine their eligibility for financial aid.

2. Main Task:

- From the home page, click on "Aid Eligibility Checker."

- Enter information that is specific to the persona, such as transfer status or international student status.
- Assess the clarity of the information provided by the tool in communicating one's eligibility and next steps.

3. Follow Up Questions:

- Did the eligibility estimator provide supportive for the proper information?
- Did the tool do an adequate job communicating your eligibility for financial aid?
- How could this service be more supportive of incoming transfers?

▪ Task 3: FAQ and Testing the Chatbot

1. **Scenario:** During the last few days, users have been trying out the FAQ section and asking more questions to the chatbot-Norm Bot-to obtain additional information.

2. Main Task:

- Look at the FAQ to locate questions your persona would have the answers to.
- If needed, ask additional questions to Norm Bot, evaluating its responses.

3. Follow Up Questions:

- Were the FAQs sufficient for your questions?
- Was Norm Bot useful? In what ways might the responses be more relevant?
- How could this FAQ and chatbot be improved to best meet your needs?

○ Usability Findings:

▪ What Went Well:

1. **Dropdown Navigation:** Because the dropdown menu was organized, it helped in finding out where major sections were.
2. **Aid Eligibility Checker:** This brought them along well in the financial options, as at least they know their eligibility status.
3. **FAQ and Chatbot:** The FAQ was a good gateway, and Norm Bot added value due to his interactive support.

▪ What Didn't Go Well:

1. **Navigation Issues:** Users wanted more persona-specific links in dropdowns-such as "Prospective Transfers" or "International Transfers."

2. **Checker Feedback Problems:** Users who were ineligible to receive actionable next steps found that frustrating.
 3. **FAQ Generalization:** The FAQs were too general and didn't get to a specific user's pain.
- **Unexpected Learnings:**
 1. **Multilingual Support:** Mihir, being an international student, made a point regarding the need for FAQs and Guides in multiple languages.
 2. **Video Tutorials:** Some of them further contributed to the point that some of the processes, like those for FAFSA applications, were really complicated and insisted on the inclusion of video tutorials as a form of guide to make it easy.
 3. **Live Chat Function:** Shruti, the alumna, recommended the feature of Live chat so that she can directly get in touch with the right person and ask questions related to her needs.
 - **Changes Made:**
 - **Improved Navigation:**
 1. Added a section link into the dropdown menu for personas that would lead to an elucidation and clear segmentation of the available resources such as "Transfer Students," "International Students," and "Alumni Students." into each section of the labels. Paid due attention to menu items using tooltips.
 - **Improved Aid Eligibility Checker:**
 1. Added in validation of required fields so one could not get into errors.
 2. Follow-up pages for both eligible and ineligible users with clear next step.
 - **Smoothened Support Tools and Feedback options:**
 1. It also contained an extended FAQ section, adding to the persona-related questions, video guides that would walk a user through the more general processes.
 2. Improved the Norm Bot with more accurate responses and feedback. The wider the range of questions and responses, the better the chatbot. Also, it will ask for feedback for each question that it answers or at the end of the chat. It will be asking users to provide a score out of 1-5. In case the rating is less than 3, then it will ask users to describe the mistake it has done. Later, it will provide a chance to schedule a live chat with an academic advisor. This feature will improve not only the accuracy of the chatbot but

will also upgrade the chatbot to give more personalized responses to the users.

3. Introduced use of live chat for instant support by overall implementing a Help button in the navbar that would contain two other buttons, Live Chat and FAQ's.

3. Conclusion:

- Usability testing was rather instrumental in yielding valuable information that made a direct impact on redesigning. Consequently, the redesigned version is more user-centered with the inclusion of meeting the needs of target groups prospected for transfer students, international students, and alumni. It enhances the manner of navigation, clarity of content, and effective interactive tools. Improved feedback mechanisms ensure support for users improves incrementally towards enhancing the functionality and usability of the website through the chatbots.

Chapter 5: High-Fidelity Prototypes and Changes:

This chapter introduces all the High Fidelity prototypes made by following various data inputs and principles gathered throughout the first four chapters.

1. Solution 1: Improved Navigation:

a. Evolution Explanation:

- i. We began the redesign of the navigation knowing from the interviews that our target persona, Ritu, was getting very frustrated with the cluttered menus and a lack of paths on where to find some of the information. The low-fidelity wireframes were our first attempt at solving this. We tried a basic layout, such as the navbar having the core buttons, however, there was no real hierarchy. The users were forced to wade through several layers to find the relevant sections. As one would expect, this wasn't intuitive enough, going by the results of usability testing.
- ii. Informed by the feedback, we totally redesigned the navigation for our high-fidelity prototypes. The improved navbar was to act like a guide to help the user get exactly where they needed to go. We made that more engaging by adding emojis to each one of the buttons. This wasn't just for aesthetic look and feel, it was about helping these users, at a glance, to identify sections. Subcategories had also been added to the dropdown

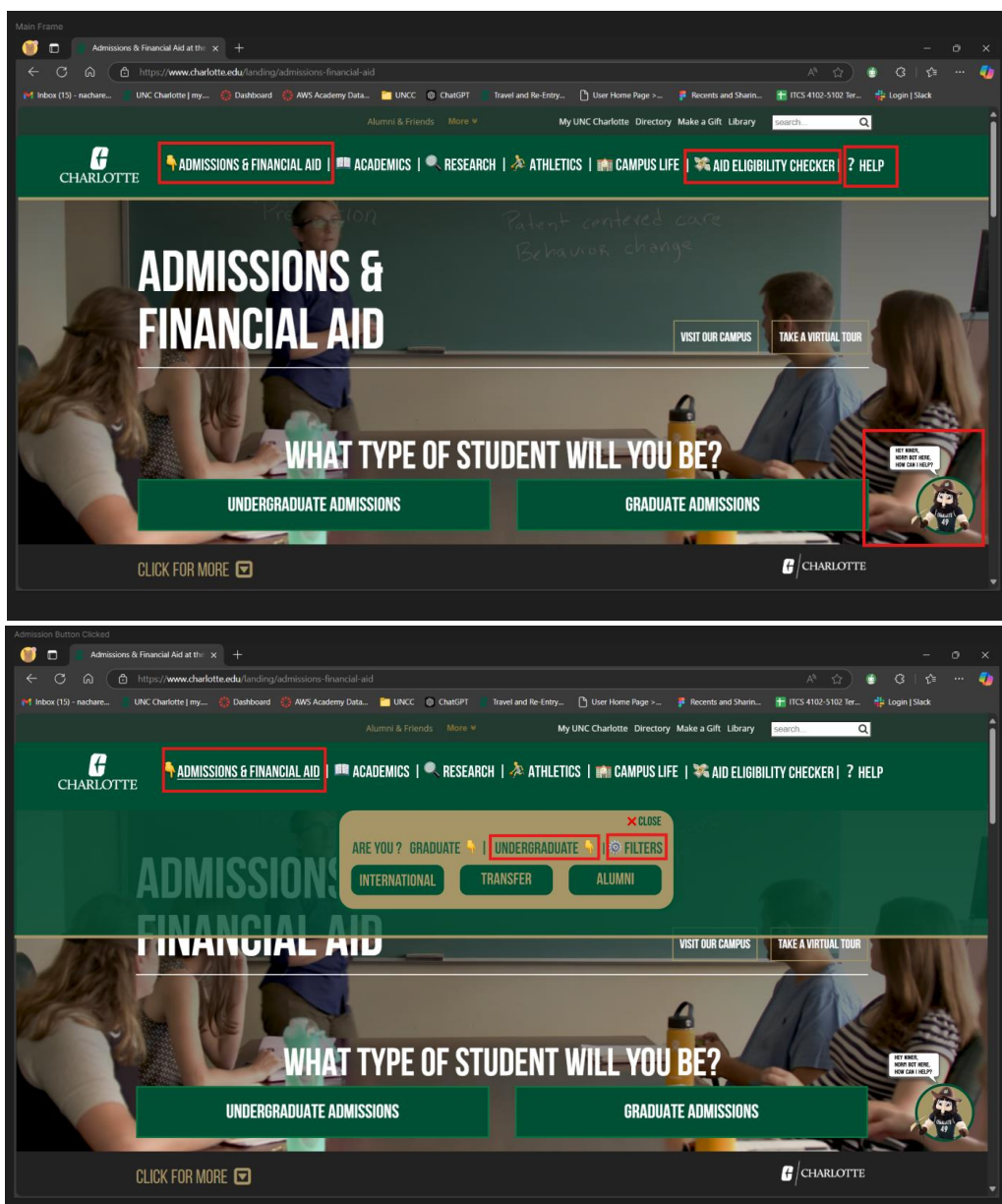
menu under "Admissions & Financial Aid", including Undergraduate and Transfer Students.

- iii. We also added a filter button directly in the navigation for more streamlined searches. This allowed users to narrow their results sans the endless scrolling or guessing where to click next. The result is a navigation system almost like an attentive assistant-smoothly guiding users to their destination.

b. Screenshots and Annotations:

i. Redesigned Navbar:

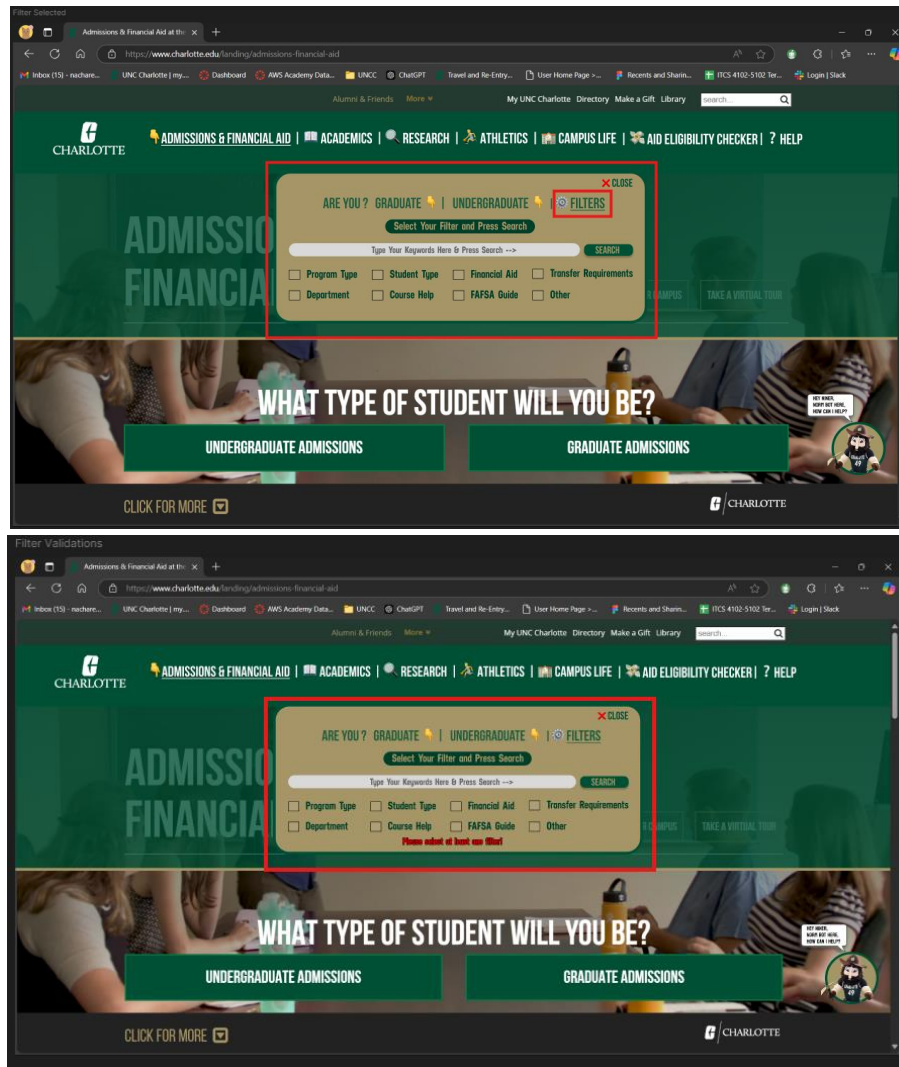
1. Screenshot:

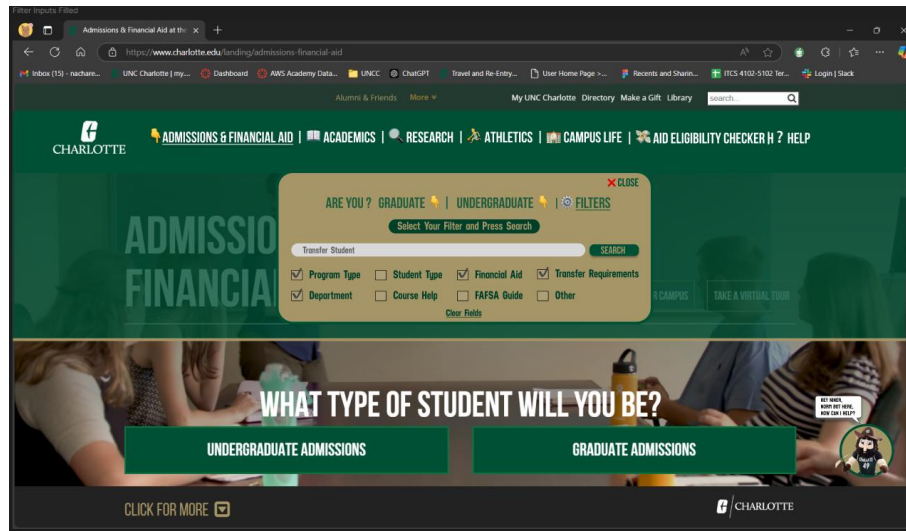


2. **Annotation:** In the drop-down menu under "Admissions & Financial Aid," one selects the student type and then drills down to pages that interest them. Emojis next to the buttons make the use of navigation more intuitive and appealing to the eye.

ii. Filters Section:

1. Screenshot:

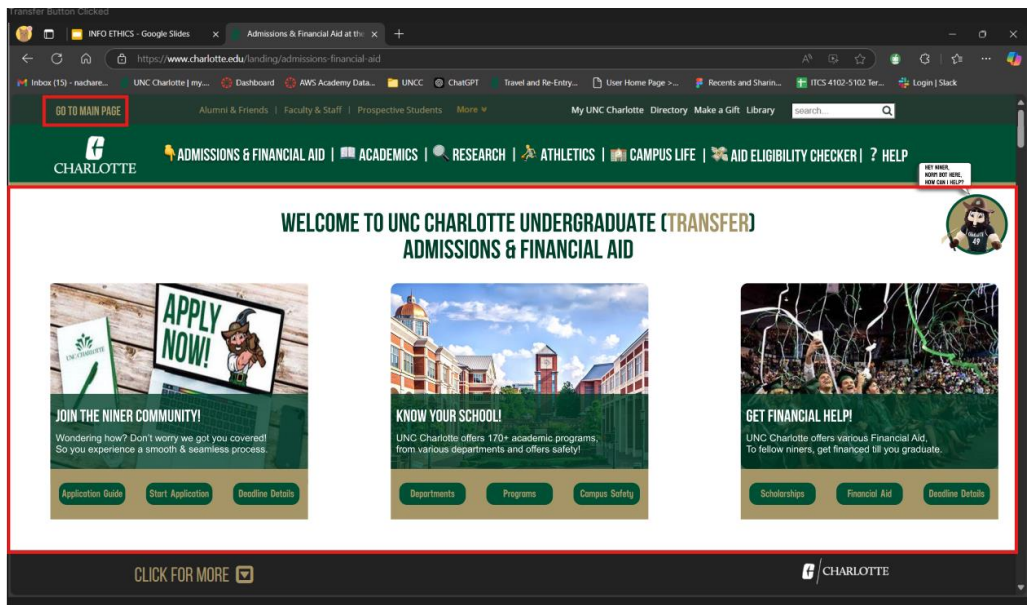




2. **Annotation:** The filters sidebar enables filtering of information by student type, program, or financial aid options. A validation ensures that at least one filter is chosen before proceeding.

iii. Undergraduate/Transfer Dashboard:

1. Screenshot:



2. **Annotation:** This page will be an information hub for applicants. It has info cards with short information and clearly headed topics of application, program offerings, and financial aid resources.

- c. **Changes Description:** From the very first wireframes to this high-fidelity design, the navigation really changed, and some new enhancements were made. Notable changes include the following:
 - i. **Dropdown Menus:** Combined categorized submenus under "Admissions & Financial Aid," such as Undergraduate and Transfer Students. Such menus link directly to the most relevant resources.
 - ii. **Visual Aids:** Added emojis to each button to enhance user recognition and interaction.
 - iii. **Filters:** Added dynamic filter button for users to get more refined search, which makes the experience so much easier and definite when they navigate something.
- d. **Improvements and Refinements:** Above-listed enhancements made quite a difference with our users:
 - i. **Usability:** It was not cumbersome anymore to navigate. The dropdown menus and filters make it very easy to get to a particular section without frustration.
 - ii. **Efficiency:** This translates to users being able to get what they need with fewer clicks, thus saving time and minimizing effort on the user's behalf.
 - iii. **Inclusivity:** Heavy usage of visual cues, such as emojis, allows navigation to be more inclusive for users who might be intimidated by text-heavy menus.

2. Solution 2: Aid Eligibility Checker:

a. Evolution Explanation:

- i. The pain points that kept on recurring in our interviews are confusions over financial aid eligibility. Ritu, like many of our potential applicants, considers this lengthy and confusing to comprehend what they might qualify for. Our early low-fidelity wireframes included a very simple form with which to gather information, but this was non-interactive and detailed enough. Users couldn't get personalized results, and there was no clear path forward if they were found ineligible.
- ii. For the high-fidelity prototypes, we extended this. We designed a fully interactive version of the Aid Eligibility Checker that feels more like having a conversation, less like a form. It does start to collect some basic details, name, age, and email address, with validation at each stage: for example, the user cannot submit an email address if its format is wrong. It drills down further with the specific questions: "Is this your first time in college?" or "What type of student are you?" The resulting answers route

them through either the eligibility page or provide other resources if they will not qualify.

- iii. The reason this was here was to let users know they wouldn't be left hanging out to dry, whether their status reflected eligibility for standard aid or not.

b. Screenshots and Annotations:

i. Eligibility Checker Form:

1. Screenshot:

AID ELIGIBILITY CHECKER

Enter your name:* Type your full name here!

Enter your age:* Type age! Country of Origin?:* Enter your Country!

Enter your email-id:* Enter a valid email-id!

Are you a First Generation Student?:* ☐ YES ☐ NO

Which Major are you in?:* Type your Major!

Select your Student Status?:* Select one status only! ⚡

Which Semester are you Starting?:* ☐ FALL ☐ SPRING ☐ SUMMER

What Kind of Student are you?:* Select one type of student only! ⚡

CHECK ELIGIBILITY !! **CLEAR FIELD'S**

PLEASE ENTER ALL VALID FIELDS TO CONTINUE

AID ELIGIBILITY CHECKER

Enter your name:*

Enter your age:* Country of Origin?:*

Enter your email-id:*

Are you a First Generation Student?:* ☐ YES ☐ NO

Which Major are you in?:*

Select your Student Status?:*
 Select one status only!
 TRANSFER
 INTERNATIONAL
 ALUMNI
 Select one type of student only!
 GRADUATE
 UNDERGRADUATE
 ALUMNI

Which Semester are you Starting?:*

What Kind of Student are you?:*

CHECK ELIGIBILITY

AID ELIGIBILITY CHECKER

Enter your name:*

Enter your age:* Country of Origin?:*

Enter your email-id:*

Are you a First Generation Student?:* ☒ YES ☐ NO

Which Major are you in?:*

Select your Student Status?:*

Which Semester are you Starting?:* ☒ FALL ☐ SPRING ☐ SUMMER

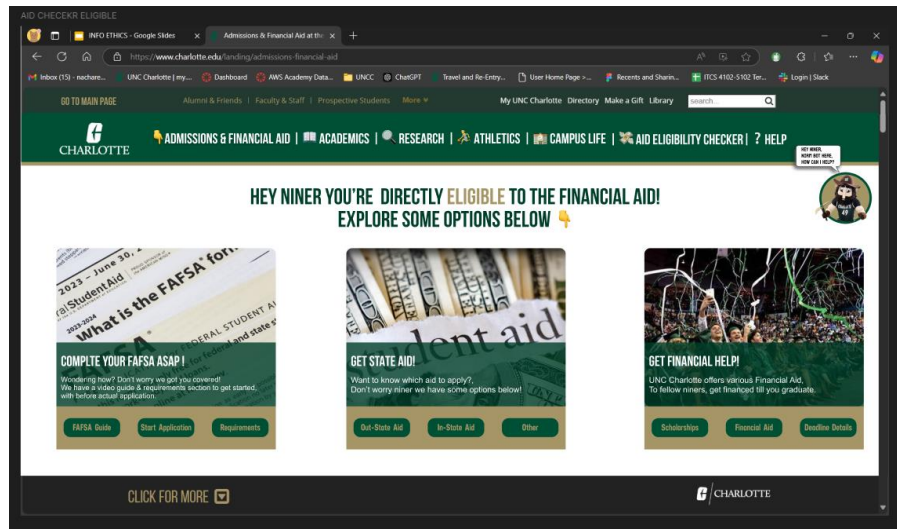
What Kind of Student are you?:*

CHECK ELIGIBILITY !! **CLEAR FIELD'S**

2. **Annotation:** The form will collect user information with validations for accuracy. Dropdowns and radio buttons ensure users can easily select their status and preferences.

ii. Eligible Page:

1. Screenshot:



2. **Annotation:** Provides personalized information, tabbed in three info cards: FAFSA guide, State Aid options, and Financial Help. Each has actionable buttons.

iii. Ineligible Page:

1. Screenshot:

AID ELIGIBILITY CHECKER [X] CLOSE

Enter your name:* Nishant Acharekar

Enter your age:* 24 Country of Origin?:* INDIA

Enter your email-id:* nishant@gmail.com

Are you a First Generation Student?:* ☒ YES ☐ NO

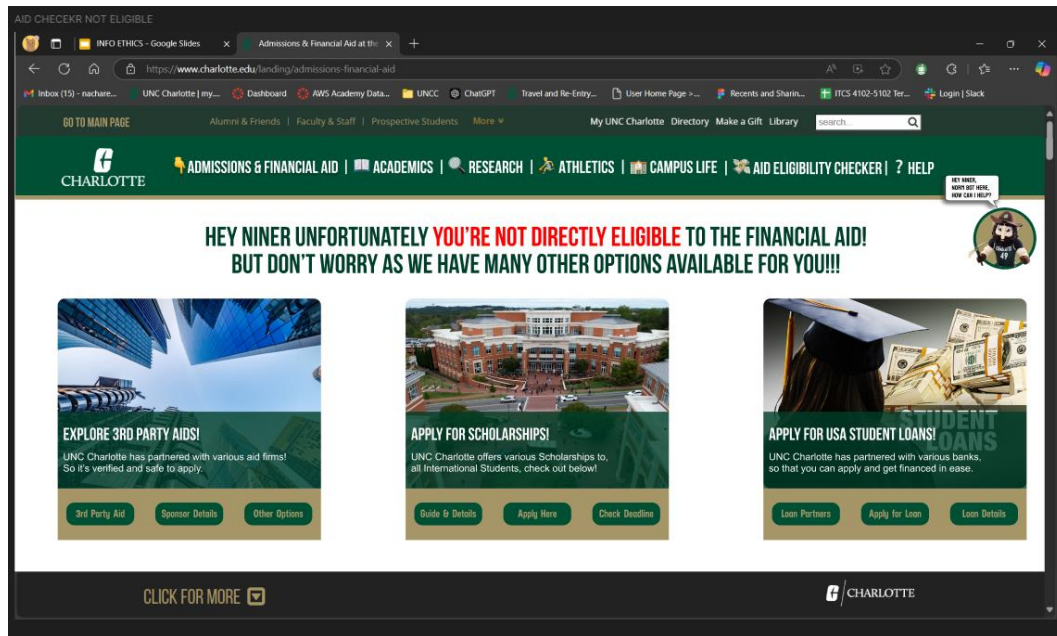
Which Major are you in?:* Computer Science

Select your Student Status?:* INTERNATIONAL

Which Semester are you Starting?:* ☒ FALL ☐ SPRING ☐ SUMMER

What Kind of Student are you?:* UNDERGRADUATE

CHECK ELIGIBILITY !! **CLEAR FIELD'S**



2. **Annotation:** These can include recommendations for third-party assistance, scholarships, and borrowing options so the visitor feels worth.

c. Changes Description:

- i. **Form Validations:** Added form validation to ensure that users cannot skip over or add invalid data in the fields.
- ii. **Customized Results:** There were two customized pages created specifically for eligible and ineligible results so that customized recommendations could be made.
- iii. **Info Cards:** Appealing cards were designed that contained clear headings and actionable buttons for resources.

d. Improvements and Refinements:

- i. **Branded Support:** Results will only show relevant to their situation, therefore avoiding possible confusion.
- ii. **Empower Users:** Users who aren't qualified will have actionable next steps; this allows them to be helped too.
- iii. **Professionalism:** The eligibility check is polished in design. This builds trust and is a reflection of the commitment on behalf of the university to its prospect students.

3. Solution 3: Adding Support to Navbar and Chatbot:

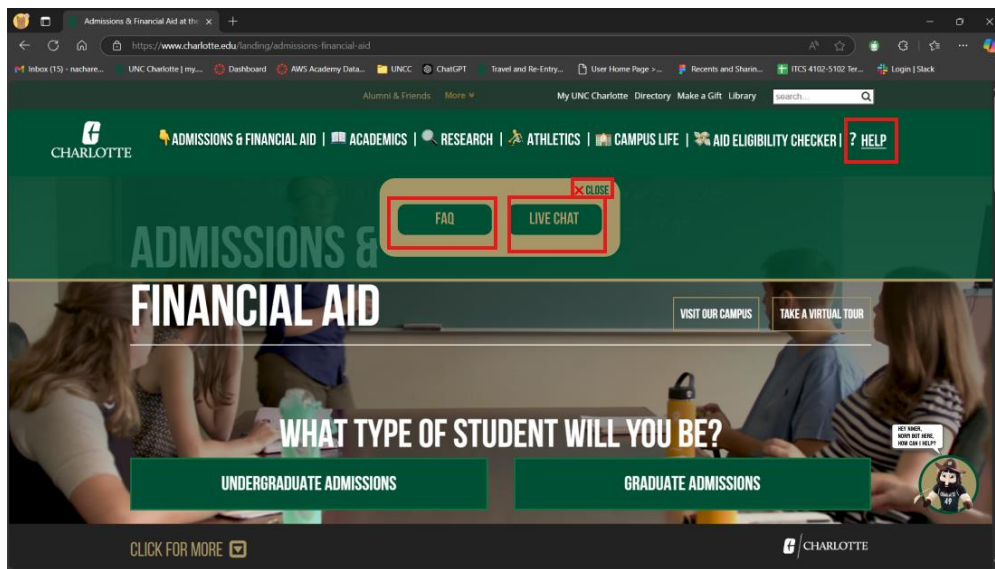
a. Evolution Explanation:

- i. More exciting things were probably putting the support system right into the navbar. Through interviews, many users would point out that support was desired directly. Be it Ritu wanting to know about application deadlines or another user having problems with transfer requirements, a crystallizing desire for a live chat and a detailed FAQ existed.
- ii. Those features were not included in the low-fidelity wireframes because, yes, we did underestimate their importance initially. The high-fidelity prototypes shed light on this with a "Help" button in the nav bar. With this button, a dropdown opens containing two options: FAQs and Live Chat. The click of FAQs leads into an interactive section where the answers link to related pages. Scheduling a live chat is possible through an extensively detailed form for real-time assistance. Finally, there is Norm Bot, our chatbot, designed to manage common queries while providing a feedback loop to enhance responses over time.

b. Screenshots and Annotations:

i. Help Dropdown Menu:

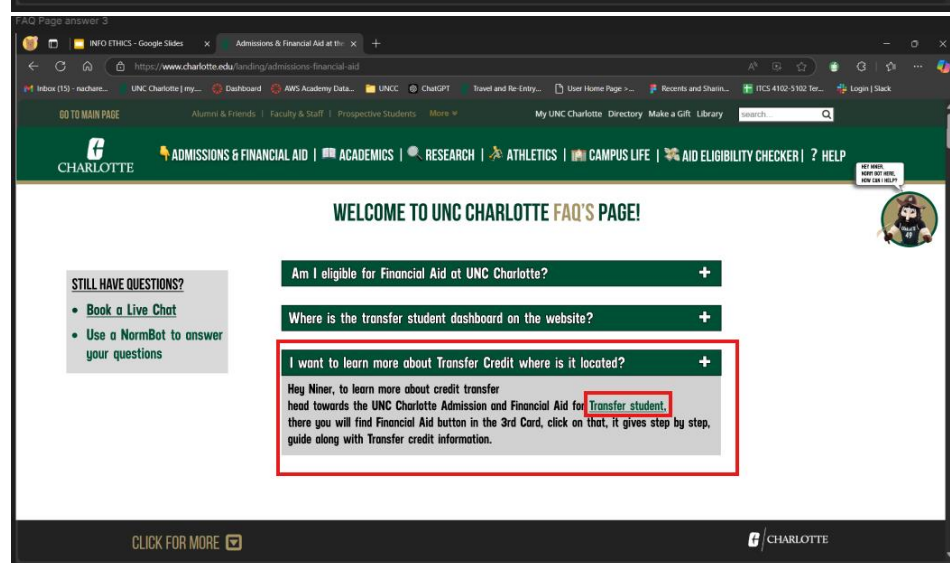
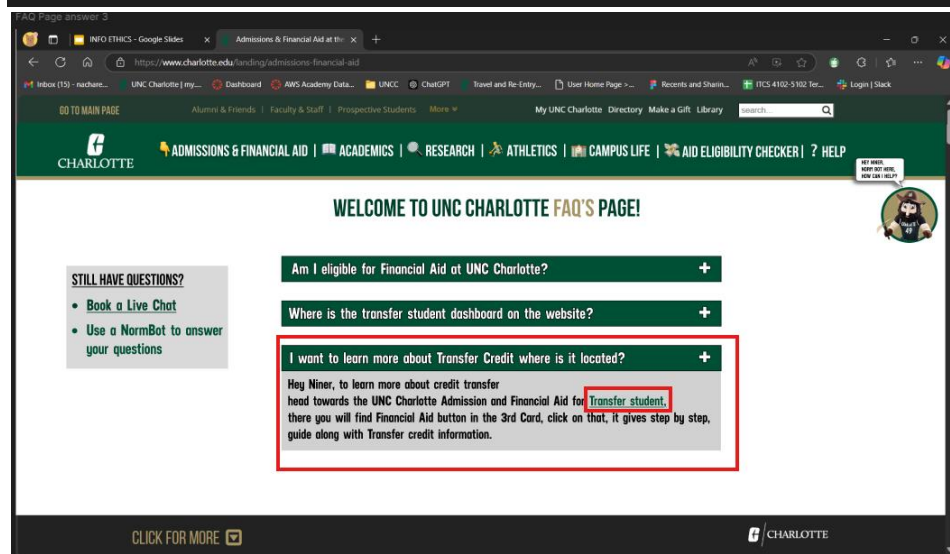
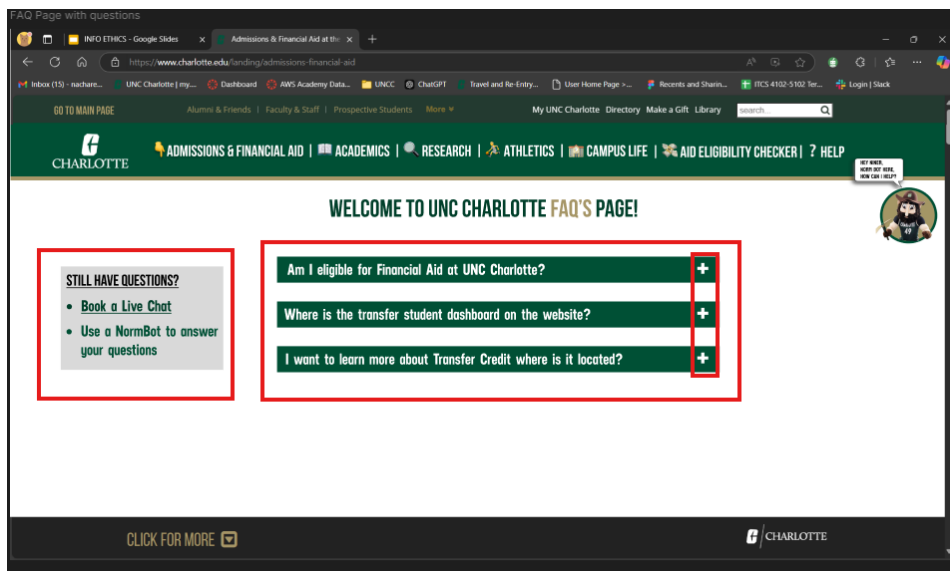
1. Screenshot:



2. **Annotation:** It contains buttons to show FAQs and Live Chat so that help is always available.

ii. Interactive FAQ:

1. Screenshot:



2. **Annotation:** The questions are interactive, and the answers link directly to related pages for ease of navigation.

iii. Live Chat Form:

1. Screenshot:

Aid checker clicked

AID ELIGIBILITY CHECKER CLOSE

Enter your name:* Type your full name here!

Enter your age:* Type age! Country of Origin?:* Enter your Country!

Enter your email-id:* Enter a valid email-id!

Are you a First Generation Student?:* ☐ YES ☐ NO

Which Major are you in?:* Type your Major!

Select your Student Status?:* Select one status only! ⚡

Which Semester are you Starting?:* ☐ FALL ☐ SPRING ☐ SUMMER

What Kind of Student are you?:* Select one type of student only! ⚡

Live Chat Form Validations

BOOK A LIVE CHAT APPOINTMENT CLOSE

Get all your questions answered by our representative!

Enter your name:* Type your full name here!

Enter your age:* Type age! Country of Origin?:* Enter your Country!

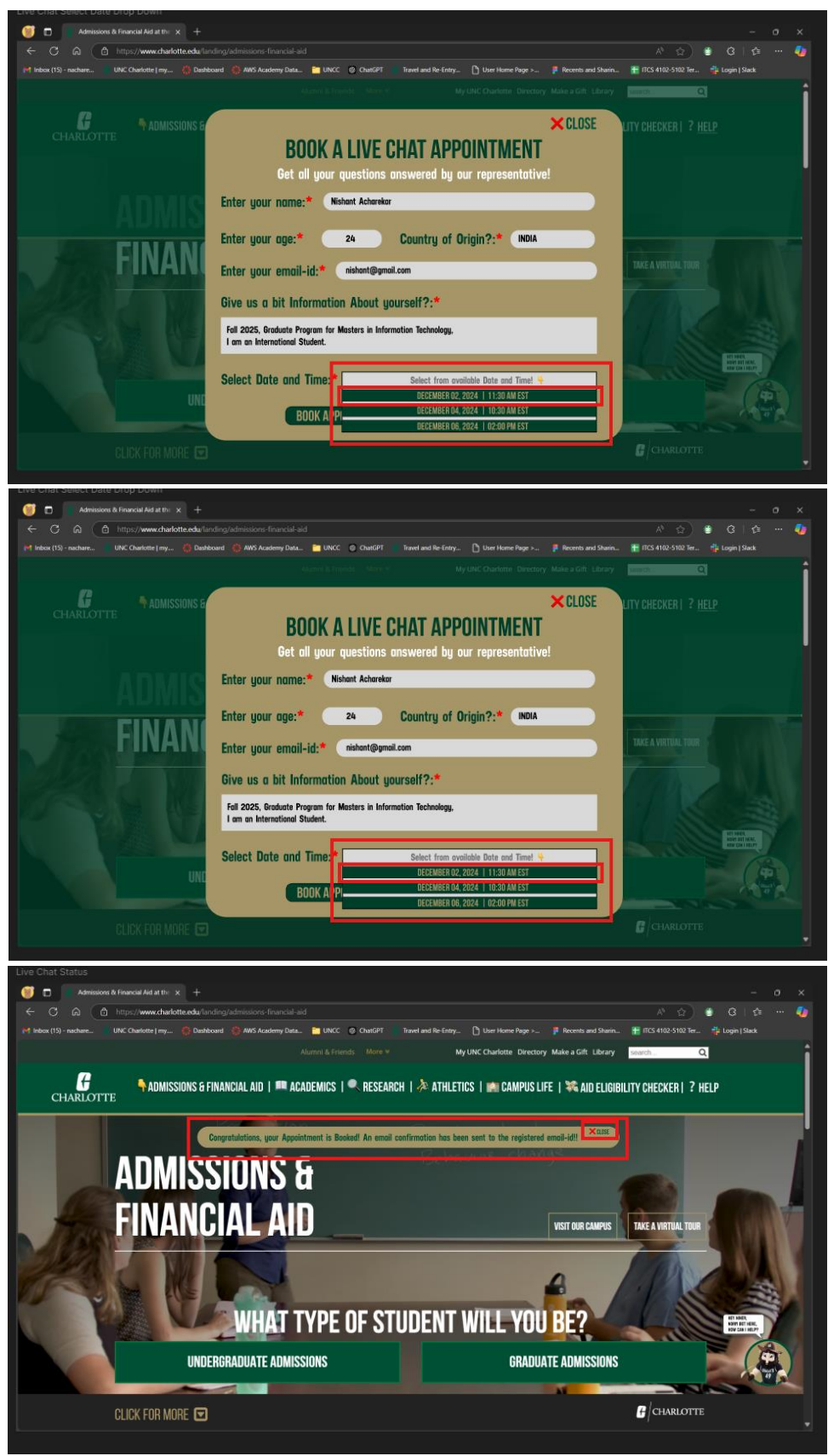
Enter your email-id:* Enter a valid email-id!

Give us a bit Information About yourself?:*

Type: Which Semester you are enrolled in and the program and major, Also type your student status (International, Transfer, Alumni).....

Select Date and Time:* Select from available Date and Time! ⚡

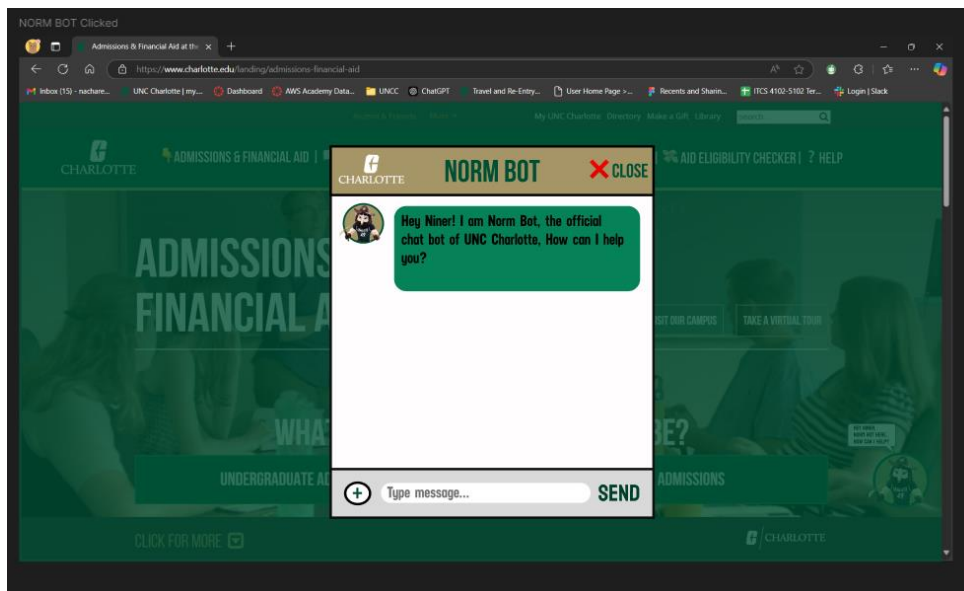
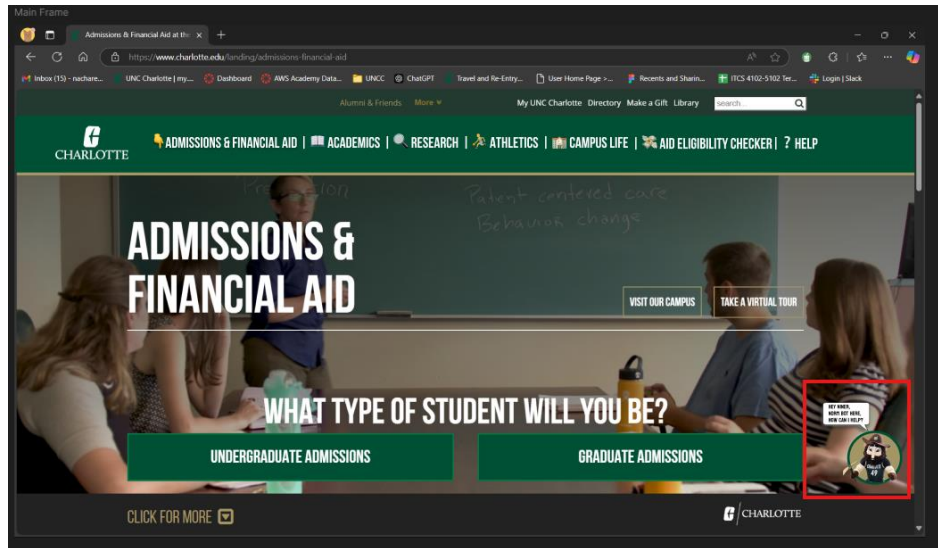
PLEASE ENTER ALL YOUR FIELD TO SUBMIT

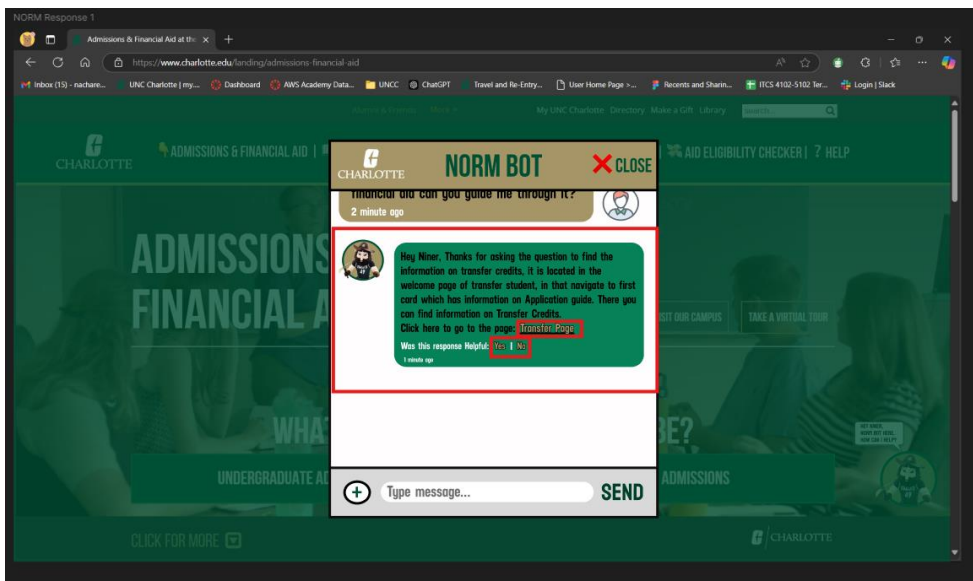
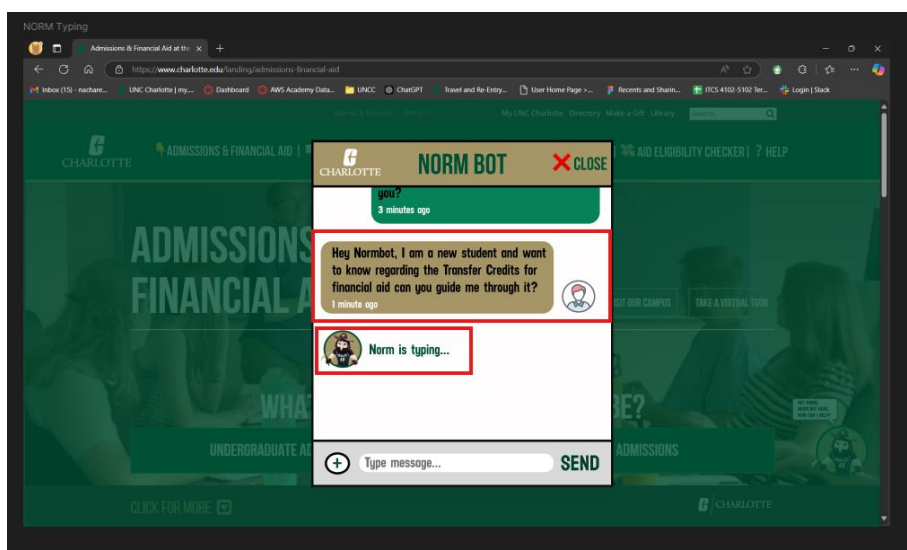
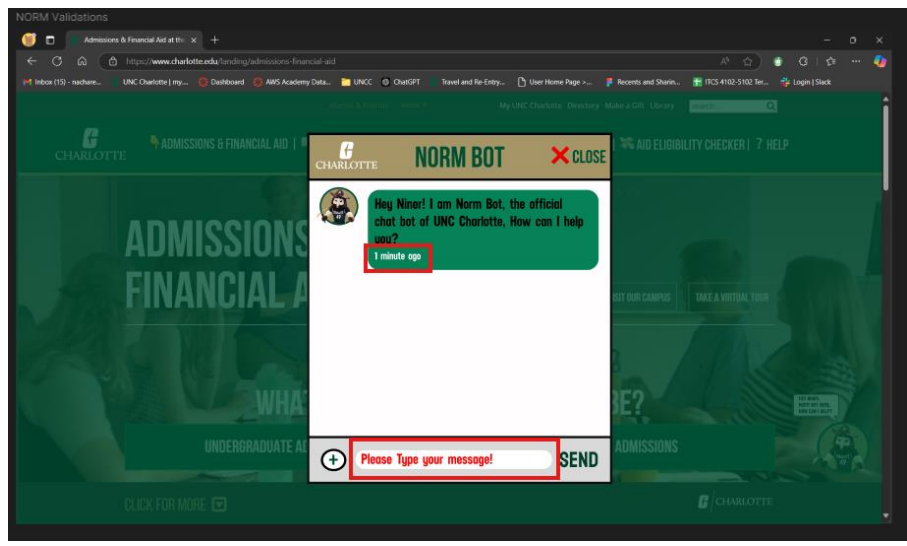


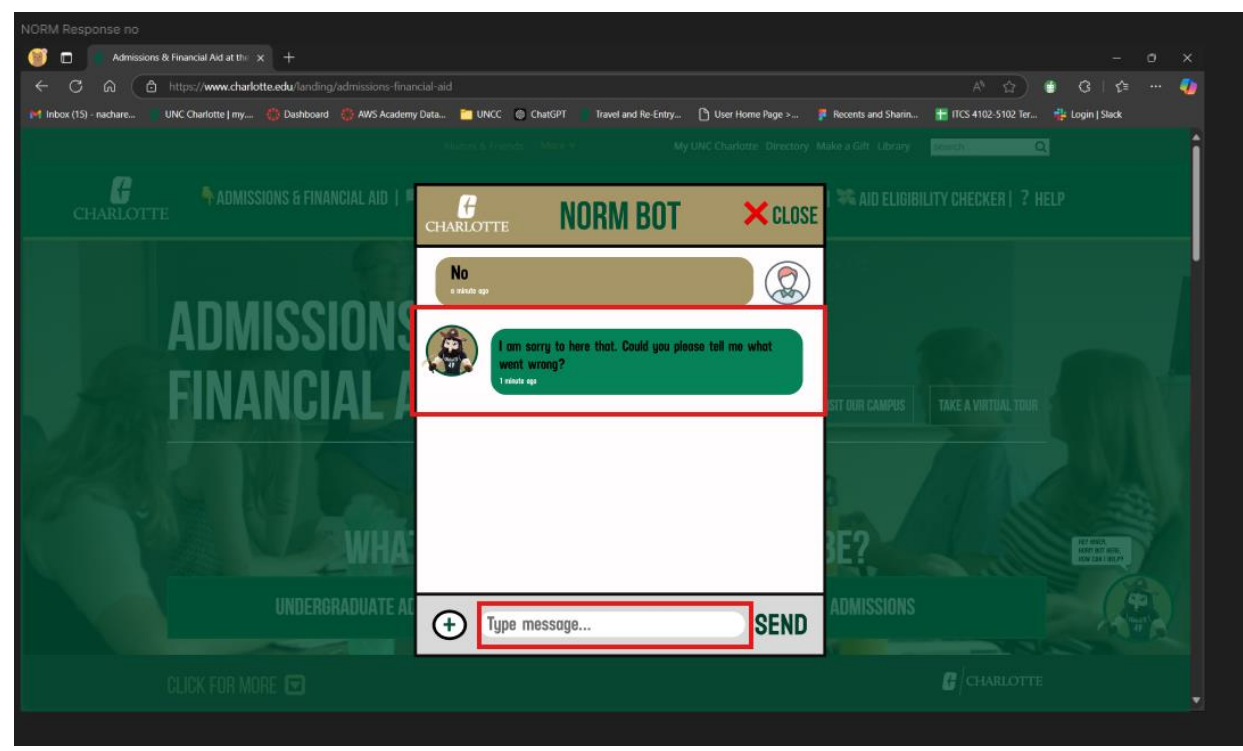
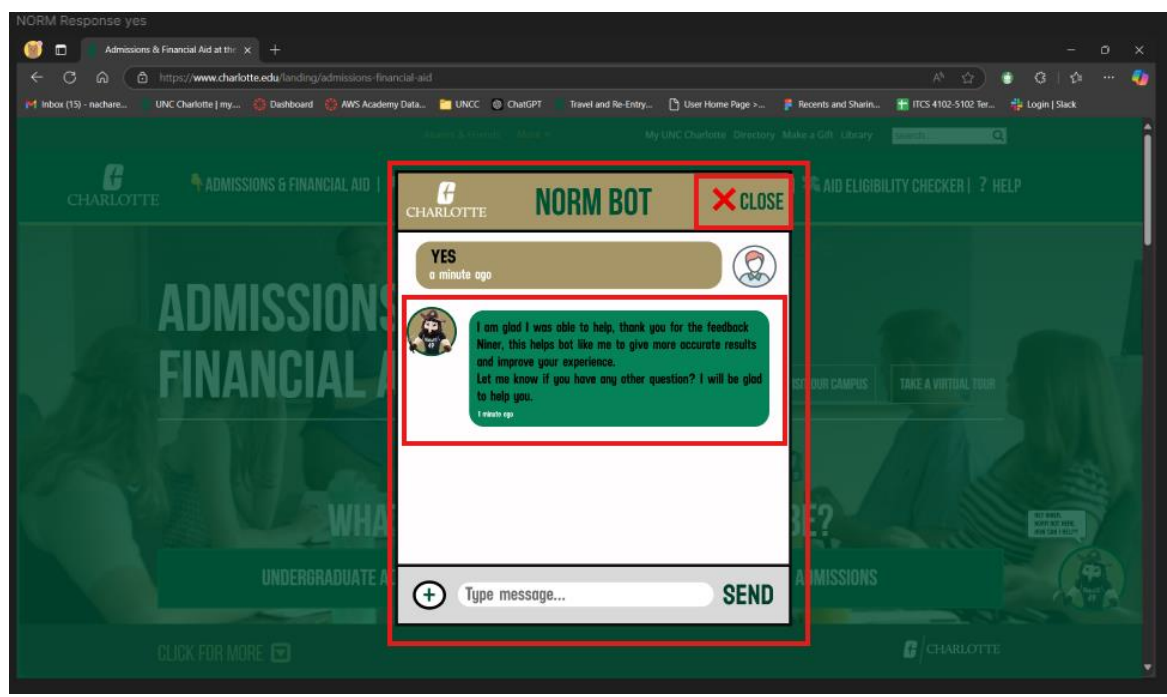
2. **Annotation:** The live chat feature gives support for users for additional questions and answers.

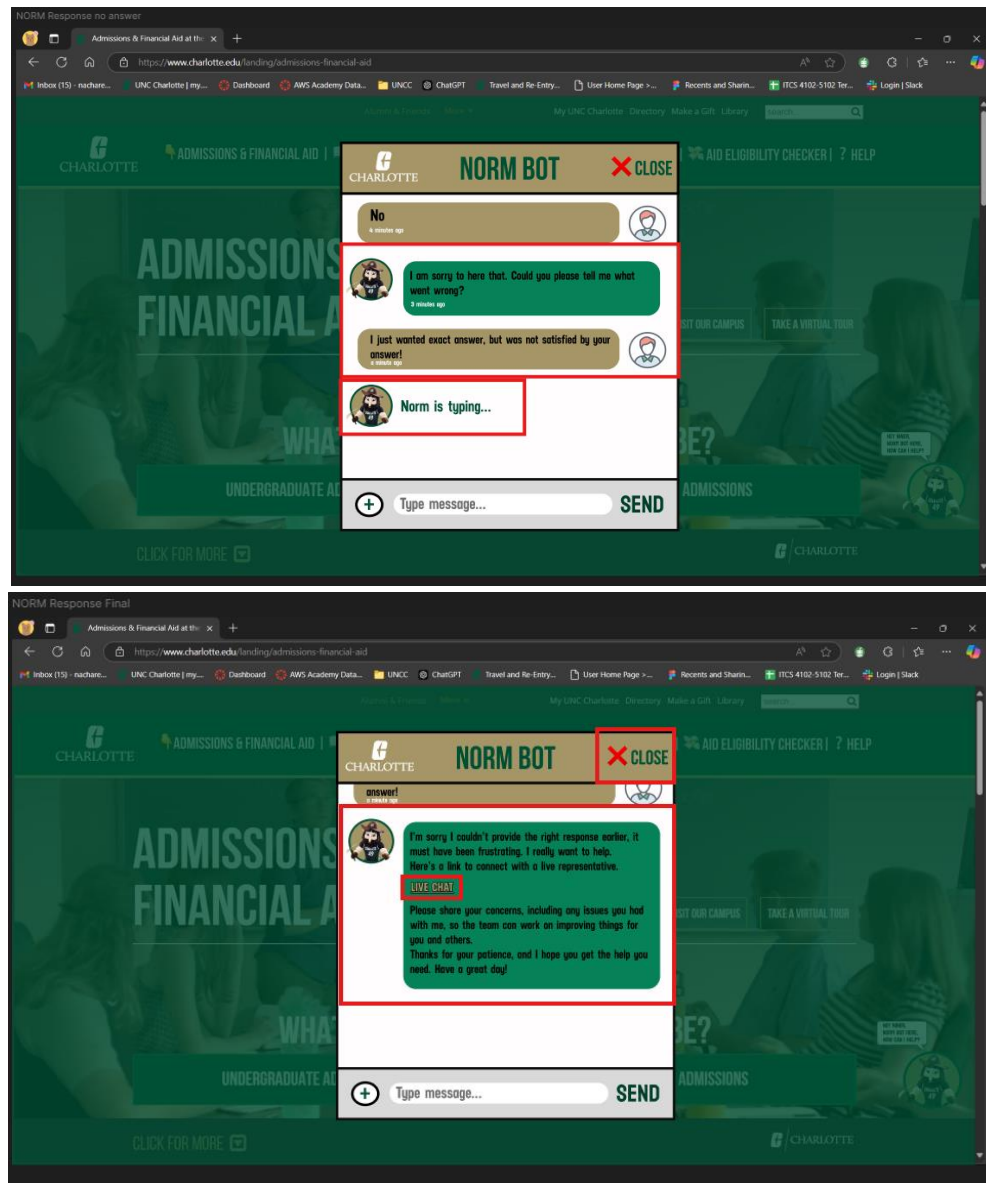
iv. Norm Bot Interface:

1. **Screenshot:** Below is an image of the interface of the chatbot.









2. **Annotation:** It provides fast, automated responses which link back to relevant resources. Users have the ability to provide feedback to improve interactions in the future.

c. Changes Description:

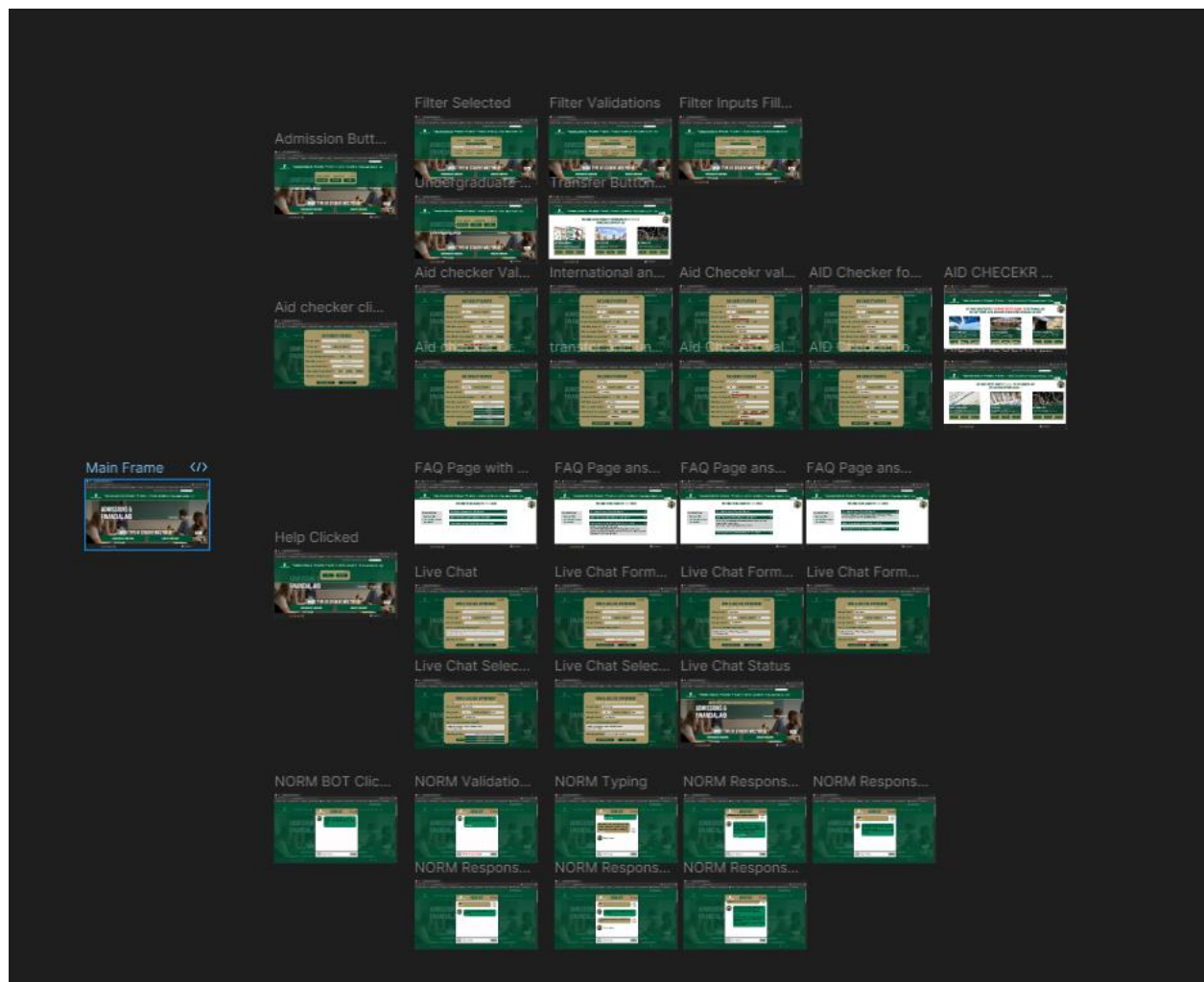
- i. **Help Menu:** Implementing a dropdown in the navigation bar that directly links to the FAQs and live chat.
- ii. **FAQ:** Clickable-Linked answers to the relevant sections of the site for ease of navigation.
- iii. **Live Chat:** If user finds something confusing and wants a guide the live chat provides the ease and helps user on a right track.

- iv. **Chatbot Enhancements:** Included feedback and fall back on cases when certain queries could not be resolved.

d. Improvements and Refinements:

- i. **Real-Time Support:** The facility of real-time resolution of queries through live chat or chatbot for the users.
- ii. **Guided Navigation:** The FAQs serve in a way as a kind of signpost that links users to other resources.
- iii. **Continuous Improvement:** Norm Bot's feedback mechanism ensures it changes with the input it gets from its users.

Chapter 6: Interactive High-Fidelity Prototype:



The image shows several frames created. Here is the [Figma link](#).

1. **Prototype Quality:** The interactive high-fidelity prototype is the live version of the redesigned website, with all features and solutions regarding user needs that it had in mind. Every part of the prototype saliently brings forth how functionality, interactivity, and navigation would be effortless. Based on Ritu's persona as a guide, the design would ensure that for any prospect students, the website must be attractive, factual, and easy to navigate.

A. Functionality and Interactivity:

▪ Improved Navigation:

- This navigation bar contains drop-down selections for "Admissions & Financial Aid" that allow a user to select their student type from Undergraduate, Transfer, and International, which then send them directly to the page they need.
- Navbar integrated filter button allowing users to dynamically filter search results. Page validation ensures users have at least one filter selected before continuing.

▪ Aid Eligibility Checker:

- This interactive tool involves user-generated results. Among the fields users fill in are student type, program, first-generation status, and more with validation to guide correct entries.
- Depending on their eligibility, users move to a page offering resources applicable to them, such as how to apply for FASFA or scholarships, as well as other options for third-party aid.

▪ Support Features (FAQs and Live Chat):

- A dedicated "Help" button in the navbar opens a dropdown menu with options for FAQs and live chat.
- The FAQ section shows interactive sections that one can click to show the answers, which link to relevant pages.
- The option to perform live chat would include a scheduling form with field validation, so users could book an appointment with university representatives.

▪ Norm Bot Chatbot:

- Norm Bot is available on every page to automatically respond to user queries; it also checks user responses for mistakes asks feedback and refers them to live chat in case something is not resolved.

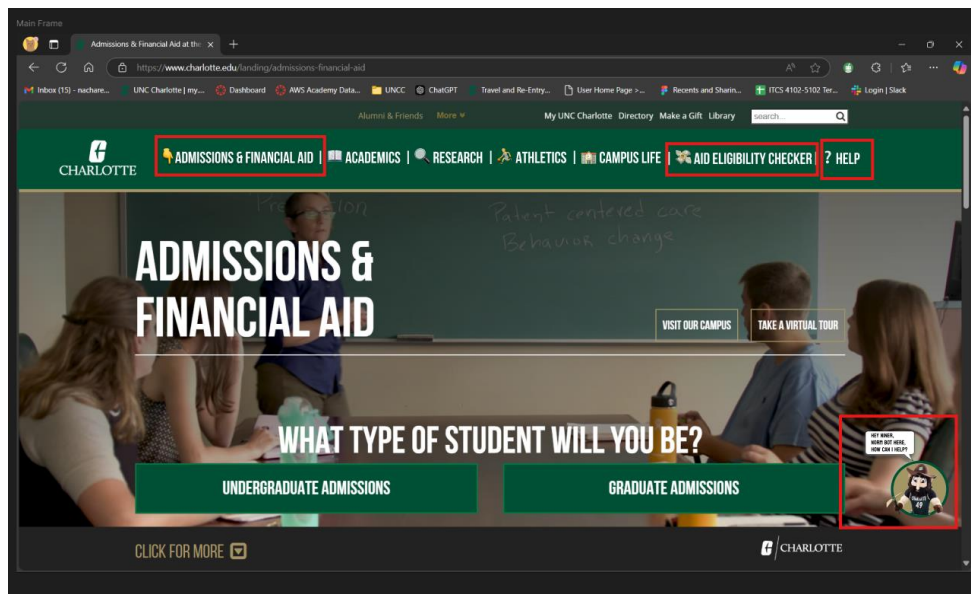
B. User-Friendly Navigation:

- The prototype promotes intuitive navigation with dropdown menus and filters reducing the click distance toward critical information.
- Visual enhancements such as emojis and hover effects (here the selected button is underlined) direct users to where they want to go. Information is chunked into, and delivered in, more crisp, easy-to-understand pieces, which reduces overwhelm and enhances usability.

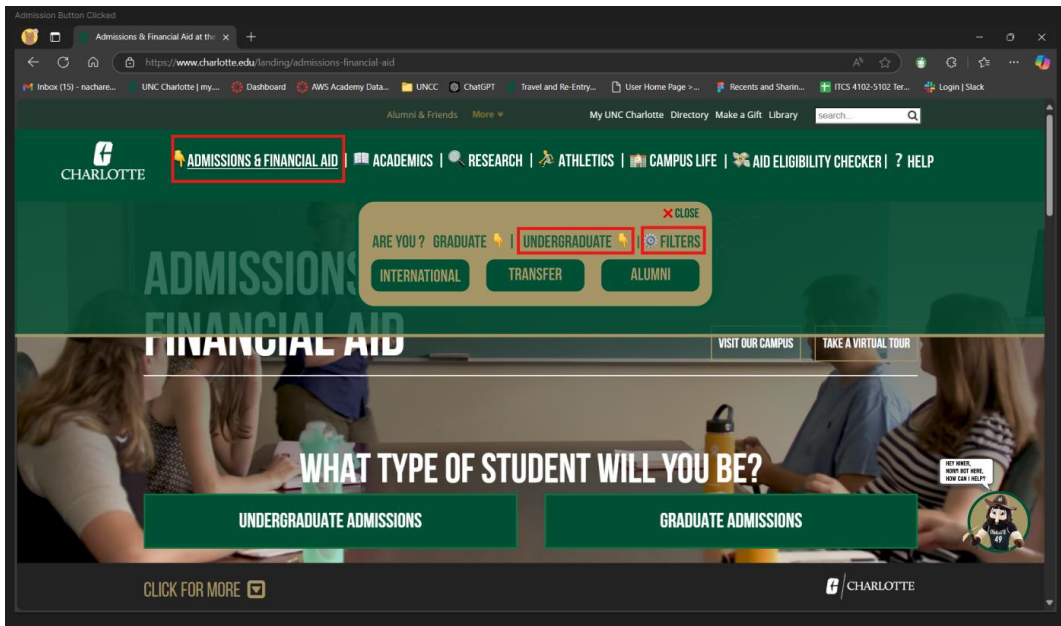
2. Instructions for Interacting with the Prototype:

A. Accessing the Navigation System:

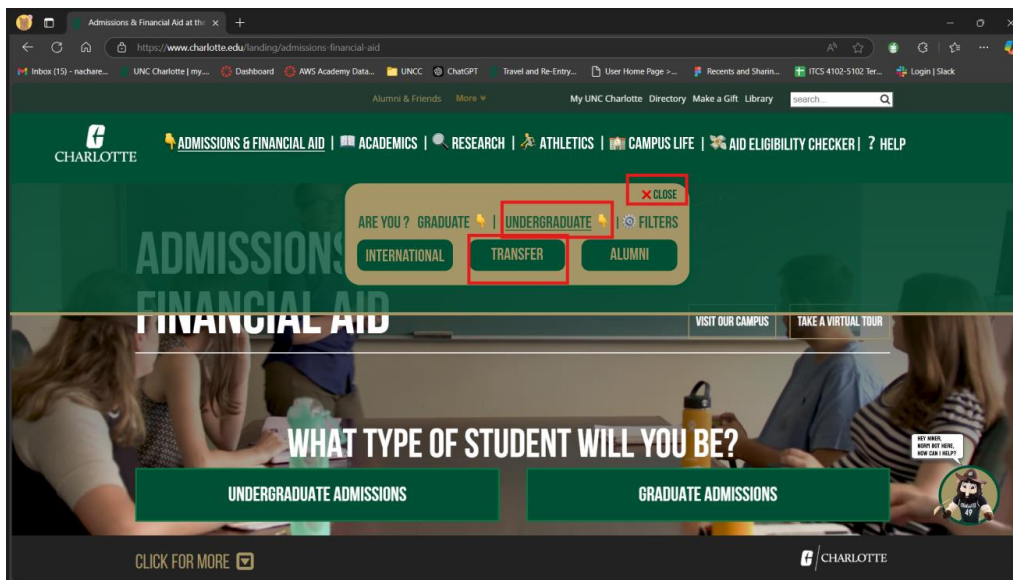
- Our main page has an enhanced navbar and each of the buttons has emojis to enhance the visual aspect also our norm bot is present on every page as we navigate. Right now buttons like **“Admissions & Financial Aid”**, **“Help”** and **“Aid Eligibility Checker”** are functional.



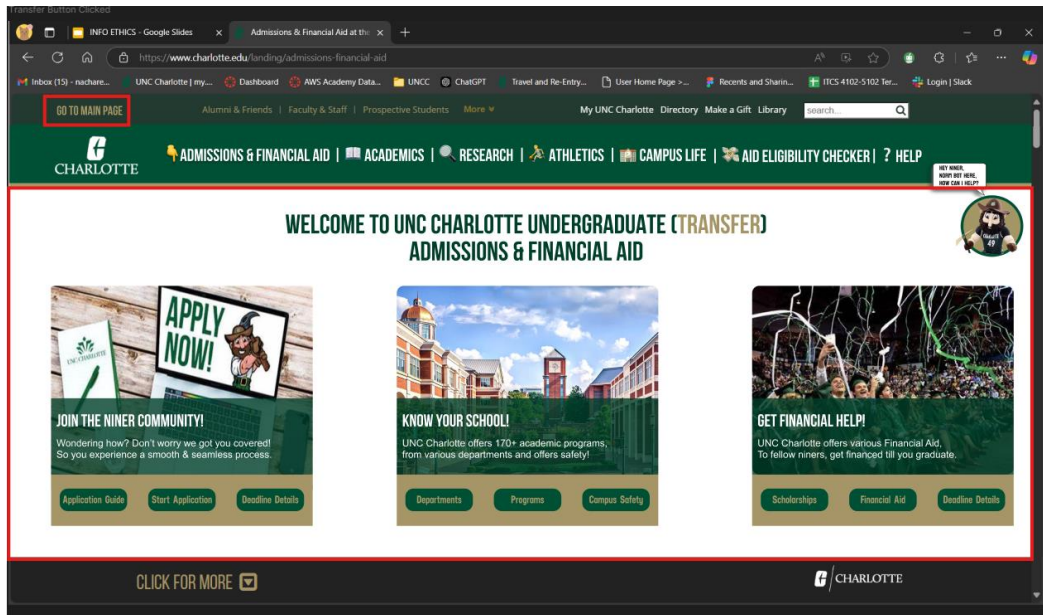
- Now we will click on the **“Admissions & Financial Aid”** button first. Note that the button gets underlined which means that the button is currently selected. Also here if you click on the **“Close”** button it will take you to the home page. Also here **“Undergraduate”** and **“Filter”** button are functional.



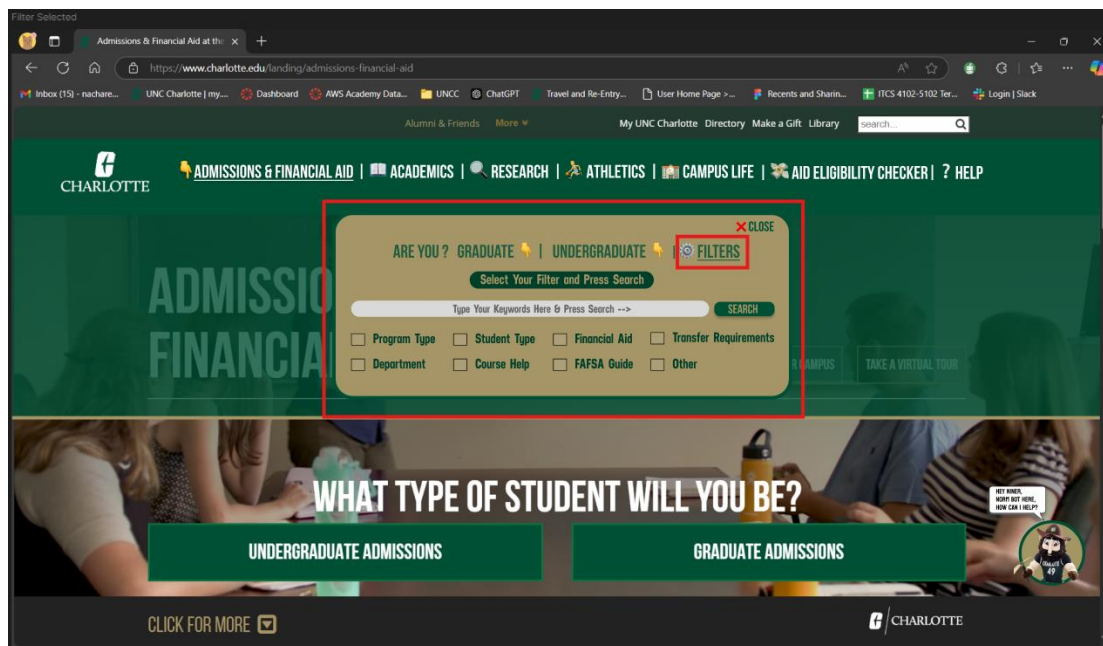
- We will click the “Undergraduate” section first, note it gets underlined showing that it is selected. We have three buttons in which the “Transfer” button is functional.



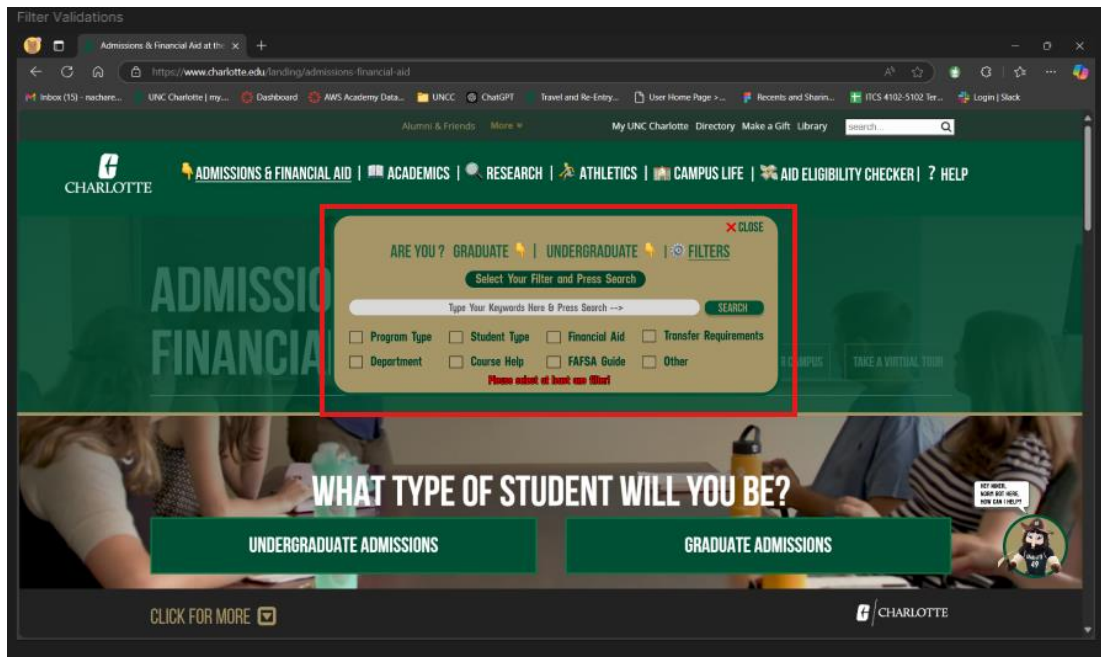
- If you click on the “Transfer” button it will take you to the Undergraduate Transfer dashboard. (As our targeted persona is a prospective undergraduate transfer student the dashboard is dedicated according to the student type.) If you click on “Go to Main Page” it takes you to the home page.



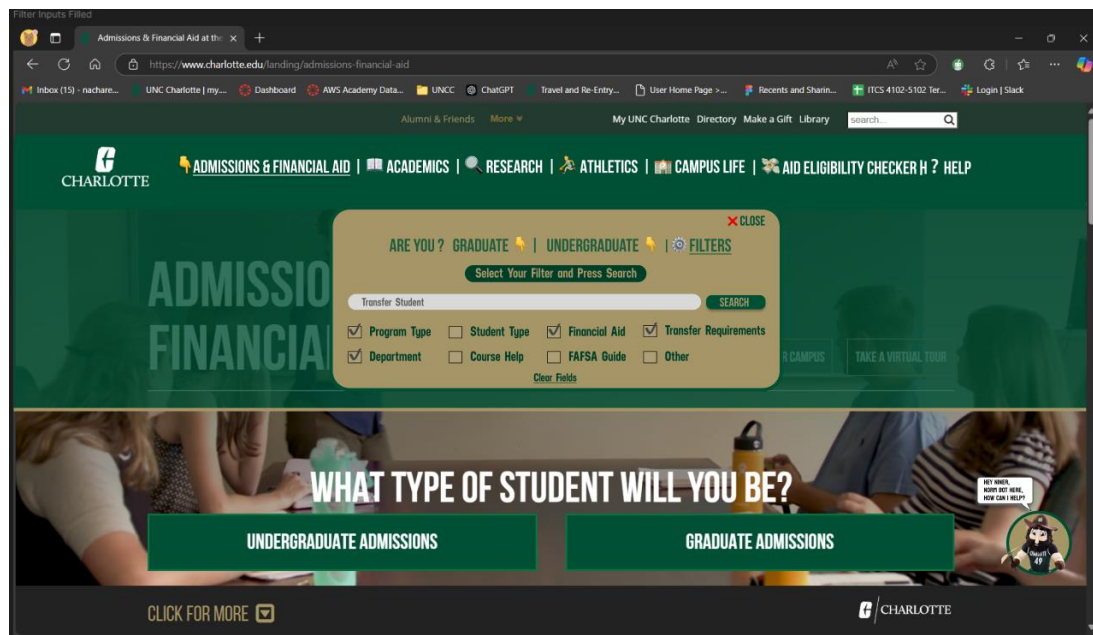
- Now repeat the above steps but this time select the **“Filters”** option, once selected it shows menu which has a search bar to type any keywords and some filters given to select.

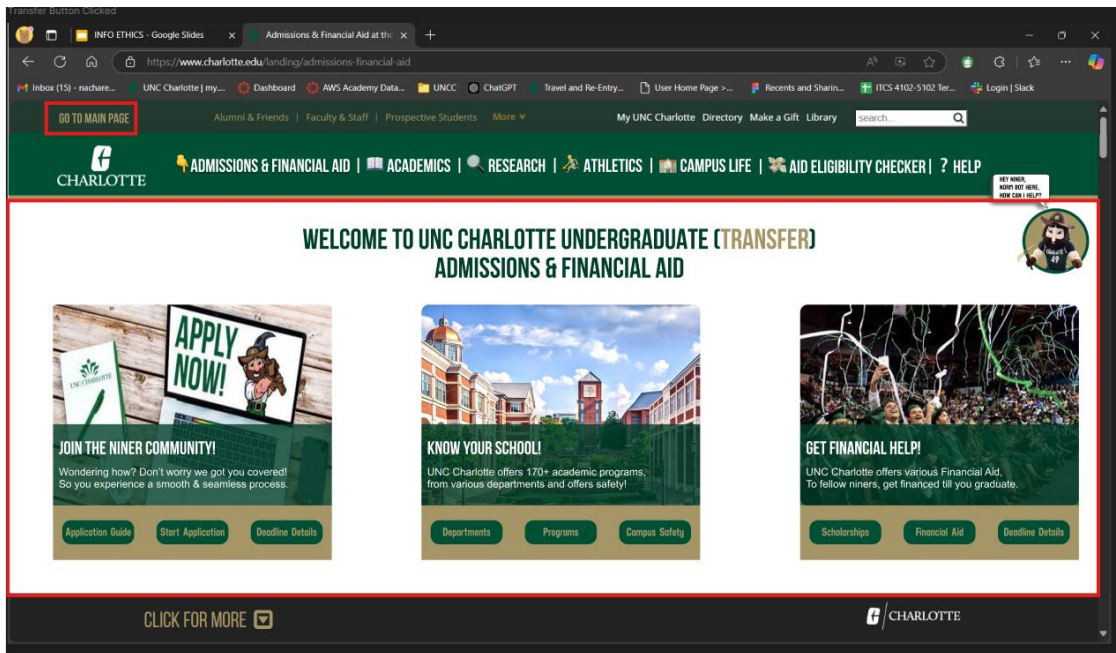


- If you press the **“Search”** button without selecting any filters or typing in the search bar it will give you form validation error. So select at least one filter to move to the desired page.



- Click on “**Search bar**” as this will select the filters and add a keyword. The “**Clear Fields**” button will clear all the fields. Now if press the “**Search**” button it will lead you to the transfer student page.





B. Using the Aid Eligibility Checker:

- Coming back to the Home Page, Click on the “**Aid Eligibility Checker**” button, you can see the button gets highlighted, once clicked on the button a form opens asking for various details.

AID ELIGIBILITY CHECKER

Enter your name: * Type your full name here!

Enter your age: * Country of Origin?: * Enter your Country!

Enter your email-id: * Enter a valid email-id!

Are you a First Generation Student?: * ☐ YES ☐ NO

Which Major are you in?: * Type your Major!

Select your Student Status?: * Select one status only! ⚡

Which Semester are you Starting?: * ☐ FALL ☐ SPRING ☐ SUMMER

What Kind of Student are you?: * Select one type of student only! ⚡

- If you click on “**Check Eligibility**” without typing anything, it will give you a validation to enter all the details.

AID ELIGIBILITY CHECKER

Enter your name:

Enter your age: Country of Origin?:

Enter your email-id:

Are you a First Generation Student?: ☐ YES ☐ NO

Which Major are you in?:

Select your Student Status?:

Which Semester are you Starting?: ☐ FALL ☐ SPRING ☐ SUMMER

What Kind of Student are you?:

PLEASE ENTER ALL VALID VALUES TO CONTINUE

CHECK ELIGIBILITY !! **CLEAR FIELD'S**

- Now we have two drop-down menus, In select your student status, we have two buttons that are interactive which are **“Transfer”** and **“International”**. The second drop-down lets you choose the kind of student you are in that **“Undergraduate”** is functional now.

AID ELIGIBILITY CHECKER

Enter your name:

Enter your age: Country of Origin?:

Enter your email-id:

Are you a First Generation Student?: ☐ YES ☐ NO

Which Major are you in?:

Select your Student Status?:

Which Semester are you Starting?: ☐ FALL ☐ SPRING ☐ SUMMER

What Kind of Student are you?:

CHECK ELIGIBILITY !!

- So, click on the **“Transfer”** drop-down menu button. It will show you the form filled out.

- If you press the “**Check Eligibility**” button it will give some errors or form validation to type the correct email and select one of the radio buttons, The “**Fall**” radio button is functional click on that or click on the “**email-id**”. This will lead you to the correct and filled form.

- Now if you click on “**Close**” it will close the form and bring you to the main page. If you click on “**Clear Fields**” it will reset the form. But Click on the “**Check Eligibility**” button this will take you to the eligible page.

AID Checker form filled correct transfer

Admissions & Financial Aid at the University of North Carolina at Charlotte

AID ELIGIBILITY CHECKER [CLOSE]

Enter your name: * Nishant Acharekar

Enter your age: * 24 Country of Origin?: * INDIA

Enter your email-id: * nishant@gmail.com

Are you a First Generation Student?: * ☒ YES ☐ NO

Which Major are you in?: * Computer Science

Select your Student Status?: * TRANSFER

Which Semester are you Starting?: * ☒ FALL ☐ SPRING ☐ SUMMER

What Kind of Student are you?: * UNDERGRADUATE

CHECK ELIGIBILITY !! **CLEAR FIELD'S**

AID CHECKER ELIGIBLE

GO TO MAIN PAGE | Alumni & Friends | Faculty & Staff | Prospective Students | More » | My UNC Charlotte | Directory | Make a Gift | Library | Search

ADMISSIONS & FINANCIAL AID | ACADEMICS | RESEARCH | ATHLETICS | CAMPUS LIFE | AID ELIGIBILITY CHECKER | ? HELP

HEY NINER YOU'RE DIRECTLY ELIGIBLE TO THE FINANCIAL AID!
EXPLORE SOME OPTIONS BELOW

COMPLETE YOUR FAFSA ASAP!
What is the FAFSA form?
2023-2024
What is the FAFSA form?
Wondering how? Don't worry we got you covered!
We have a video guide & requirements section to get started, with before actual application.

FAFSA Guide | Start Application | Requirements

GET STATE AID!
Want to know which aid to apply?
Don't worry niner we have some options below!

Out-State Aid | In-State Aid | Other

GET FINANCIAL HELP!
UNC Charlotte offers various Financial Aid.
To fellow niners, get financed till you graduate.

Scholarships | Financial Aid | Deadline Details

CLICK FOR MORE

- Now if you go back to the form, and this time if you select “International” in the student status section and press the “**Check Eligibility**” button this will take you to the not eligible page. If you want to go to main page, press “**Go to Main Page**”.

The image shows two screenshots of the UNC Charlotte website's financial aid section. The top screenshot displays the 'AID ELIGIBILITY CHECKER' form, which is a modal window with a green header and a white body. The form contains the following fields and options:

- Enter your name:*** Nishant Acharekar
- Enter your age:*** 24 **Country of Origin?:*** INDIA
- Enter your email-id:*** nishant@gmail.com
- Are you a First Generation Student?:*** ☒ YES ☐ NO
- Which Major are you in?:*** Computer Science
- Select your Student Status?:*** INTERNATIONAL
- Which Semester are you Starting?:*** ☒ FALL ☐ SPRING ☐ SUMMER
- What Kind of Student are you?:*** UNDERGRADUATE

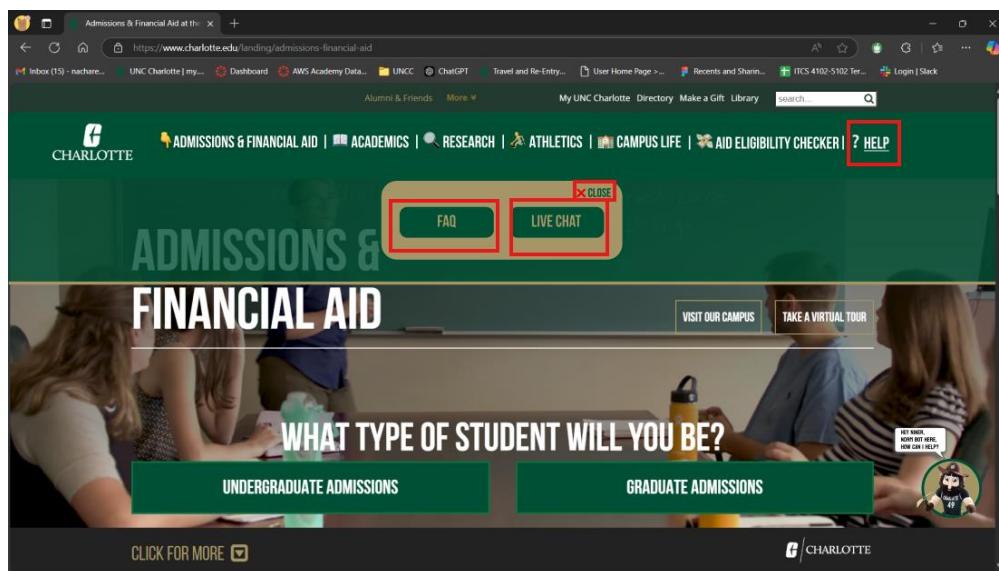
At the bottom of the form are two buttons: 'CHECK ELIGIBILITY !!' and 'CLEAR FIELD'S'. The bottom screenshot shows the result page, titled 'AID CHECKER NOT ELIGIBLE'. It features a green header with the UNC Charlotte logo and navigation links. The main content area has a green background with white text that reads: 'HEY NINER UNFORTUNATELY YOU'RE NOT DIRECTLY ELIGIBLE TO THE FINANCIAL AID! BUT DON'T WORRY AS WE HAVE MANY OTHER OPTIONS AVAILABLE FOR YOU!!!'. Below this text are three columns of options, each with an image and a button:

- EXPLORE 3RD PARTY AIDS!** (Image of a modern building) with buttons: '3rd Party Aid', 'Sponsor Details', 'Other Options'.
- APPLY FOR SCHOLARSHIPS!** (Image of a brick building) with buttons: 'Guide & Details', 'Apply Here', 'Check Deadlines'.
- APPLY FOR USA STUDENT LOANS!** (Image of a graduation cap and money) with buttons: 'Loan Partners', 'Apply for Loan', 'Loan Details'.

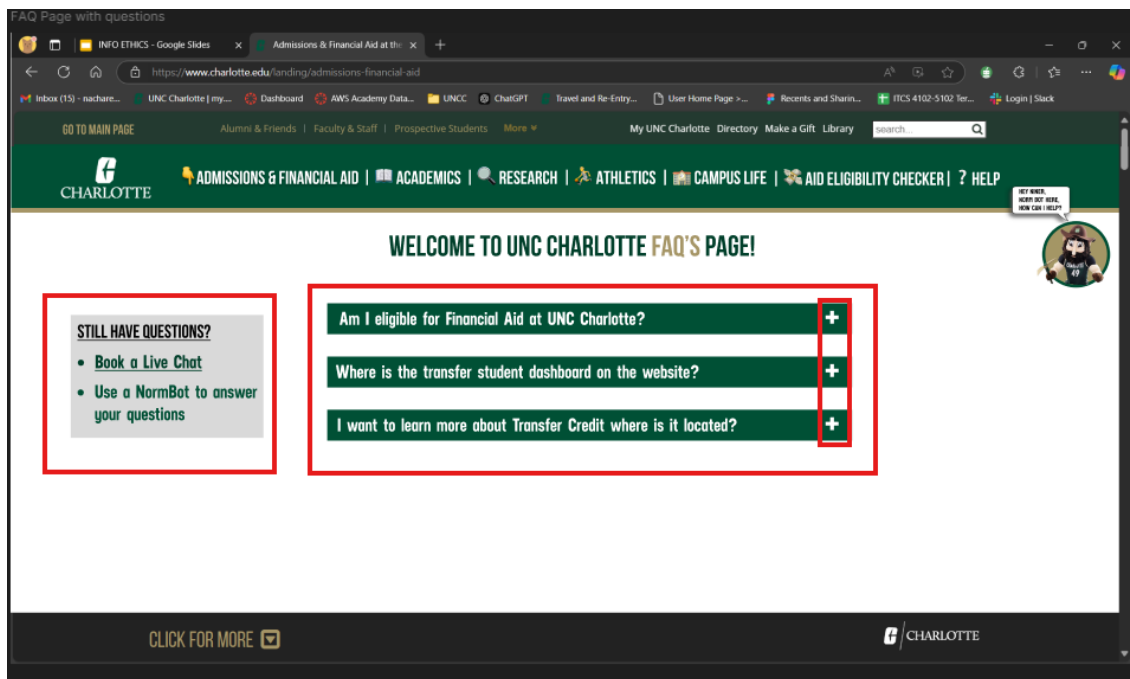
At the bottom of the result page is a 'CLICK FOR MORE' button and the UNC Charlotte logo.

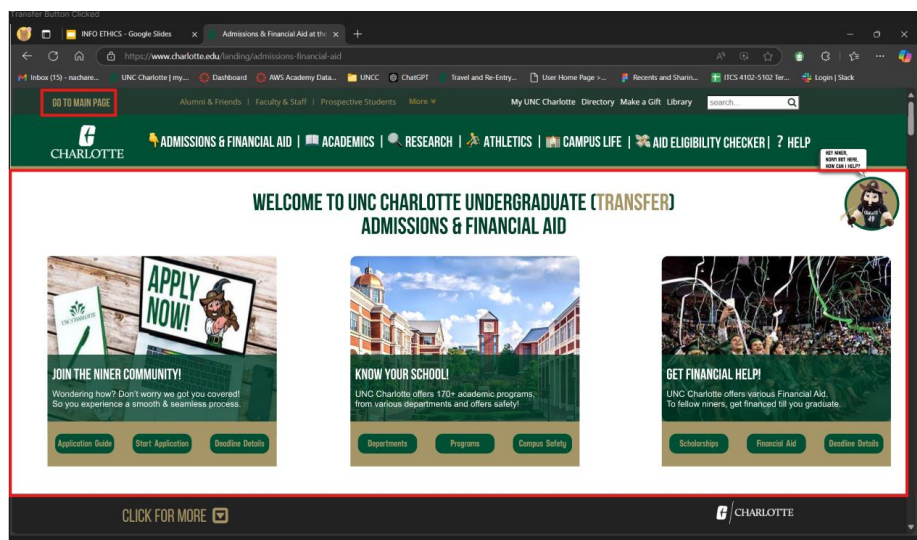
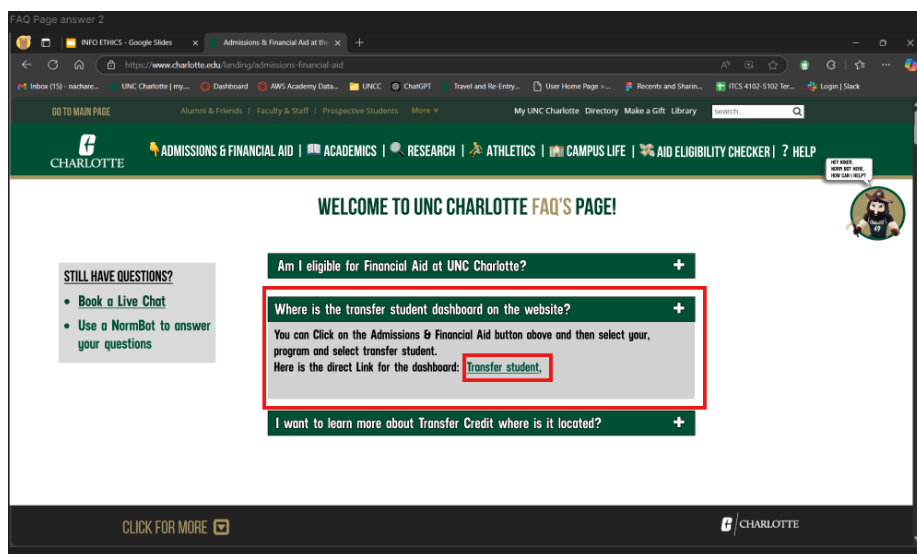
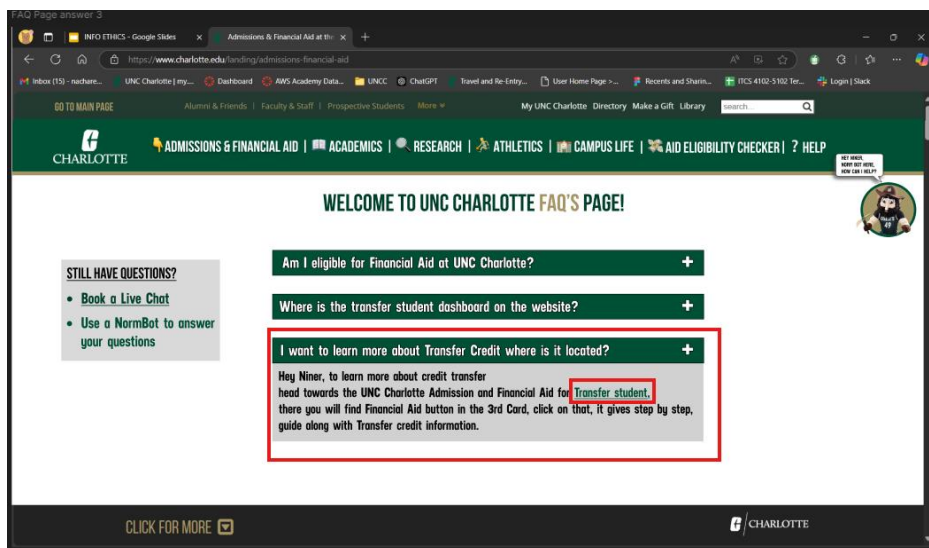
C. Exploring the FAQ Section:

- To open the FAQ page, click on the “**Help**” button on the navbar. This will expand the navbar and will show the menu which has two buttons, “**FAQ**” and “**Live Chat**”. Press on the “**FAQ**” button.

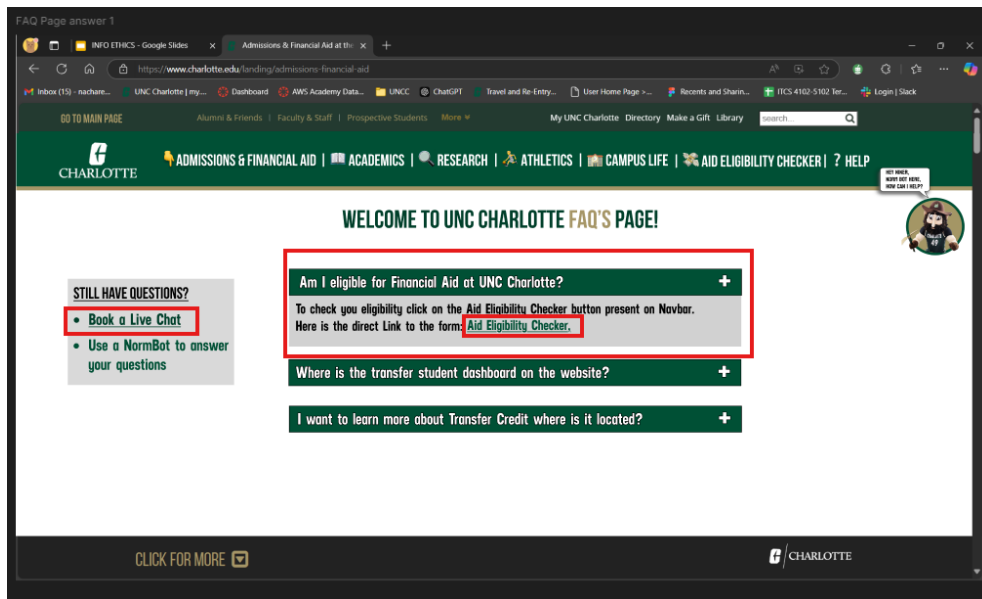


- As you are on the FAQ page, you have three questions displayed. You can click on the “+” icon to see the answer to any of the listed questions.





- Each question has a link to a page. As you can see in answer 1, clicking on **“Aid Eligibility Checker”** will take you to that form. On the left side, you have an option to **“Book a Live Chat”** This will open the Live Chat appointment form.



BOOK A LIVE CHAT APPOINTMENT
Get all your questions answered by our representative!

Enter your name:* Type your full name here!

Enter your age:* Type age! Country of Origin?:* Enter your Country!

Enter your email-id:* Enter a valid email-id!

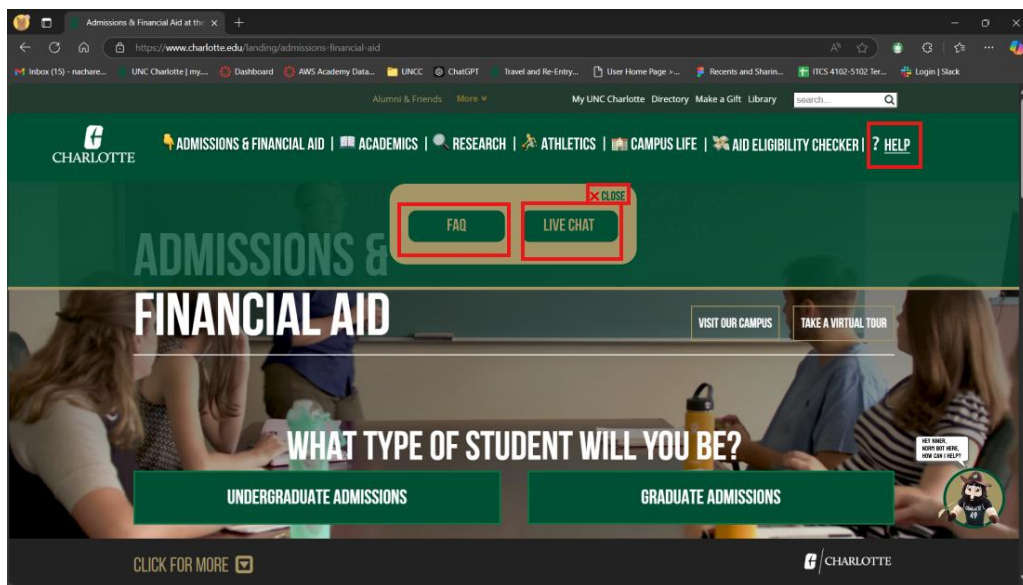
Give us a bit Information About yourself?:*
Type: Which Semester you are enrolled in and the program and major, Also type your student status (International, Transfer, Alumni)....

Select Date and Time:* Select from available Date and Time!

[BOOK APPOINTMENT !](#) [CLEAR FIELD'S](#)

D. Scheduling a Live Chat:

- To open the “Live Chat” from the home page, click on the “Help” button on the navbar and then select “Live Chat”. This will open the form for booking the live chat form.



Live Chat

Admissions & Financial Aid at the...

https://www.charlotte.edu/landing/admissions-financial-aid

Index (15) - natchar... UNC Charlotte | my... Dashboard AWS Academy Data... UNCC ChatGPT Travel and Re-Entry... User Home Page >... Recents and Share... ITCS 4102-5102 Ter... Login | Slack

My UNC Charlotte Directory Make a Gift Library

BOOK A LIVE CHAT APPOINTMENT

Get all your questions answered by our representative!

Enter your name:* Type your full name here!

Enter your age:* Type age! Country of Origin?:* Enter your Country!

Enter your email-id:* Enter a valid email-id!

Give us a bit Information About yourself?:*

Type: Which Semester you are enrolled in and the program and major, Also type your student status (International, Transfer, Alumni)....

Select Date and Time:* Select from available Date and Time!

BOOK APPOINTMENT ! CLEAR FIELD'S

CLICK FOR MORE

CHARLOTTE

- If you click on **“Book Appointment”** without entering any fields, it will give you some errors along with form validation.

Live Chat Form Validations

Admissions & Financial Aid at the...

https://www.charlotte.edu/landing/admissions-financial-aid

Index (15) - natchar... UNC Charlotte | my... Dashboard AWS Academy Data... UNCC ChatGPT Travel and Re-Entry... User Home Page >... Recents and Share... ITCS 4102-5102 Ter... Login | Slack

My UNC Charlotte Directory Make a Gift Library

BOOK A LIVE CHAT APPOINTMENT

Get all your questions answered by our representative!

Enter your name:* Type your full name here!

Enter your age:* Type age! Country of Origin?:* Enter your Country!

Enter your email-id:* Enter a valid email-id!

Give us a bit Information About yourself?:*

Type: Which Semester you are enrolled in and the program and major, Also type your student status (International, Transfer, Alumni)....

Select Date and Time:* Select from available Date and Time!

PLEASE ENTER ALL YOUR FIELDS TO CONTINUE

BOOK APPOINTMENT ! CLEAR FIELD'S

CLICK FOR MORE

CHARLOTTE

- Now Click on the dropdown menu where you have to select the date and time, if you don't select any date then it will give you error and a validation. If you click on the drop down menu you have three dates available, current **“Dec 02, 2024”** button is working, Click on that.

Live Chat Form 50% Validations

Admissions & Financial Aid at the University of North Carolina at Charlotte

BOOK A LIVE CHAT APPOINTMENT

Get all your questions answered by our representative!

Enter your name:* Nishant Acharekar

Enter your age:* 24 Country of Origin?:* INDIA

Enter your email-id:* nishant@gmail.com

Give us a bit Information About yourself?:*

Fall 2025, Graduate Program for Masters in Information Technology,
I am an International Student.

Select Date and Time:* Select from available Date and Time! ⚡

PLEASE AT LEAST SELECT A DATE AND TIME!

BOOK APPOINTMENT! CLEAR FIELD'S

Live Chat Select Date Drop Down

Admissions & Financial Aid at the University of North Carolina at Charlotte

BOOK A LIVE CHAT APPOINTMENT

Get all your questions answered by our representative!

Enter your name:* Nishant Acharekar

Enter your age:* 24 Country of Origin?:* INDIA

Enter your email-id:* nishant@gmail.com

Give us a bit Information About yourself?:*

Fall 2025, Graduate Program for Masters in Information Technology,
I am an International Student.

Select Date and Time:* Select from available Date and Time! ⚡

DECEMBER 02, 2024 | 11:30 AM EST

DECEMBER 04, 2024 | 10:30 AM EST

DECEMBER 06, 2024 | 02:00 PM EST

BOOK A P...

- Once clicked it shows you the full form. You can also “Clear the details” to clear the form. If satisfied press the “Book Appointment” button.

Live Chat Selected a Date

Admissions & Financial Aid at the

BOOK A LIVE CHAT APPOINTMENT

Get all your questions answered by our representative!

Enter your name:* Nishant Acharekar

Enter your age:* 24 Country of Origin?:* INDIA

Enter your email-id:* nishant@gmail.com

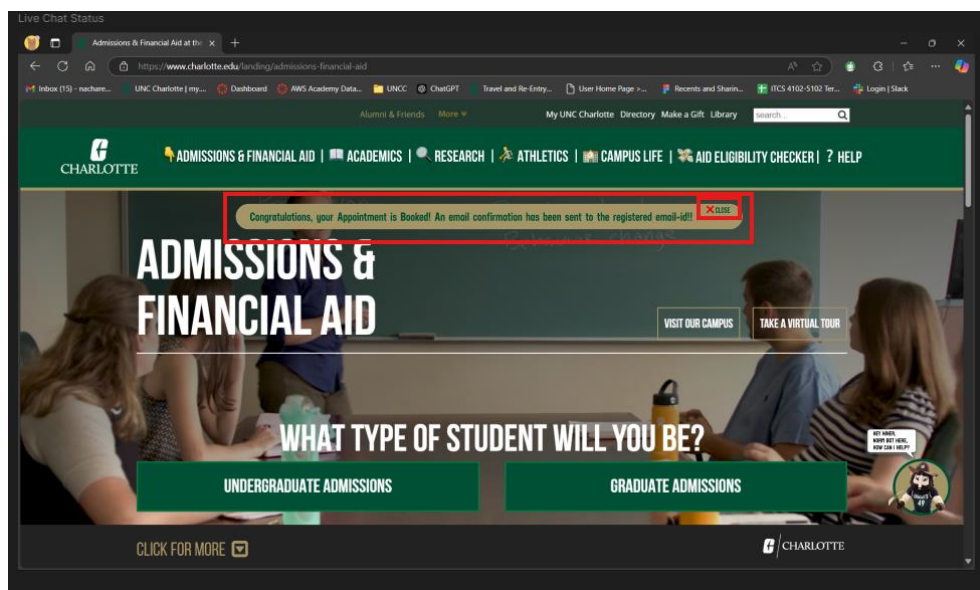
Give us a bit Information About yourself?:*

Fall 2025, Graduate Program for Masters in Information Technology.
I am an International Student.

Select Date and Time:* December 02, 2024 | 11:30 AM EST

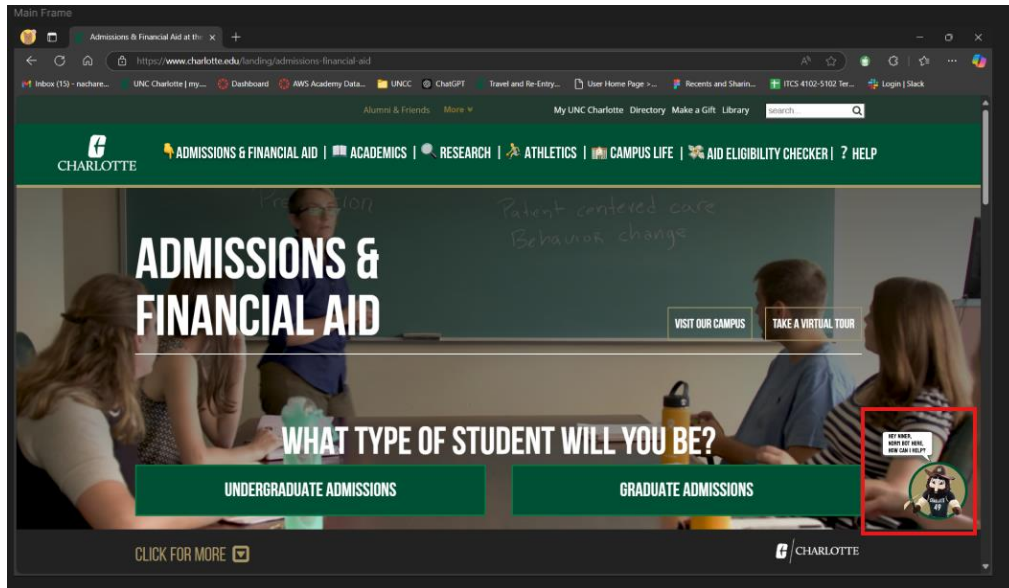
BOOK APPOINTMENT CLEAR FIELD'S

- Once clicked it shows a confirmation message on the home page that the appointment has been booked successfully. You can close the notification by pressing the “Close” button.

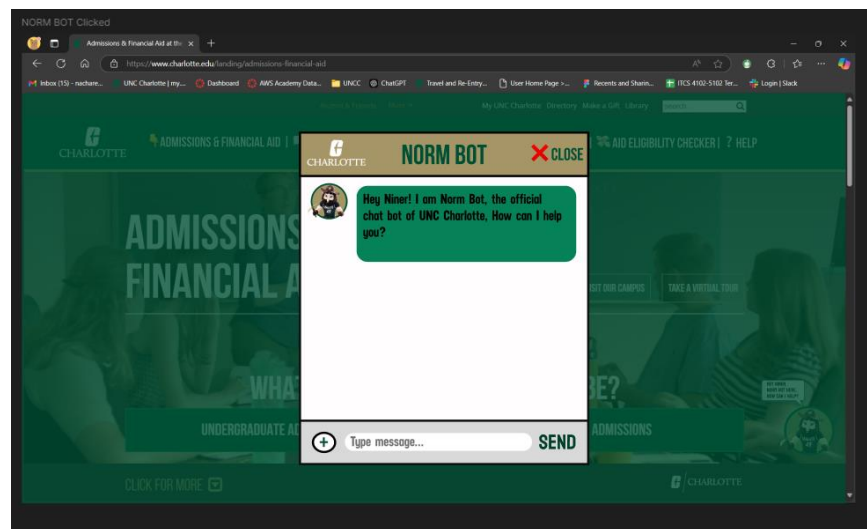


E. Engaging with Norm Bot:

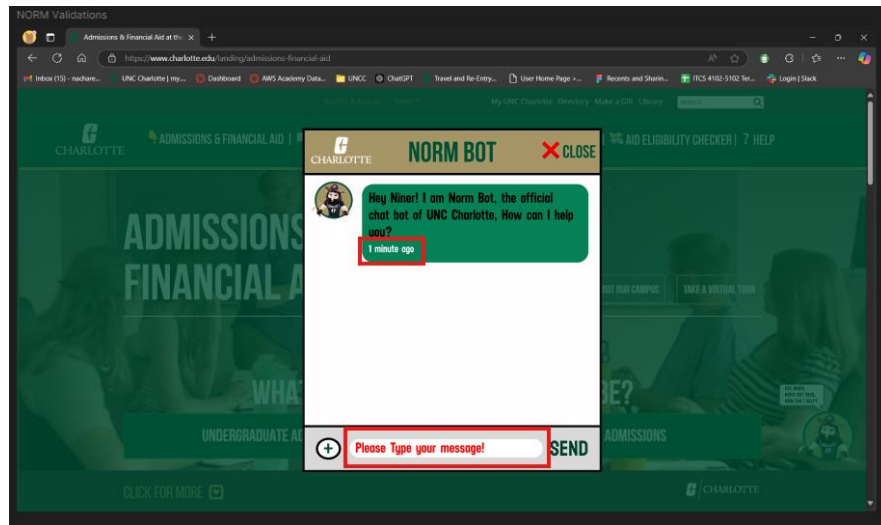
- You can access the Norm bot our chatbot from any page of the website. Right now on the home page on the bottom right corner, we have a small bot icon showing “Norm bot icon” click on it.



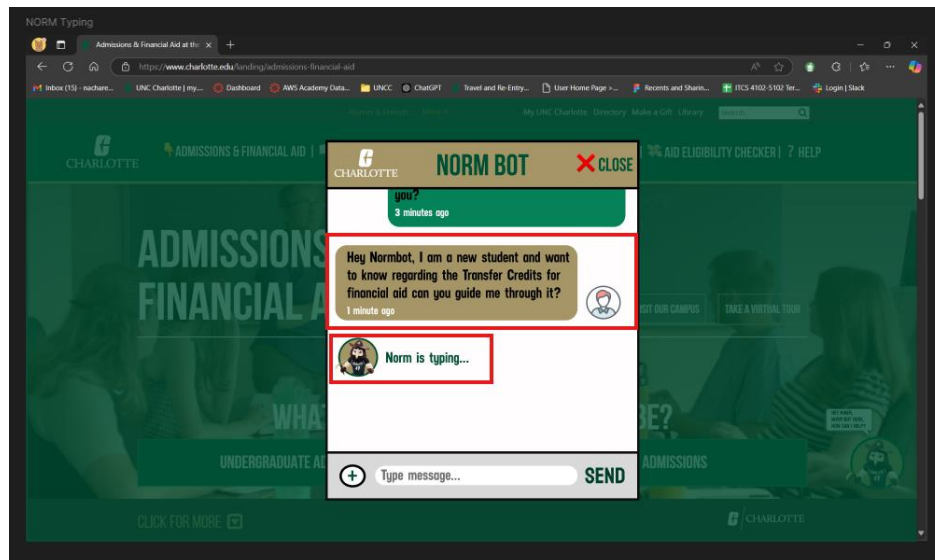
- This will open the Chatbot window. If you click on the “Send” button without asking the question the bot will ask you to type a question.



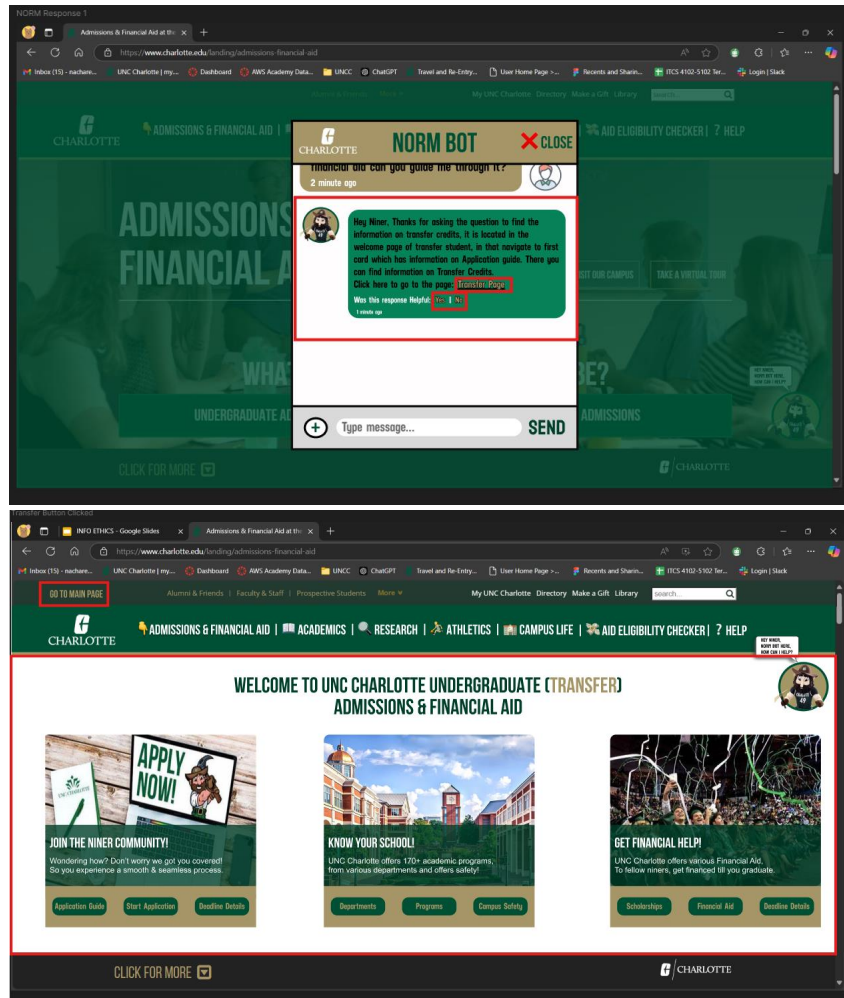
- Click on the “type message.” This will take you to the question asked.



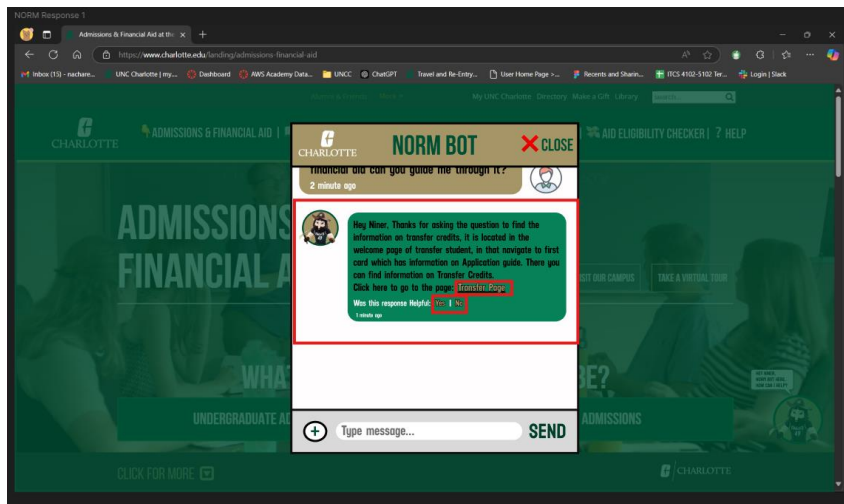
- Now click on “Norm is typing” to get the answer.

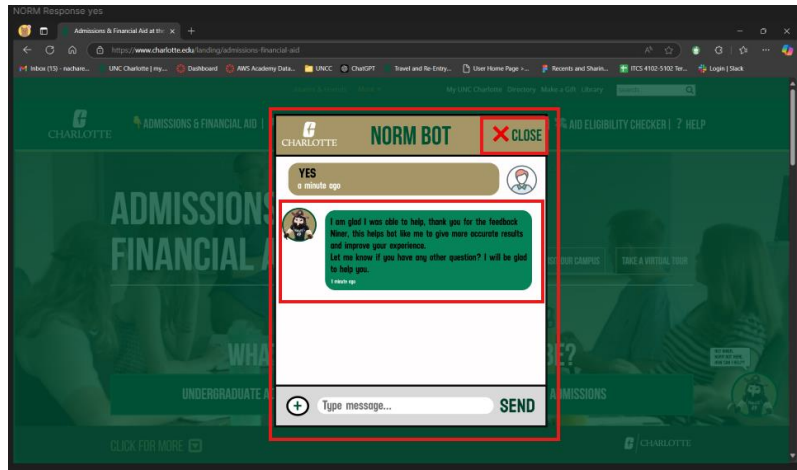


- The norm bot gives an answer with the page link, clicking on that link will take you to the desired page.

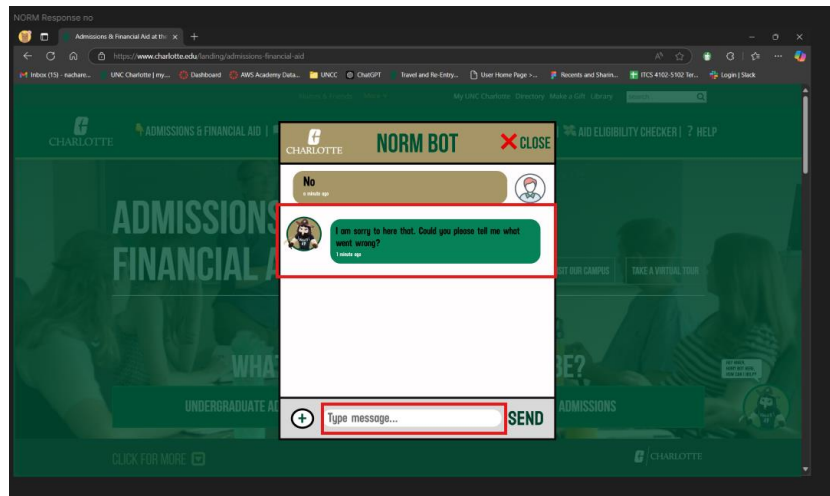


- You may have noticed that the bot is asking for Feedback, if you click “yes” the bot will thank you for the feedback.

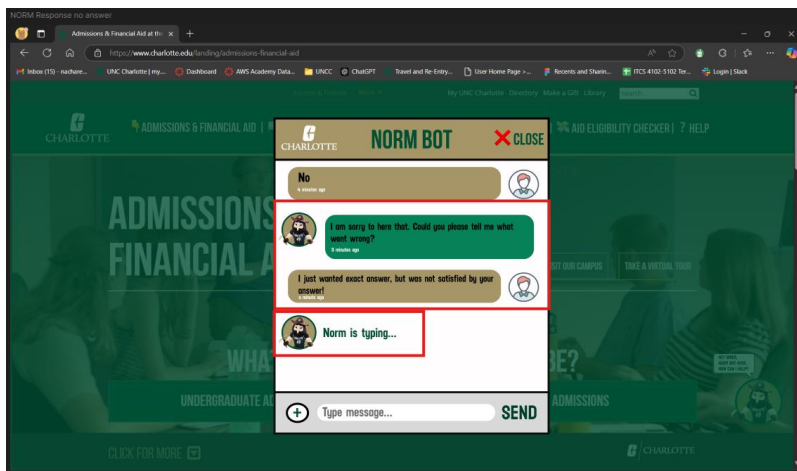




- If you click “no” then the bot will ask what went wrong. Clicking on the “type message” this will take you to the question type.



- Now click on “Norm is typing” This will take you to the response.



- The norm bot apologizes and also mentions to talk to a representative by giving a “Live chat” option, clicking on that will open the Live Chat form. If you press “close” this will close the norm bot window.

The first screenshot shows the NORM BOT window on the UNC Charlotte website. The window has a title bar that says "NORM BOT" and a "CLOSE" button. The bot's message reads: "I'm sorry I couldn't provide the right response earlier, it must have been frustrating. I really want to help. Here's a link to connect with a live representative." Below the message is a "LIVE CHAT" button and a text input field with a "SEND" button.

The second screenshot shows the "Live Chat" window, titled "BOOK A LIVE CHAT APPOINTMENT". It has a "CLOSE" button and a message: "Get all your questions answered by our representative!". The form includes the following fields: "Enter your name:" (with a placeholder "Type your full name here!"), "Enter your age:" (with a placeholder "Type age!"), "Country of Origin:" (with a placeholder "Enter your Country!"), "Enter your email-id:" (with a placeholder "Enter a valid email-id!"), "Give us a bit Information About yourself:" (with a placeholder "Type: Which Semester you are enrolled in and the program and major. Also type your student status (International, Transfer, Alumni)..."), and "Select Date and Time:" (with a placeholder "Select from available Date and Time!"). At the bottom are "BOOK APPOINTMENT!" and "CLEAR FIELD'S" buttons.